ORCHARD PLACE

Ricardo Zheng

CHAPTER ONE

“Seven.”

“What?”

“Table seven.”

The boy holding the gray bus tub stopped between the counter and the kitchen doors. “You said six.”

Natalie folded the rag over once and dragged it along the edge of the table.

“I said seven.”

“I’m pretty sure you said six.”

She looked at him.

He lifted one shoulder.

“Okay. Seven.”

He carried the tub away.

Natalie went back to wiping the table.

The restaurant had been closed for nine minutes. Half the overhead lights were off, leaving the booths along the windows in alternating bands of brightness. Beyond the glass were the parking lot, the side wall of a hotel, and, higher up, the red lights of a plane descending toward O’Hare. Another followed before the first had disappeared.

Someone in the kitchen dropped a pan.

“Leave it,” the manager called.

“I got it,” somebody answered.

Natalie finished the table, pushed the sugar caddy back against the wall, then did the same thing at the next one. Her apron was already untied. One strap dragged behind her until she noticed and stuffed the whole thing into her bag.

Her phone showed eight percent.

She put it in her pocket.

At the booth beside the door, a black phone lay against the vinyl seat.

Natalie stopped.

The screen was dark.

She picked it up and looked through the front windows. A family of four had left that booth less than two minutes earlier. Their minivan was no longer in the space outside.

“Somebody leave that?” the manager asked.

Natalie was already at the door.

Outside, the air was colder than it had looked through the glass.

She crossed the parking lot at a run. At the hotel driveway she stopped and looked both ways. Cars moved along River Road. A shuttle turned in, its white roof lights passing over her face.

No minivan.

When she came back, the manager held out his hand.

“Just leave it here.”

“I know.”

“Then why did you run?”

Natalie handed him the phone.

He put it beneath the register.

Outside, a Pace bus pulled away from the stop across River Road.

She checked hers again.

Seven percent.

“Great.”

“What?”

“Nothing.”

She zipped the phone into the outside pocket of her bag, found one earbud tangled around her keys, untangled neither of them, and went out through the back door.

Owen looked away from the television during the last game.

When he looked back, Ricardo was winning.

“You paused it.”

“No.”

“You did.”

Ricardo put the controller on the coffee table and reached for the last piece of pizza.

“You looked away.”

“Because you paused it.”

That remained Owen’s position.

Ricardo took another bite.

Four empty cans stood beside the television. Someone had folded a paper plate in half and wedged it into another one. The baseball game they had stopped watching an hour earlier was still on mute.

From upstairs, Owen’s mother called, “Who still needs a ride?”

“Nobody,” Owen shouted.

Ricardo’s phone vibrated.

A picture from ten minutes earlier had appeared in the group chat. Ricardo was looking away from the camera. Owen had both hands raised behind his head.

Ricardo typed:

delete this

Owen leaned over.

“No.”

“Come on.”

“No.”

Another copy appeared, cropped around Ricardo’s face.

He put the phone down.

Owen’s mother came halfway down the stairs.

“Ricardo, you need a ride?”

“I’m good.”

“You sure?”

“Yeah.”

She looked toward the window.

“The bus is still running?”

Ricardo looked at Owen.

Owen looked back.

“Probably.”

His phone vibrated again.

Ricardo put it in his pocket and stood.

“Text when you get home,” Owen said.

“Why?”

“My mom said.”

“Okay.”

He took his jacket from the back of a chair.

“You paused it,” Owen said.

Ricardo opened the front door.

“Good night.”

The last message on Yichen’s screen read:

you know what i meant

She locked the phone.

At the corner she unlocked it again.

The messages above were still there.

she didn’t say that

thats what she meant

no thats what she said

same difference

no

There was a gap of four minutes.

Then:

you know what i meant

Yichen opened the text field.

She typed three words.

Deleted them.

Typed one.

Deleted that too.

A Pace bus passed through the intersection before the light changed.

Yichen stayed where she was.

She put the phone in her coat pocket.

At the next corner she took it out again.

No new message.

She locked it and kept walking.

Natalie reached the stop first.

The bus was already visible when she turned onto River Road. She broke into a jog for the last half block and raised one hand.

The driver waited.

She climbed aboard.

“Thanks.”

He nodded toward the reader.

Natalie tapped her card and walked back.

There were perhaps a dozen people on the bus, spread far enough apart that no one needed to sit beside anyone else. She chose the right side, several rows behind the middle doors, put her bag on the seat beside her, then moved it to the floor when another passenger came down the aisle.

A woman sat several rows behind the driver.

She wore a light-colored coat and held a paper grocery bag upright on her knees.

The top of the bag had been folded over twice.

Natalie sat by the window.

Her phone showed six percent.

A message had arrived from the restaurant.

made it?

She typed:

barely

Sent it.

Put the phone down.

Picked it up again.

Opened something else.

Outside, hotel entrances and parking structures slipped past in pieces between roadside signs. A shuttle waited at a curb with its hazard lights on. Two people stood beside rolling suitcases while a third held the rear door open.

At the next red light, the driver lifted a paper cup from beside his seat and drank from it.

The light changed.

The car ahead did not move.

“Come on,” he said.

The car moved.

So did the bus.

Ricardo got on several stops later.

His first tap did nothing.

“Again,” the driver said.

Ricardo tapped the card a second time.

The reader chimed.

“Thanks.”

He walked past Natalie without looking at her and took a seat on the other side of the aisle, one row ahead. His backpack went on the floor with one strap extending into the aisle.

Natalie looked at it.

A minute later she shifted her legs.

“Hey.”

Ricardo turned.

She pointed down.

“Your bag.”

“Oh.”

He pulled it in.

“Sorry.”

Natalie put one earbud in.

It did not play anything.

She took it back out.

Ricardo’s phone lit several times in quick succession. He answered one message and put it face down on his thigh.

The bus stopped.

The woman near the front did not move.

Ricardo glanced up.

Natalie looked toward the doors.

Two people got off.

A man waiting outside stepped forward, saw the route display, and stepped back again.

The doors closed.

The bus continued south.

Yichen boarded a few stops later.

She tapped her card once and walked down the aisle without looking at either of them.

There was something dark and wet on the first seat she approached. She stopped, looked at it, then chose the seat behind Ricardo instead.

Natalie watched her sit down.

Yichen looked back.

Natalie turned to the window.

Yichen’s phone came out almost immediately.

The screen stayed on for a few seconds.

Off.

On again.

Off.

The woman near the front shifted the paper bag farther onto her lap.

At another stop the driver braked harder than expected.

Natalie's bag slid from the seat and across the floor.

Yichen stopped it with one shoe.

"Sorry," Natalie said.

Yichen nudged the bag back.

"Thanks."

Natalie picked it up.

"Didn't hit you, did it?"

"No."

"Okay."

She put the bag between her feet.

Ricardo did not turn around.

A shuttle came across the lane in front of the bus without much warning.

The driver braked.

Natalie caught the seat in front of her.

"Jesus."

Ricardo looked up.

Yichen looked toward the windshield.

The driver said something too low to make out.

For three or four seconds, all three were looking forward.

Then the shuttle turned away.

Ricardo went back to his phone.

Natalie checked hers.

Four percent.

She lowered the brightness and locked the screen.

Yichen stayed turned toward the window.

A plane passed low enough overhead that its sound reached the bus through the glass.

Ricardo put one earbud in.

A few minutes later his head rested against the window.

It dipped once.

Lifted.

Dipped again.

Then stayed there.

The bus turned right.

Yichen watched the intersection disappear behind them.

Natalie looked up a little later.

The road was narrower now. River Road, its parking lots, airport hotels and lit commercial signs had given way to a two-lane street with cars parked along one side.

Nothing else changed.

The driver kept one hand on the wheel.

The woman near the front adjusted the grocery bag.

Natalie watched through the window.

“Is this—”

Yichen looked over.

“What?”

Natalie looked outside again.

“Nothing.”

Ricardo was asleep.

The bus continued.

There were houses first.

Two-story brick buildings with small front steps. A driveway. A blue SUV parked half on the curb. Garbage bins beside a fence.

A man stood outside a building smoking.

Someone walked a dog on the opposite sidewalk.

A television flickered blue behind a second-floor window.

At the next intersection the light was green.

The driver went through.

Natalie leaned toward the aisle and looked toward the front.

“Does this still go to Forest Park?”

The driver gave no sign that he had heard her.

Natalie waited.

Ricardo shifted against the window.

“Hey.”

He opened his eyes.

“What?”

“Forest Park?”

He blinked.

“What about it?”

“This still goes there?”

“Yeah.”

“You sure?”

Ricardo looked briefly through the windshield.

“Pretty sure.”

Yichen turned from the window.

“He didn’t answer your question.”

Natalie looked at her.

“Who?”

“The driver.”

Natalie looked forward.

“Maybe he didn’t hear me.”

“Maybe.”

The bus rolled through another intersection.

Natalie waited a few seconds.

“Do either of you know this area?”

Ricardo looked outside.

“Not really.”

Yichen shook her head.

“Great.”

A porch with three plastic pumpkins passed by.

A pickup truck was parked halfway into a driveway with its hood open. Two people stood beside it, one holding a flashlight while the other leaned over the engine.

At the next corner a woman pushed a shopping cart across the street after the light had changed. The bus waited for her.

She lifted one hand toward the driver without looking up.

The bus moved again.

Ricardo pulled out his earbud.

“I’m Ricardo.”

Natalie looked over.

“Natalie.”

He turned enough to see Yichen behind him.

She said her name.

Ricardo repeated it.

Yichen corrected him.

He tried again.

Natalie tried once.

Yichen gave her a small nod.

Ricardo lifted one hand.

“Close enough.”

“For you.”

He looked back at her.

“Okay. Sorry.”

He said it again.

Yichen nodded.

The bus moved on.

A convenience store occupied one corner. Its OPEN sign was still lit, though the parking lot was empty.

A block farther down, a man dragged a trash bin from the sidewalk toward the side of a house.

Then came the laundromat.

Its windows were brighter than the buildings around it.

The laundromat lights were too white.

Two dryers turned behind the glass. A woman stood at a plastic table folding something beneath a television mounted near the ceiling.

The television changed from a blue screen to a man behind a desk.

Ricardo leaned toward the window.

Natalie watched until the building passed behind them.

Yichen looked back once.

The next block had a narrow house, an empty driveway and a chain-link fence.

The bus stopped at an intersection.

Ricardo looked toward the light.

Red.

His phone vibrated.

He checked it.

Natalie pressed the side button on hers, saw the battery percentage, then put it away.

Yichen watched a cyclist ride past in the opposite direction.

The light changed.

Another house.

A low apartment building.

A fenced side yard with children's plastic toys stacked against a wall.

Then Ricardo laughed.

"Look."

A skeleton sat in an upstairs window.

It was the kind sold in drugstores in October, too white and too thin, with one arm caught awkwardly above its head as though someone had tried to hang it and given up.

Ricardo took out his phone.

The bus moved before the camera focused.

He took the picture anyway.

"Why?" Natalie asked.

Ricardo turned the screen toward her.

She laughed.

He sent it.

A reply came less than a minute later.

lol where are you

Ricardo typed:

idk

He sent that too.

The bus passed a row of parked cars.

One had its rear passenger door open. A man stood beside it fastening a child into a car seat.

Natalie pointed toward Ricardo's phone.

"Send me that."

"It's blurry."

"Still."

He tapped the screen a few times.

Natalie's phone buzzed.

For another block there were only houses.

The bus passed a fire hydrant with most of its paint missing. A porch had a chair tipped onto its side. Somewhere between two buildings a dog barked once, then again.

The driver turned the radio slightly lower.

At the next corner was a narrow storefront under a green awning.

White letters read **KELLER & SONS**.

Half the lights inside were off. There were shelves or racks behind the glass, and farther back a yellow work light burned over a counter.

Natalie looked at the sign.

Ricardo was looking at the opposite side of the street.

Yichen turned as the bus passed.

Another plane crossed above the roofs.

Its sound filled the bus for several seconds.

By the time it faded, they had passed two more storefronts.

One was dark.

The other had a handwritten sign taped inside the door.

The bus stopped.

A man was waiting near the curb.

He wore a dark jacket and held a convenience-store drink in one hand.

He boarded.

Tapped his card.

The reader chimed.

He walked past Natalie, Ricardo and Yichen, took a seat farther back, and put in his earbuds.

The doors closed.

The bus moved again.

Natalie unlocked her phone.

Three percent.

She locked it.

Yichen rested one elbow against the window ledge.

A restaurant on the opposite side was closing. A man inside placed chairs upside down on the tables one by one.

At a driveway, a sedan reversed, stopped, pulled forward, then reversed again.

The driver of the bus watched it.

“Come on.”

The sedan finally straightened.

The bus continued.

Natalie watched the houses.

Ricardo scrolled.

Yichen looked out.

Another bus stop went by on the opposite side of the street. Its shelter had an advertisement with most of one corner peeled away.

A woman carrying two grocery bags walked beneath it.

A porch light came on.

Three teenagers stood around a parked car, one sitting on the hood.

Two blocks later a man came out of a convenience store carrying a plastic bag and crossed behind a parked pickup.

At the next intersection, a car went through ahead of them.

At another, the bus waited behind an SUV whose turn signal had been blinking for nearly a minute.

The SUV finally turned.

The bus moved.

Then it slowed again.

Natalie looked toward the front.

There was a sign near the curb.

“Is this it?”

The woman with the paper bag did not turn around.

“Not yet.”

Natalie looked at her.

“Thanks.”

Yichen looked at the woman.

The bus accelerated again.

The woman stayed seated.

They passed a small brick building with three dark windows and one lit one.

A man stood in the lit window doing dishes.

At a red light, Ricardo opened the map on his phone. He pinched the screen once, moved it, then locked the phone.

The light changed.

The woman shifted the bag against her knees.

They passed another intersection.

Natalie checked her phone.

“We’ve been on this street for a while.”

Ricardo looked up.

“How long?”

“I don’t know.”

She looked at the screen again.

“Ten minutes?”

“Since the turn?”

“I don’t know.”

Ricardo looked through the window.

He stayed looking.

They passed a driveway.

Another intersecting street.

A small parking lot with one pickup truck in it.

He twisted in his seat and looked through the opposite windows.

Then toward the back.

“Wait.”

Natalie looked at him.

“What?”

Ricardo kept watching outside.

“Nothing.”

“Okay.”

A moment later he moved to the empty seat across the aisle so he could see farther forward.

Natalie lifted her bag from between her feet and put it beside her.

Yichen leaned forward to look past Ricardo toward the windshield.

The bus went through another green light.

A delivery van waited at the curb with its rear doors open.

Ricardo looked back again.

Then forward.

By the next intersection the three of them were sitting within a few feet of one another.

The woman at the front picked up her grocery bag.

She held it against her chest and stood.

Natalie looked toward the stop-request strip.

No sound had gone off.

The driver looked in the mirror.

“You sure?”

The woman looked at him.

“Yes.”

The bus stopped.

The doors opened.

She stepped down onto the sidewalk.

The doors closed behind her.

Natalie watched the woman through the window until the bus had passed her.

“Did she know him?”

Yichen was still looking toward the front.

“He asked if she was sure.”

“I know.”

“That’s all I know.”

Natalie looked at her.

Yichen looked back out the window.

The bus continued.

The man in the back still had his earbuds in.

Natalie leaned toward the aisle.

“Does this still go to Forest Park?”

This time the driver answered.

“Yes.”

“Okay.”

Ricardo waited.

“Then what road is this?”

The driver kept driving.

“Hey.”

No answer.

Yichen said, “He heard you.”

Ricardo looked toward the front for another second, then sat back.

Natalie adjusted the strap of her bag.

“Maybe he’s tired.”

Ricardo looked out the window again.

The bus approached another corner.

The driver signaled.

Turned left.

The buildings thinned.

For a short stretch there were fences and darker lots, the edge of something industrial, then trees.

A railway line appeared beyond them.

Ricardo leaned toward the glass.

Natalie watched forward.

The bus crossed under a light.

For several seconds the windows reflected the inside of the bus: seats, overhead bars, Ricardo leaning forward, Yichen behind him, Natalie across the aisle.

Then there were buildings outside again.

The bus turned.

More cars.

A brighter intersection.

A gas station.

Ricardo sat upright.

“Wait.”

Natalie looked over.

“What?”

He pointed through the window.

“I know this road.”

Natalie leaned across to see.

She looked ahead.

“I know this road.”

Yichen shifted toward the aisle.

A pharmacy sign passed above a parking lot. Cars moved steadily through the intersection ahead.

Ricardo sat back.

“Detour.”

“Looks like it,” Natalie said.

Ricardo yawned.

The bus continued south.

Then he turned around.

He looked through the rear window.

Sat forward.

Looked left.

Then right.

“No.”

Natalie looked up from her phone.

“What?”

“That doesn’t make sense.”

“What doesn’t?”

Ricardo pointed behind them.

“That road.”

Natalie turned.

“What about it?”

“It doesn’t go there.”

“Apparently it does.”

“No.”

Yichen looked at him.

“Have you been here before?”

Ricardo stopped.

“No.”

“Then how do you know?”

He looked back through the window.

“Because—”

The bus crossed an intersection.

Ricardo pointed again, but the turn was already behind them.

“That road doesn’t go there.”

Natalie looked outside.

Cars.

Streetlights.

A pharmacy.

A parking lot.

A bus shelter with two people standing beneath it.

“Maybe you were asleep longer than you thought,” she said.

“I wasn’t asleep that long.”

“You were asleep?”

“For like two minutes.”

Yichen looked at him.

“Longer.”

Ricardo turned.

“How do you know?”

“You were asleep.”

He looked at her for a second.

“Right.”

Natalie smiled.

Ricardo looked through the window again.

A stop announcement played.

Someone near the front got off.

At the next light, two cars passed in the other direction.

Several stops later, Natalie pulled her bag onto her lap.

Ricardo looked over.

“This yours?”

“Next one.”

He looked at his phone.

“I’m going back tomorrow.”

Natalie zipped her bag.

“Why?”

“Because that road doesn’t fit.”

“Okay.”

“I’m serious.”

“I know.”

Ricardo unlocked his phone.

“Can I get your number?”

Natalie looked at him.

“Why?”

“I’ll send you the road if I find it.”

She held out her hand.

Ricardo gave her the phone.

She entered her number and handed it back.

He turned toward Yichen.

She shook her head.

“You were there too.”

“So were other people.”

Ricardo glanced around the bus.

Yichen followed his eyes.

“You know what I mean.”

A short silence.

Natalie looked at her.

Yichen closed her eyes for half a second.

Ricardo held out the phone.

Yichen took it.

She entered her number and returned it.

The bus slowed.

Natalie stood.

“Good luck.”

Ricardo looked back toward the window.

“Thanks.”

The doors opened.

Natalie stepped down.

The doors closed.

The bus moved on.

Ricardo got home first.

He did not text Owen.

Instead, he made a group with the two numbers from the bus.

home

Nothing.

He put his phone on the charger.

Nine minutes later:

Natalie: same

Ricardo typed:

im going back tomorrow

Three dots appeared beside Natalie’s name.

Stopped.

Appeared again.

Natalie: why

Ricardo: because that road makes no sense

A minute passed.

Natalie: go to sleep

No answer from Yichen.

Ricardo put the phone face down.

It vibrated once.

He looked.

Yichen: Tell us if you find it.

Ricardo did not reply.

The group went quiet.

CHAPTER TWO

Ricardo came downstairs after ten.

His phone was still plugged into the wall beside his bed.

There were three messages from Owen.

alive

Seven minutes later:

???

Then, sometime after midnight:

my mom says ur rude

Ricardo typed:

tell her sorry

He sent it from the stairs.

A second later:

also you paused it

He put the phone in his pocket.

There was leftover pizza in the refrigerator. He ate one slice standing at the kitchen counter, then took a second one to the table.

His phone came back out.

The group from the bus was still near the top of the screen.

Natalie: go to sleep

Yichen: Tell us if you find it.

Nothing after that.

Ricardo opened the map.

He searched for River Road.

The screen filled with names.

Rosemont.

Schiller Park.

Franklin Park.

The blue line of the Des Plaines River appeared and disappeared as he moved the map. Roads crossed it. Roads ran beside it. Larger roads were drawn thicker. The airport occupied a pale block to the northwest.

He zoomed in.

Smaller streets appeared around River Road.

He moved south.

Stopped.

Moved back north.

The second slice of pizza remained on the plate.

Ricardo pinched the map smaller.

A wider section appeared.

River Road.

Mannheim Road.

Irving Park Road.

Rail lines.

I-294.

He moved the map again.

Then back.

He locked the phone.

Picked up the pizza.

Unlocked the phone before taking another bite.

He opened directions from Rosemont toward Forest Park.

A blue route appeared.

Ricardo changed the starting point.

The route moved.

He changed it again.

Moved the map.

Zoomed in.

Zoomed out.

The pizza went back onto the plate.

A few minutes later he opened the group chat.

Typed:

what road did we turn on

He looked at the message.

Deleted it.

He opened the map again.

* * *

By noon, two screenshots were in his camera roll.

One showed River Road and the streets around it.

The other was wider and included Mannheim, the rail lines and part of the airport.

Ricardo switched between them.

Then back to the map.

He put the phone on the bathroom counter while the shower ran.

When he came back to it, the screen had gone dark.

He dried one hand on a towel and turned it on.

The map was still open.

Ricardo stood there for several seconds.

Then he zoomed out until River Road and Mannheim were both visible again.

He moved the map north.

Then south.

Locked the screen.

The shower continued running.

* * *

He left the house a little after noon.

This time he took both earbuds.

Neither went in.

On the bus, Ricardo sat near the middle and kept his phone in his hand.

Parking lots.

Low brick buildings.

Gas stations.

A strip mall.

Hotel signs farther north.

Planes lowering beyond rooftops.

At one stop, a man loaded a folded stroller through the front door. At another, two women got on carrying shopping bags.

Ricardo looked through the window.

Then at the map.

Then through the window again.

The bus stopped at River Road.

He got off.

The bus pulled away.

Traffic moved behind him.

Across the road was a parking lot bordered by a chain-link fence. A delivery truck stood with its rear door open. Two men were moving boxes onto a cart.

Ricardo turned once in a full circle.

Then he checked the map.

He walked south.

At the next intersection he stopped.

Checked the map.

Crossed.

A plane passed over.

He kept walking.

At the first side street, Ricardo stopped again.

Checked the map.

Turned into it.

Houses appeared almost immediately.

Brick.

Small lawns.

Cars in driveways.

A basketball hoop leaned over one garage.

He walked for several minutes.

The road curved.

Then ended at another street.

Ricardo stopped.

Checked the map.

Turned around.

On the way back, a woman was dragging a recycling bin toward the curb.

He passed her.

At River Road he crossed again and kept south.

Another side street.

He went in.

This one had a laundromat.

Ricardo stopped.

It occupied the end of a small commercial strip between a nail salon and a store with paper signs taped across its windows.

The laundromat sign was red.

The windows were wide.

Inside, several machines turned.

Ricardo took out his phone.

He stood across the street looking at it.

A car passed between him and the laundromat.

Then another.

He crossed.

The door opened when someone came out carrying a blue plastic basket.

Ricardo held it for her.

“Thanks.”

“Yeah.”

He looked through the windows.

There was a television mounted in one corner.

A row of plastic chairs.

Six large dryers against the back wall.

He took a picture.

Then another.

The woman with the basket put it into the back seat of a car and drove away.

Ricardo opened the picture from the night before.

The skeleton filled most of it.

The bus window reflected the dark interior over the buildings behind it.

He enlarged the left edge.

Blur.

The right edge.

More blur.

He went back to the photo of the laundromat.

Then the map.

The street beside it continued west.

Ricardo walked.

For two blocks there were houses on both sides.

Parked cars along one curb.

Small front steps.

At the third block, the road bent south.

Ricardo stopped.

Ahead, the houses continued.

He checked the map.

The blue location dot sat on the street.

He walked farther.

The road came out onto another road.

Ricardo stood at the corner.

Looked left.

Looked right.

Then back at the street he had just used.

He checked the map once more.

The street connected at both ends.

Ricardo walked back to River Road.

* * *

The next side street lasted less than three blocks.

Houses gave way to a fenced lot.

Beyond the fence were stacked pallets, two trailers and the side of a warehouse.

A sign on the gate read:

NO TRESPASSING

Ricardo walked to the next corner.

The fence continued around the property.

The road on the map continued on the other side.

He went back.

* * *

At one twenty-three, Ricardo sent the first message to the group.

where exactly did you get on

No answer.

He kept walking.

A minute later:

Natalie: why

Ricardo typed:

just tell me

Three dots appeared.

Stopped.

Appeared again.

Natalie: near work

Ricardo stopped at a crosswalk.

where

Natalie sent the name of the restaurant.

Ricardo searched it.

The result appeared farther north.

He looked at the streets between the restaurant and River Road.

The light changed.

Someone behind him crossed.

Ricardo stayed on the curb.

He typed:

and yichen

Nothing.

The light changed again.

He crossed.

* * *

The third road was narrower than the others.

For half a block there were houses.

Then garages.

Then the backs of commercial buildings.

Ricardo followed it until a rail line appeared ahead.

The road ended before the tracks.

A gravel strip ran beside them.

There was no crossing.

Ricardo stood behind a low metal barrier.

A freight train was visible in the distance, moving slowly behind a row of utility poles.

He took out his phone.

The map showed the rail line.

He moved west.

The next crossing was several blocks away.

He moved east.

Another crossing.

Neither was on the road in front of him.

A train horn sounded.

Ricardo locked his phone.

The freight cars moved past behind the barrier.

One after another.

When the last car had gone, he could see through to the other side.

Warehouses.

A parking lot.

Another fence.

No continuation.

Ricardo turned around.

* * *

Yichen answered while he was walking back.

where i got on?

yes

She sent an intersection.

Ricardo searched it.

Then:

Natalie: are you actually there

yes

Natalie: why

Ricardo did not answer.

He searched Yichen’s intersection again.

Then Natalie’s restaurant.

Then the stop where he had gotten on.

All three were along River Road.

He opened directions toward Forest Park again.

The route ran south.

Ricardo closed it.

He opened satellite view.

Buildings became roofs.

Parking lots became rectangles.

Rail lines sharpened.

The river darkened.

He moved the screen west.

Then east.

He stopped under an overpass.

Cars passed overhead.

The phone lost the satellite image for a moment and showed gray squares.

Ricardo waited.

The image loaded.

He moved it again.

* * *

He reached a gas station sometime after two.

Across the intersection was a pharmacy.

It was the road Ricardo and Natalie had recognized after the detour.

Cars moved steadily through the light.

Ricardo stood outside the gas station and looked down the road.

Then he walked to the corner.

Turned around.

Looked back the way the bus had come.

The street behind him led toward industrial buildings and the rail line.

He started walking.

At the first turn, he checked the map.

At the second, he checked it again.

The third road ran beside a fenced property.

Ricardo followed it.

It narrowed.

Then curved.

Then came back out two blocks south.

He returned.

Tried the road before it.

That one reached the tracks.

No crossing.

He went north.

Another street ended behind a warehouse.

He went south.

A service road turned toward the highway and stopped at a gate.

Ricardo stood in front of it.

Beyond the gate, cars moved quickly on the other side of a barrier.

He checked the map.

I-294 cut across the screen.

He moved north.

The tollway continued.

South.

Continued.

There were crossings.

None nearby.

A plane passed overhead.

Ricardo watched it until it disappeared behind the buildings.

Then he looked back at the map.

* * *

At two thirty-seven, Natalie sent:

did you find it

Ricardo did not answer.

Yichen sent:

what are you looking for

He put the phone away.

He walked east.

A while later he reached River Road again.

Across from him was a building he had already passed.

A white van stood in the parking lot.

Someone had closed its rear doors.

Ricardo looked north.

Then south.

He crossed.

The first street he had tried was three blocks away.

He walked back to it.

Turned west again.

Same houses.

Same basketball hoop.

Same curve.

Same road at the other end.

He stopped at the corner.

A child rode past on a bicycle.

Ricardo took out his phone.

Opened the photo of the skeleton.

Zoomed in until the image broke into squares.

A white shape.

A dark window.

The black reflection of the bus interior.

His own hand faintly visible near the bottom.

He went back to the map.

Search:

laundromat River Road

The screen filled with results.

He locked the phone.

* * *

The bus stop on River Road had a bench.

Ricardo sat.

A bus came north.

The number on the front was different.

It stopped anyway.

Two people got off.

The doors closed.

Ricardo stayed on the bench.

He opened the wider screenshot from home.

River Road on one side.

Mannheim farther west.

The rail line.

The tollway.

Industrial blocks.

He switched back to the map.

Moved north.

South.

West.

Back to River Road.

A Pace bus came into view.

Ricardo stood.

It stopped.

He did not get on.

The driver looked at him through the open doors.

“You getting on?”

Ricardo looked down at the phone.

“No.”

The doors closed.

The bus left.

He sat again.

* * *

At three twelve, Ricardo opened the group.

did either of you see what street we turned on

Natalie answered first.

not the name

Then:

i told you i wasnt looking

Yichen: I saw the turn

Ricardo typed:

where

A pause.

Yichen: River Road

Ricardo: where on river road

Longer pause.

Yichen: I don’t know

Ricardo looked at the message.

Natalie: you were asleep

Ricardo: i know

Natalie: then how are you supposed to know where it was

He did not answer.

Yichen: That’s what I was asking.

Ricardo locked the phone.

The next bus arrived a few minutes later.

This time he got on.

* * *

He sat by the window.

The bus moved north along River Road.

Ricardo kept the map open.

At each side street he looked up.

Then down.

Up.

Down.

One intersection.

Another.

Ainslie.

Another.

Winona.

The names passed on signs.

At one point the bus stopped behind a line of cars.

Ricardo leaned toward the window.

Across the road was a low brick building.

Behind it, the rail line.

Beyond that, roofs.

The bus moved.

A few blocks later the view opened enough to show the highway.

He looked at the map.

River Road on one side.

Mannheim farther west.

The rail line between parts of them.

Industrial property.

The tollway.

Airport infrastructure farther north.

The bus stopped.

A woman got on carrying two grocery bags.

She sat near the front.

Ricardo looked back at the map.

He moved it west.

The tracks.

North.

Airport roads.

South.

The tollway.

Back east.

River Road.

The bus continued.

His phone buzzed.

Natalie: so?

Ricardo did not type.

The bus passed the street with the laundromat.

Then the fenced property.

Then the road leading toward the tracks.

He watched each one disappear behind them.

Yichen: Did you find anything?

Ricardo looked through the window.

The next intersection came.

Then another.

He opened the group.

Typed three words.

Deleted them.

Typed again.

Natalie’s typing indicator appeared before he sent anything.

Stopped.

Ricardo looked at the map one last time.

River Road.

Mannheim.

The tracks.

The tollway.

The airport.

He sent:

there’s nowhere for it to be

CHAPTER THREE

Natalie answered fourteen minutes after Ricardo's last message.

what does that mean

Ricardo replied:

there isnt a road there

Yichen:

You don't know where we turned.

Ricardo:

i know

Natalie:

you were asleep

Ricardo: not the whole time

A minute passed.

Then Yichen:

At the turn.

Ricardo did not answer.

The group stayed quiet.

Then:

Ricardo: what time did you get on

Natalie:

idk

Ricardo: around what time

Natalie: 10:30 maybe

Ricardo: can you check

Three dots appeared beside Natalie's name.

Stopped.

Appeared again.

Natalie: check what

Ricardo: your phone

Natalie: why

Ricardo: because if i know when you got on

Another message followed.

and when i got on

Yichen:

You still won’t know where we turned.

Ricardo: i know

Nothing came from Natalie.

A few minutes passed.

Ricardo sent:

?

No answer.

Then:

Natalie: wait

A screenshot appeared.

Most of it was a text conversation.

Near the bottom:

made it?

barely

The time above the exchange read 10:28 PM.

Natalie:

i was already on when i sent that

Ricardo:

10:28

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: ok

Natalie:

why is that useful

Yichen:

It isn’t yet.

No one answered that.

A little later Ricardo sent:

was the woman already there when you got on

Natalie:

yes

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo: did either of you see her get on

Natalie:

no

Yichen:

No.

Ricardo: did the driver know her

There was a pause.

Natalie:

how would i know

Then:

Ricardo: yichen

Yichen:

I don’t know.

Ricardo: you were looking

Yichen: He looked in the mirror.

Ricardo: at her?

The typing indicator appeared beside Yichen’s name.

Stopped.

Appeared again.

Yichen: I don’t know.

Natalie:

she said “Not yet.”

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

and he asked if she was sure

Yichen:

He did.

Ricardo:

thats weird

A pause.

Yichen:

Maybe.

The group went quiet again.

At eleven seventeen Ricardo sent:

tomorrow

Natalie:

what about tomorrow

Ricardo: come see it

Natalie: you already did

Ricardo: i know

Yichen:

That isn’t an explanation.

Ricardo sent an intersection.

River Rd & Lawrence

Then:

2

Natalie:

why

Ricardo: because if im wrong you can tell me

A pause.

Natalie:

and if youre right

Ricardo:

then you can tell me that too

Nobody answered for several minutes.

Then:

Natalie: fine

Yichen did not respond.

At eleven forty-two:

Ricardo: yichen

Nothing.

Two minutes later:

Yichen: Fine.

* * *

Ricardo was already at River Road and Lawrence when Natalie arrived.

He was standing beside the bus shelter with a bottle of Coke in one hand and his phone in the other.

Natalie stopped beside the shelter.

“You really came back yesterday?”

“Yes.”

She looked down River Road.

Then at him.

“Why?”

“Because I said I would.”

A bus passed without stopping.

Natalie watched it go.

“Okay.”

Ricardo put his phone in his pocket.

They waited.

A plane crossed low enough that both of them looked up.

Yichen arrived several minutes later.

She walked toward them from Lawrence with one hand holding the strap of a shoulder bag.

Ricardo lifted one hand.

“Hi.”

“Hi.”

Natalie said, “Hey.”

Yichen nodded.

Nobody said anything for a few seconds.

Then Yichen looked at Ricardo.

“Where?”

He pointed south.

They started walking.

* * *

For the first few blocks, nobody said much.

Traffic moved beside them on River Road.

A truck passed close enough that Natalie stepped farther from the curb.

Ricardo checked his phone.

Yichen looked at the intersections as they passed.

At Eastwood, Natalie stopped.

Ricardo took two more steps before turning.

“What?”

Natalie looked west.

“Could it have been here?”

Ricardo looked down Eastwood.

“I don’t think so.”

“That’s different from no.”

“I walked around here yesterday.”

Natalie looked at him.

“You were asleep at the turn.”

“I know.”

Yichen stood beside the street sign.

Ricardo looked at her.

“You saw it.”

“Yes.”

“Was it here?”

Yichen looked down Eastwood.

Then back along River Road.

“I don’t know.”

Natalie crossed first.

The other two followed.

* * *

Past the first block, Eastwood became residential.

Small houses stood close together on narrow lots.

Cars filled some of the driveways.

At Kolze, Ricardo stopped and looked back toward River Road.

Natalie looked at him.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

They crossed.

At Grace, Yichen stopped.

Ricardo turned.

“What?”

“I don’t remember this intersection.”

Natalie looked around.

“Do you remember there not being one?”

Yichen shook her head.

“No.”

They kept walking.

At Wesley Terrace, Ricardo checked the map.

Eastwood continued west.

He locked the phone.

They turned back.

* * *

They returned to River Road and continued south.

At Moore Lane, Ricardo slowed.

Natalie looked at him.

“What?”

He looked west.

Then at the street sign.

“Maybe.”

Yichen looked down the road.

Natalie waited.

Ricardo shook his head.

They kept walking.

Montrose was next.

This time Yichen stopped first.

Ricardo and Natalie stopped with her.

Yichen looked west.

Natalie said, “What?”

Yichen did not answer immediately.

Then:

“This is closer.”

Ricardo looked at the street.

“To what?”

She looked at him.

“The street.”

He crossed.

Natalie followed.

Yichen came after them.

* * *

Near the corner was a low building with several storefront windows.

One carried a red **LAUNDROMAT** sign.

Ricardo stopped.

Natalie stopped beside him.

Yichen looked through the window.

Machines turned inside.

A woman stood beside a rolling basket.

Natalie said, “I don’t think it looked like this.”

Ricardo looked through the glass.

“What was different?”

Natalie looked again.

“I don’t know.”

Yichen said, “There was someone inside.”

Natalie glanced at her.

“There’s someone inside.”

“I know.”

Traffic moved behind them on River Road.

Nobody went inside.

They continued west.

The storefronts gave way to houses.

The street stayed straight.

At Kolze, a car crossed in front of them.

They waited.

Then crossed.

At Grace, Yichen stopped again.

Ricardo looked back.

“What?”

She pointed at the intersection.

“I don’t remember this.”

Natalie looked around.

“Do you remember there not being one?”

Yichen lowered her hand.

“No.”

Ricardo checked the map.

Montrose continued west.

Natalie looked at the screen.

“So?”

Ricardo locked it.

“So nothing.”

They stood there for a moment.

Then walked back toward River Road.

* * *

They were halfway back when Natalie said, “Maybe you slept longer.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“We did this already.”

“You said two minutes.”

“I said like two.”

Yichen said, “It was longer.”

“How long?”

“I don’t know.”

Ricardo looked at Natalie.

She shook her head.

“Don’t look at me.”

“You checked last night.”

“That was a message.”

“So?”

“So I can check a message.”

They kept walking.

Ricardo said, “Did you see when I fell asleep?”

Natalie shook her head.

He looked at Yichen.

“No,” she said.

“When I woke up?”

“Yes.”

“When?”

Yichen looked at him.

“When you woke up.”

Ricardo stopped.

Natalie walked several more steps.

Then she turned.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

He caught up.

When they reached River Road, Ricardo looked north.

Then south.

Across the road, a Pace bus moved through the intersection and continued without stopping.

Natalie said, “What if we’re wrong about where we came out?”

Ricardo looked at her.

“We knew that road.”

“You knew it.”

“You did too.”

Natalie waited.

Ricardo looked at Yichen.

Yichen said, “I knew where we were after.”

Ricardo frowned.

“That’s what I mean.”

“No.”

“What’s the difference?”

Yichen looked down River Road.

“I don’t know.”

Natalie said, “Good.”

Nobody answered.

* * *

They walked north again.

At Montrose, Yichen looked at the sign.

At Moore, Ricardo looked west.

At Eastwood, Natalie stopped.

Ricardo turned.

“What?”

Natalie looked down the street.

“I still think it was around here.”

“You said it could be.”

“Yes.”

“That’s the same thing?”

Natalie looked at him.

“No.”

Yichen looked back south.

“I thought it was farther down.”

Ricardo looked from one of them to the other.

“So where?”

Natalie said nothing.

Yichen said nothing.

A car went past.

Ricardo looked at the map on his phone.

Then put it away.

“I’m hungry.”

Natalie looked toward the bus stop.

“Good.”

“There’s a McDonald’s up by Rosemont.”

Yichen looked north.

“We just walked down here.”

“I know.”

Natalie started toward the shelter.

“I’m not walking back.”

Nobody argued.

* * *

The next northbound bus had several empty seats.

Natalie boarded first.

Yichen followed.

Ricardo went last.

The reader chimed three times.

They sat in different rows.

Natalie by the window.

Yichen across the aisle one row behind her.

Ricardo farther back.

The bus stayed on River Road.

Eastwood passed.

Then Lawrence.

At one stop two people got off.

A man carrying a grocery bag got on.

The doors closed.

The bus continued.

Nobody mentioned Friday night.

A few minutes later Ricardo stood.

Natalie looked back.

He pointed toward the front.

They got off near the McDonald’s.

The bus continued north without them.

* * *

The McDonald’s was busy enough that they had to wait for a table.

Ricardo bought fries and another Coke.

Natalie bought fries.

Yichen bought coffee.

They stood beside a wall until a family left.

Then they sat near the window.

Cars moved along River Road outside.

For a while, the bus did not come up.

Natalie asked Yichen what school she went to.

Yichen answered.

Then asked Natalie the same question.

Natalie told her.

Ricardo ate.

Nobody asked him anything.

After a while he looked at both of them.

Natalie was opening a packet of ketchup.

Yichen had both hands around the coffee cup.

Ricardo looked back at his fries.

A child at the next table dropped a straw wrapper.

His father pointed toward it.

The child climbed down, picked it up, and put it in the trash.

A worker wiped a table near the door.

Natalie ate another fry.

Ricardo reached into his backpack.

He took out a sheet of printer paper folded in quarters.

Natalie looked at it.

“You printed it?”

“My phone keeps moving when I zoom.”

He unfolded the page.

A map of River Road covered most of it.

The top edge had been cut off by the printer.

Part of Mannheim was visible to the west.

Several streets were labeled.

Lawrence.

Eastwood.

Moore.

Montrose.

Irving Park.

Nothing had been drawn on it.

Ricardo pushed his tray aside and flattened the paper with one hand.

“Show me where you think we turned.”

Natalie looked at him.

“You first.”

“Why?”

“You asked.”

Ricardo put one finger on the map.

Between Eastwood and Moore.

Natalie leaned closer.

“No.”

“You haven’t even—”

“It wasn’t there.”

“Then where?”

She moved his hand and put one finger near Eastwood.

Ricardo looked at it.

“That’s barely different.”

“It’s different.”

Yichen pulled the map slightly toward herself.

Natalie moved her cup.

Yichen followed River Road with one finger.

Past Eastwood.

Past Moore.

She stopped near Montrose.

Ricardo looked at her.

“There?”

Yichen moved her finger a little.

“Maybe.”

Natalie looked at the three places.

Ricardo put his finger back between Eastwood and Moore.

Natalie’s remained near Eastwood.

Yichen’s rested farther south.

Natalie looked at Ricardo.

“You said there was nowhere for it to be.”

“There isn’t.”

She pointed to his finger.

Then hers.

Then Yichen’s.

“Which turn are you talking about?”

CHAPTER FOUR

On Sunday night, Ricardo sent:

if it was montrose then we wouldve crossed irving park before we came out

Natalie replied:

if it was montrose

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: you said it wasnt montrose

There was no answer for a while.

Then:

Ricardo: i said i dont think it was

Yichen: You said Eastwood.

Ricardo: between Eastwood and Moore

Yichen: Okay.

Ricardo: thats different

Natalie: from eastwood? barely

Ricardo: from montrose yes

Yichen: I said maybe.

Ricardo did not reply.

Natalie sent:

so none of us know

Three dots appeared beside Ricardo’s name.

Stopped.

Appeared again.

Then:

i know what it wasnt

Natalie: apparently not

Nothing else came that night.

* * *

On Monday afternoon, Ricardo was at Owen’s house again.

Owen sat on the floor in front of the television.

Ricardo was on the couch with his phone.

The game was paused.

Owen looked back.

“You’re doing it again.”

Ricardo looked up.

“What?”

“The bus thing.”

Ricardo locked his phone.

“No.”

“You are literally looking at a map.”

“It’s Google.”

“That’s a map.”

Ricardo put the phone beside him.

Owen waited.

Ricardo picked up the controller.

Owen unpaused the game.

Thirty seconds later Ricardo’s phone vibrated.

He looked at it.

Owen paused the game again.

“I didn’t ask you to do that.”

“You were going to.”

Natalie had sent a message to the group.

there couldve just been a detour

Ricardo: for what

Natalie: construction

Ricardo: where

Natalie: i dont know

Ricardo: then how does that help

Natalie: because roads have construction

Owen leaned over the back of the couch.

“Is that one of the bus people?”

Ricardo moved the phone away.

“Yes.”

“You’re still talking about it?”

“Apparently.”

Owen turned back around.

Ricardo typed:

a detour still has to go somewhere

Natalie: yes ricardo usually roads go somewhere

He read the message.

Owen looked over again.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

Ricardo typed:

thats not what i mean

Yichen replied:

It could have been a service road.

Ricardo: for that long?

Yichen: How long?

Ricardo did not answer.

Natalie: exactly

Ricardo: it was long

Yichen: Yes.

Ricardo: how long

There was a pause.

Yichen: I don’t know.

Natalie: neither do i

Ricardo: you checked

Natalie: i checked when i got on

not how long anything took

Ricardo put the phone down.

Owen unpaused the game.

They played until Ricardo's phone vibrated again.

Neither of them paused.

* * *

At 8:46 that evening, Ricardo opened the group again.

Yichen: Also you were asleep.

Ricardo replied:

we already did this

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: neither of you knows how long either

Natalie: exactly

Ricardo did not answer.

* * *

On Tuesday morning, Natalie carried coffee to a booth near the diner window.

A man moved his newspaper to make room for the cup.

"Thanks."

"Sure."

At another table, two children were arguing over a packet of syrup.

Their mother took it from both of them and put it beside her plate.

Natalie cleared an empty table.

Someone at the counter asked for ketchup.

She brought it over.

Her phone stayed in the pocket of her apron until her break.

There were four new messages in the group.

Ricardo: i looked for construction

theres road work everywhere around there

A minute later:

which doesnt help

Yichen: No.

Natalie: congratulations

Ricardo: but there were detours

Natalie: also congratulations

Ricardo: none that match

Natalie: match what

There had been no answer.

Natalie read the exchange again.

Then typed:

thats kind of the problem

Ricardo replied almost immediately.

what is

Natalie: you dont know what youre matching

No message followed before her break ended.

Natalie put the phone away.

* * *

That afternoon, Ricardo sent:

what about the woman

Natalie: what about her

Ricardo: not yet

Yichen replied several minutes later.

You asked her, “Is this it?”

Natalie: maybe she heard me ask about Forest Park

Yichen: Maybe.

Ricardo: still weird

* * *

That evening, Yichen walked home from school with her phone in one hand.

At a corner she stopped for a red light.

A new message appeared.

Ricardo: maybe we came out somewhere else

Yichen read it.

Natalie replied before the light changed.

yes

Ricardo: you said the gas station

Natalie: i said we were near it

Ricardo: same thing

Yichen: Not necessarily.

Ricardo: how far away could we have been

Natalie: dont know

Ricardo: of course

The light changed.

Yichen crossed.

Nothing else appeared before she reached the next block.

* * *

On Wednesday, the group stayed quiet through the morning.

At 3:11 PM, Yichen sent:

Maybe we didn’t turn once.

Ricardo: what

Yichen: Maybe there were several turns.

Natalie: obviously there were several turns

Yichen: I mean maybe we’re talking about different ones.

There was a pause.

Ricardo: we were on the same road

Natalie: were we

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: how do you know

Ricardo: because i remember the houses

Natalie: which houses

No answer.

A minute later:

Ricardo: the houses

Natalie: excellent

Yichen: There were houses on more than one street.

Ricardo: i know

Natalie: so

Ricardo: so what

Natalie: so maybe thats why we pointed at three different places

Ricardo: that doesnt make the road fit

Yichen: Maybe it wasn't one road.

The group went quiet.

Five minutes passed.

Then Ricardo:

thats stupid

Natalie: good argument

Another minute.

Ricardo: i mean we wouldve noticed turning

Natalie: you were asleep for some of it

Ricardo: not all of it

Yichen: No.

Ricardo: and you both saw the street

Natalie: parts of it

Nothing came from Ricardo.

After a while, Natalie sent:

i have homework

Yichen: Same.

The group went quiet again.

* * *

At 9:17 PM, Ricardo sent:

so what are we saying

Natalie: about what

Ricardo: friday

Natalie: i thought we just spent four days saying it

Ricardo: say it then

There was no answer.

Ricardo: ?

Natalie: you probably slept longer than you think

A second message appeared.

there was probably a detour

Then:

we dont actually know where we turned

A final message:

and we probably mixed up some roads after

Ricardo: probably

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: thats it

Natalie: unless you have something better

Ricardo did not answer.

Yichen: Maybe.

Ricardo: theres still stuff that doesnt fit

Natalie: like

Three dots appeared beside Ricardo’s name.

They stayed for several seconds.

Disappeared.

Returned.

Disappeared again.

Nothing came.

Natalie: ?

The typing indicator appeared once more.

Then:

i dont know

Natalie answered:

then thats probably it

No one sent anything for a minute.

Then Yichen:

Good.

Ricardo did not reply.

* * *

On Thursday, Natalie worked after school.

A family of four took the booth beside the window.

One child ordered pancakes for dinner.

The other wanted fries and changed his mind after they arrived.

A man at the counter complained that his coffee was cold.

Natalie replaced it.

Later, the manager asked her to refill the napkin holders.

She carried a stack of clean glasses from the kitchen.

Someone dropped a fork.

Natalie brought another one.

Her phone stayed in her bag.

* * *

Ricardo went to Owen’s house.

They finished the game they had started on Monday.

Owen won.

Ricardo said the controller had stuck.

Owen handed him the other controller.

They played again.

Ricardo lost again.

“You want the broken one back?” Owen asked.

Ricardo threw a cushion at him.

Owen caught it.

Neither of them mentioned the bus.

* * *

Yichen stopped at a convenience store on the way home.

She bought a bottle of water and a pack of gum.

Outside, a bus went through the intersection.

She watched it pass.

Then she started walking again.

* * *

The group had no new messages on Thursday.

On Friday afternoon, Ricardo sent Owen a photograph of a game case from a store.

Owen replied:

already have it

Ricardo: no you dont

Owen: yes i do

Ricardo: since when

Owen sent a photograph.

Ricardo replied:

oh

The bus group stayed farther down the screen.

He did not open it.

* * *

Natalie worked Friday night.

Near closing, a customer sat down at a section of counter Natalie had already wiped.

He ordered pie.

She brought it.

At another table, someone laughed loudly enough that two people turned around.

Outside, traffic moved past the window.

A little later, Natalie carried a trash bag through the back door.

When she came back, the manager was locking one side of the front entrance.

* * *

There were no new messages in the group on Friday.

None on Saturday.

CHAPTER FIVE

On Sunday afternoon, Owen sent Ricardo a message.

score pic

Ricardo was at his desk.

He opened his camera roll.

There were photographs from the week before.

A television screen.

A game case.

One picture of the floor.

Another in which most of the lens had been covered by a finger.

Then the skeleton.

Ricardo stopped scrolling.

The photograph filled the screen.

The skeleton sat in the upstairs window with one arm caught above its head.

The picture was blurry even before he enlarged it.

The window reflected the inside of the bus over everything behind it. A pale bar from an overhead light crossed the glass. The edge of a seat appeared over the wall of the house.

Ricardo enlarged the photograph.

The skeleton became blocks.

He moved the image left.

Dark roof.

Reflection.

A patch of sky.

Something pale behind the roofline.

He moved farther.

The shape disappeared beneath the edge of the screen.

Back.

A narrow white section rose above the house.

At the top it widened.

There was something darker across it.

Ricardo stared at the screen.

He reduced the picture.

Enlarged it again.

The shape was still there.

His phone vibrated.

Owen: hello

Ricardo ignored it.

He opened his browser.

Typed:

schiller park water tower

Images loaded.

He opened one.

A white tower rose above a neighborhood.

The top was wider than the column beneath it.

Ricardo switched back to the skeleton photograph.

Then to the search result.

Back.

The thing behind the roof was too blurred to read.

He took a screenshot anyway.

The group from the bus was farther down the screen now.

There had been no new message since Wednesday.

Ricardo opened it.

The last thing there was still:

Yichen: Good.

He typed:

found something

Sent.

Nothing happened.

Ricardo attached the skeleton photograph.

Then the crop.

He waited.

Owen sent:

ricardo

Ricardo turned the phone face down.

A minute later it vibrated.

Natalie: what am i looking at

Ricardo picked it up.

behind the house

Natalie: what

Ricardo: white thing

There was a pause.

Then:

Natalie: the pole?

Ricardo: not a pole

He sent the screenshot from the search result.

Natalie: oh

Another message:

water tower?

Ricardo: i think

Yichen appeared in the group.

Maybe.

Ricardo: look at the top

Natalie: i am

Ricardo: its the same shape

Yichen: It could be.

Ricardo sent a map screenshot with the water tower marked.

Natalie: where is that

Ricardo: schiller park

Natalie: i know that

where

Ricardo moved the map.

Sent another screenshot.

Natalie: okay

Ricardo: okay what

Natalie: if thats actually it

Yichen: Then the photo was taken somewhere near it.

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: somewhere

Ricardo: yes natalie

Natalie: just checking

Ricardo enlarged the photograph again.

The white shape was still barely a shape.

He sent:

thats not somewhere random

Natalie did not answer.

Yichen: No.

A few seconds later:

But we already thought we were in Schiller Park.

Ricardo: we thought we were around there

Yichen: Yes.

Ricardo: this is actually in the picture

Natalie: if its the tower

Ricardo stared at the message.

Then:

its the tower

Yichen: Probably.

Ricardo did not reply.

* * *

Seven minutes later Natalie sent:

wait

Nothing followed.

Ricardo: what

No answer.

He opened the photograph again.

Tapped the information icon.

The date appeared.

Under it:

10:51 PM

He was still looking at the screen when Natalie sent a screenshot.

It was their message thread from Friday night.

The skeleton photograph appeared in the middle.

Above it:

10:52 PM

Natalie: you sent it to me at 10:52

Ricardo: photo says 10:51

Natalie: okay

Another message:

10:51 then

Ricardo: thats when i took it

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: and you were already on at 10:28

There was no answer for several seconds.

Then Natalie sent another screenshot.

The same one she had sent the previous Sunday.

Near the bottom:

made it?

barely

Above it:

10:28 PM

Yichen: Right.

Ricardo: so 23 minutes

Natalie: between me already being on and the picture

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: not between the turn and the picture

Ricardo: i know

Natalie: okay

Ricardo: but 23 minutes

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: and you got on before 10:28

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: and i got on after you

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: and yichen after me

Yichen: Yes.

Ricardo: so

Natalie: so what

Ricardo typed.

Stopped.

Typed again.

i dont know yet

Natalie: good

Ricardo: why is everyone saying good now

No one answered.

* * *

The printed map from McDonald's was still folded in Ricardo's backpack.

He took it out.

The folds crossed River Road in four places.

Lawrence.

Eastwood.

Moore.

Montrose.

Irving Park.

Nothing had been drawn on it.

Ricardo flattened the sheet with both hands.

It did not stay flat.

He put his phone on one corner and a calculator on another.

The water tower was not labeled on the printout.

He found it on his phone.

Moved between the screen and the paper.

Then made a small circle on the map.

He added a question mark beside it.

Ricardo looked at the circle.

Then put his pen near River Road.

The first line began between Eastwood and Moore.

It went west.

Curved down.

He stopped at the railway.

Ricardo checked the phone.

The railway was exactly where the printed map said it was.

He drew a line through the route.

Started again.

This one began farther south.

It bent around the railway and continued toward the circle.

Then it had to turn north to reach it.

Ricardo followed the streets on his phone.

One ended.

Another became an industrial access road.

The third continued but carried the line farther west than the three places they had pointed to on Sunday.

He stopped drawing.

His phone vibrated.

Natalie: are you doing the map thing again

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: of course

He took a photograph of the paper.

Sent it.

Natalie: what happened to it

Ricardo: nothing

Natalie: there are lines all over it

Ricardo: thats the route

Yichen: Which one?

Ricardo looked down.

There were two crossed-out lines and part of a third.

Ricardo: none yet

Natalie: excellent

Ricardo drew again.

The third route began close to Montrose.

It went west.

Turned twice.

Passed south of the circle he had drawn for the tower.

Then came back east toward River Road.

It looked possible until Ricardo checked the distance.

He wrote:

S

near the point where the skeleton photograph belonged.

Then, near the beginning of the route:

10:30?

He took another picture.

Natalie replied almost immediately.

no

Ricardo: what

Natalie: 10:30

Ricardo: around then

Natalie: around what

Ricardo: when we turned

Natalie: we dont know when we turned

Ricardo: its an estimate

Natalie: based on what

Ricardo looked at the map.

Ricardo: when you got on

Natalie: i was already on at 10:28

Ricardo: exactly

Natalie: you werent

Ricardo did not answer.

Natalie: you got on after me

Ricardo: i know

Natalie: then 10:30 is completely made up

Ricardo: not completely

Natalie: what percentage made up is okay

Ricardo looked at the paper again.

He put one line through 10:30?.

Then another.

Ricardo: happy

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: we know 10:51

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: so i can write that

Natalie: next to the photo

Ricardo: the photo is on the map

Natalie: the time isnt

Ricardo: fine

He wrote 10:51 beside the S anyway.

Then stared at it.

After several seconds he crossed that out too.

* * *

By late afternoon the map had three failed routes.

Ricardo had stopped using the black pen.

He found a pencil in a drawer.

The fourth route began near Eastwood, where Natalie had pointed the previous Sunday.

It went west for two blocks.

Turned south.

Then west again.

The route could get closer to the tower without crossing the railway.

The problem came afterward.

To return toward the road by the gas station, the bus either had to double back or make another series of turns through streets none of them had mentioned.

Ricardo drew both.

The paper became difficult to read.

He erased one.

A gray mark remained.

He erased the other harder.

The paper wrinkled.

His phone vibrated.

Yichen: Why did you put the woman there?

Ricardo looked at the map.

Beside one bend he had written:

woman knew stop

Ricardo: because thats around where she got off

Yichen: We don’t know that.

Ricardo: we know she got off before we came out

Yichen: Yes.

Ricardo: and she knew the stop

There was a pause.

Yichen: No.

Ricardo: not yet

Yichen: That's what she said.

Ricardo: exactly

Yichen: That doesn't mean what you wrote.

Natalie: here we go

Ricardo: she literally answered you

Natalie: i asked if this was it

Ricardo: and she said not yet

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: so she knew

Yichen: Maybe.

Ricardo: thank you

Yichen: That isn't yes.

Ricardo: close enough

Yichen: No.

Ricardo put the phone down.

He looked at:

woman knew stop

He drew a line through it.

Underneath he wrote:

"Not yet."

His phone vibrated again.

Yichen: Better.

Ricardo: glad you approve

No answer.

A few minutes later he added:

driver: you sure?

Then:

woman: yes

He left them where they were.

The words took up more space than the original note.

* * *

At 5:14, Natalie sent three messages.

10:28 - already on bus

10:51 - skeleton photo

10:52 - sent to me

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: thats what we actually know

Ricardo: we know more than three things

Natalie: with times

Ricardo: yes

A few seconds later she sent:

we dont know when you got on

Then:

we dont know when yichen got on

Then:

we dont know when the turn was

Ricardo: obviously they were between 10:28 and 10:51

Natalie: probably

Ricardo: how could they not be

Natalie: i dont know

Ricardo: then why probably

Natalie: because you like that word now

Yichen: The photograph is after the laundromat.

Ricardo looked at the message.

Ricardo: yes

Yichen: And after we introduced ourselves.

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: i think so

Yichen: We did.

Ricardo: okay

He looked back at the paper.

The laundromat had not been marked.

He wrote:

L

before the skeleton.

Then looked at it.

Moved the pencil.

Put another L farther back.

He erased the first.

Natalie: what are you doing

Ricardo: nothing

Natalie: youre definitely doing something

Ricardo did not answer.

* * *

He went downstairs when his mother called him.

The map stayed open on the desk.

When Ricardo came back upstairs, the room was darker.

He turned on the desk lamp.

The circle around the water tower looked darker than everything else because he had traced it several times.

His phone showed nine new messages.

Most were Natalie and Yichen trying to remember the order of the stops after the skeleton.

Natalie: was the store before the man got on

Yichen: Yes.

Natalie: the green sign thing

Yichen: I think so.

Natalie: keller?

Yichen: Maybe Keller.

Ricardo scrolled.

Natalie: ricardo

Then:

was it keller

Ricardo typed:

keller something

Yichen: That’s what I remember.

Ricardo: same

He opened the text field again.

Then closed it.

Natalie: okay

Then:

so store then man

Yichen: I think so.

Natalie: and then the woman

Yichen: Later.

Ricardo: how much later

Yichen: I don’t know.

Ricardo: great

Natalie: put it on your beautiful map

Ricardo: already did

He looked down.

The L for laundromat.

The S.

The quotations beside the woman.

The crossed-out routes.

The circle with a question mark.

He moved the L again.

* * *

At 6:02, Ricardo sent the next photograph of the map.

Natalie: why is the laundromat there

Ricardo: because it was before the skeleton

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: and before i woke up

Nothing appeared.

Ricardo waited.

Then Natalie:

what

Ricardo: i was still asleep when we passed it

There was a longer pause.

Natalie: no you werent

Ricardo: yes i was

Natalie: you were awake

Ricardo: i woke up after

Natalie: after the laundromat?

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: no

Ricardo: yes

The typing indicator appeared beside Yichen’s name.

Stopped.

Appeared again.

Yichen: I thought you woke up at a light.

Ricardo: what light

There was no answer.

Natalie: you were awake before the laundromat

Ricardo: i wasnt

Natalie: you were

Ricardo: how do you know

Natalie: because we had already talked to you

Ricardo: about forest park

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: that was after

Natalie: no

Ricardo: yes it was

Yichen: I thought the light was before that.

Ricardo: which light

Yichen: I don’t know.

Ricardo: then why do you remember it

Yichen: I remember a light.

Ricardo: helpful

No one answered.

Ricardo looked at the map.

The L was in pencil.

He erased it.

The paper went gray.

He put the L in the same place again.

Natalie: you looked at the laundromat

Ricardo: i dont remember that

Natalie: you did

Ricardo: did i say anything

There was a pause.

Natalie: i dont know

Ricardo: then

Natalie: you looked at it

Ricardo: how do you know

Natalie did not answer immediately.

Then:

i remember you looking

Ricardo: you didnt remember when i fell asleep

Natalie: thats different

Ricardo: why

No answer.

Yichen: I remember you being awake when we said our names.

Ricardo: that was before

Yichen: I know.

Ricardo: before the laundromat or after

Another pause.

Yichen: Before, I think.

Ricardo: you think

Yichen: Yes.

Ricardo did not type.

Natalie: it was before

Ricardo: youre sure now

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: you werent sure two seconds ago

Natalie: about you looking at the laundromat

Ricardo: exactly

Natalie: not the names

Ricardo put the phone down.

The screen went dark after a minute.

He did not touch it.

When it vibrated again, he waited before looking.

Natalie: okay maybe im mixing those up

Ricardo read the message.

No one sent anything after it.

For almost four minutes the group stayed still.

Then Ricardo typed:

so nobody knows

Yichen: Not exactly.

Ricardo: what does that mean

Yichen: We know some things.

Ricardo: apparently not the order

No answer.

After another minute:

Natalie: not all of it

Ricardo looked at the map again.

He erased the L a second time.

This time he did not put it back.

* * *

At 6:41 Natalie sent:

things with actual times

Then:

10:28 already on

10:51 photo

10:52 you sent it

A fourth message:

thats it for now

Ricardo: you forgot when you got off

Natalie: i dont have it

Ricardo: you can estimate

Natalie: no

Ricardo: why not

Natalie: because then youll write it on the map

Ricardo: fair

A few minutes later Yichen sent:

Things I remember being said:

Then, separately:

“Not yet.”

Driver: “You sure?”

Woman: “Yes.”

Ricardo: forest park

Yichen: What?

Ricardo: we asked about forest park

Yichen: Yes.

After a pause:

Natalie asked the driver first.

Natalie: he ignored me

Yichen: I know.

Ricardo: and then

Yichen: I don’t remember the exact words after that.

Ricardo: you remember exact words from the woman

Yichen: Those.

Ricardo: why

No answer for almost a minute.

Then:

Yichen: I don’t know.

Ricardo left the message there.

He copied the three quoted lines onto the margin of the paper.

Not beside any particular point this time.

* * *

The fifth route did not begin at Eastwood.

Ricardo started between Eastwood and Moore again.

He drew west until the line reached the first street that would take it south without crossing the railway.

Then another turn.

Then another.

The route passed well south of the circle around the water tower.

He stopped.

Moved the circle.

Stopped again.

The tower could not move.

Ricardo erased the route.

The sixth began near Montrose.

It could get closer.

Then it ran into a street that did not continue.

Ricardo checked satellite view.

Same result.

He drew a small X at the end.

The seventh route went farther south before turning west.

It avoided the railway, followed ordinary streets and came back near the place Ricardo and Natalie had recognized.

Ricardo measured the route with his finger.

Then checked the map on his phone.

It was long.

Not impossible.

He took a photograph.

Sent it.

Natalie: that one looks normal

Ricardo: yes

Yichen: Does it fit?

Ricardo looked again.

Ricardo: sort of

Natalie: thats new

Ricardo: but the tower is wrong

Natalie: how

Ricardo: we wouldve been on the wrong side

Yichen: If it is the tower.

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: and if the picture is where you put it

Ricardo: yes

Yichen: And if that's where we turned.

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: thats a lot of if

Ricardo did not answer.

He put the phone down.

On the paper, the seventh route was the only one that had not been crossed out.

He looked at it for a while.

Then wrote a question mark at the start.

Another beside the skeleton.

Another where the route came back out.

Three question marks.

The line remained.

* * *

At 8:03, Natalie sent:

you wrote 10:51 on the new one again

Ricardo looked at the photograph he had sent.

He had.

Ricardo: thats when the picture was

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: so

Natalie: nothing

A second message:

leave it

Ricardo: wow

Natalie: im serious leave it

Ricardo: okay

Yichen: The man didn’t say anything.

Natalie: what

Yichen: I was trying to remember.

Ricardo: he didnt

Yichen: I don’t remember him saying anything.

Ricardo: same thing

Yichen: No.

Natalie: there it is

Ricardo: what

Natalie: nothing

Ricardo: everyone is very funny today

No answer.

A few minutes passed.

Natalie: also 10:28 is not when i got on

Ricardo: i know

Natalie: its just when i know i was already on

Ricardo: i know

Natalie: okay

Ricardo: youve said this like five times

Natalie: because you keep writing it like its a start time

Ricardo looked at the paper.

He had written:

10:28

near River Road.

He erased it.

Put the pencil down.

Then wrote the number on the blank margin instead.

No arrow.

No road beside it.

Just:

10:28 - Natalie already on

Below it:

10:51 - photo

He left room underneath.

* * *

At 9:11, Ricardo sent another map.

This one was cleaner only because he had traced the seventh route onto the back of the sheet.

Natalie: you used the back

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: why

Ricardo: couldnt see anything

Yichen: I still can’t tell what the line means.

Ricardo: possible route

Natalie: possible according to who

Ricardo: roads

Natalie: very reliable source

Ricardo: thank you

Yichen: Where is the laundromat?

Ricardo looked at the map.

He had left it off.

Ricardo: dont know

Natalie: good

Ricardo: stop saying good

Yichen: Where is the woman’s stop?

Ricardo: dont know

Natalie: good

Ricardo: im blocking you

Natalie: okay

He did not.

Yichen: And the man?

Ricardo: somewhere before her

Yichen: Probably.

Ricardo: yes

No one sent anything for a while.

Then Natalie:

does the route work without those

Ricardo looked down.

The route existed.

The railway was avoided.

The tower was close enough if the photograph showed the tower at all.

The road came back near the gas station.

But the laundromat had nowhere fixed to go.

Neither did the man.

Neither did the woman.

The beginning was a question mark.

So was the end.

He typed:

not really

Natalie: okay

Ricardo: why is that okay

Natalie: because yesterday you wouldve said it did

Ricardo did not answer.

Yichen: I'm going to sleep.

Natalie: same

Ricardo: wait

Yichen: What?

Ricardo looked at the paper.

He looked at the margin with the times.

Then at the messages Yichen had sent.

Ricardo: anything else you remember people saying

There was a pause.

Yichen: Not now.

Ricardo: tomorrow

Yichen: Maybe.

Natalie: good night

Yichen: Good night.

Ricardo: night

The group went quiet.

* * *

His phone vibrated less than a minute later.

Owen: THE SCORE PIC

Ricardo looked at the message.

Then at the camera roll.

He swiped backward through the photographs.

Skeleton.

Floor.

Finger over the lens.

Game case.

Television.

He sent the photograph Owen wanted.

Owen: finally

Then:

we won by 3 btw

Ricardo: i know

Owen: did you

Ricardo: yes

Owen: sure

Ricardo put the phone down.

The printed map stayed open on the desk.

On the front were the crossed-out routes.

On the back was one route that had not worked either.

In the margin were two times.

Below them was empty space.

The three places from the previous Sunday were still visible underneath everything else.

CHAPTER SIX

The next message about the bus came two days later.

Ricardo sent a screenshot.

Most of it was a page about road construction. Near the top were the words:

MANNHEIM ROAD

Farther down:

Irving Park Road

and:

Higgins Road

Natalie replied:

construction

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: you found construction near ohare

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: groundbreaking

Ricardo sent the screenshot again.

This time he had circled a paragraph.

Yichen: What am I looking at?

Ricardo: mannheim was being rebuilt

it started in 2012

Natalie: okay

Ricardo: and it was still going

Yichen: Does it say the bus was detoured?

There was no answer for a minute.

Then:

Ricardo: no

Natalie: excellent

Ricardo: it means there was construction

Yichen: Yes.

Ricardo: which means there couldve been a detour

Yichen: Yes.

Natalie: this is the most supportive shes ever been

Ricardo: thank you

Yichen: I didn’t say the bus took one.

Ricardo: there it is

Nothing else came that night.

* * *

On Saturday, they met at the library on Old River Road.

Ricardo arrived first.

He had printed the construction page.

The map from the previous Sunday was folded inside it.

Natalie came in carrying a paper cup.

Yichen arrived several minutes later with a notebook in one hand.

Ricardo looked at Natalie’s cup.

“You can have that in here?”

Natalie looked down at it.

“Apparently.”

Yichen sat across from them.

Ricardo unfolded the page.

Natalie took a drink.

“What exactly are we doing?”

“Checking it.”

“You already checked it.”

“I checked online.”

“That’s checking.”

“I’m checking the route.”

Ricardo put the map beside the construction page.

He pointed at Mannheim.

“The work was here.”

Natalie leaned closer.

Yichen opened her notebook.

“And if the bus came this way—”

“From where?” Yichen asked.

Ricardo looked at her.

“What?”

“Where are you starting?”

He pointed.

“Here.”

Natalie looked.

“Montrose?”

“Near Montrose.”

“You didn’t pick Montrose.”

“Yichen did.”

Yichen looked up.

“I said maybe.”

Ricardo moved his finger slightly north.

“Fine. Around here.”

Natalie said, “That somehow feels worse.”

“I’m testing it.”

“Test mine.”

“I will.”

“And yours.”

Ricardo looked at Yichen.

She nodded.

“All three.”

He turned the map sideways.

For several minutes the only sounds at the table were paper, pencil and the ventilation above them.

Ricardo traced one route with his finger.

Stopped.

Started again from another point.

Stopped sooner.

The third went farther west before he shook his head.

Natalie watched.

Yichen wrote something.

Ricardo noticed.

“What are you writing?”

“Nothing.”

“That’s obviously something.”

Yichen covered the line with her hand.

Natalie leaned sideways.

Yichen moved the notebook.

“What?” Ricardo said.

Yichen looked at the construction page.

“It doesn’t tell us where we turned.”

“I know.”

She finished the line.

Ricardo looked at the map again.

“The bus still could’ve been sent around it.”

Natalie took another drink.

“Could’ve.”

“Yes.”

“That word is doing a lot of work.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“You used probably for three days.”

“I’ve grown.”

Yichen said, “No.”

Natalie looked at her.

“Whose side are you on?”

“No one’s.”

“That seems healthy.”

Ricardo folded the construction page in half.

* * *

The construction explanation lasted another week.

There was no message where anyone declared it dead.

Ricardo found another notice.

That one was too far west.

Natalie found a date on a different page that did not help.

Yichen pointed out that one route would have crossed the railway and then crossed back.

Ricardo found a road that could do it.

It was nowhere near the place he needed.

One afternoon Natalie sent:

so construction can explain some turns

Ricardo: yes

Yichen: Not ours yet.

Ricardo: maybe theres another one

Natalie: how much construction do you need

Ricardo: one useful one

Yichen: That would help.

Ricardo did not reply.

The next afternoon Natalie sent:

im taking construction off

Ricardo answered immediately.

off what

A photograph appeared.

It showed part of a notebook page.

At the top Natalie had written:

possible

Underneath:

construction / detour

service road

mixed streets

wrong turn

photo location wrong

Farther down was another line:

not enough

Under it:

construction

Ricardo: why is construction in both

Natalie: because there was construction

Another message:

it just doesnt explain enough

Ricardo: thats stupid

Yichen: No.

Natalie: thank you

Ricardo: you two are becoming a problem

No one answered.

* * *

The service road was Ricardo's idea.

He sent the first photograph on Thursday afternoon.

A narrow road ran beside a chain-link fence. Beyond it were loading docks and the back of a long low building.

Under the photograph:

bus fits

Natalie: lots of things fit

Ricardo: thats literally the point

Yichen: Where is that?

Ricardo sent the location.

Natalie: thats airport stuff

Ricardo: yes

Yichen: There weren't warehouses outside the whole time.

Ricardo: not the whole time

Yichen: There were houses.

Ricardo: later

Natalie: and the laundromat

Ricardo: later

Yichen: And stores.

Ricardo: later

Natalie: everything is later

Ricardo did not answer.

A few minutes passed.

Then:

Ricardo: saturday

Natalie: what

Ricardo: lets go look

Natalie: no

Yichen: Where?

Natalie: dont encourage him

Ricardo sent a pin.

Yichen: Okay.

Natalie: why

Yichen: Because otherwise he'll send photographs all weekend.

Ricardo: correct

Natalie: fine

* * *

Saturday was colder than the week before.

Ricardo met them near River Road.

Natalie had gloves.

Yichen did not.

Ricardo looked at Yichen's hands.

"You're going to complain."

“No.”

“You will.”

Natalie said, “She can borrow mine after I get tired of them.”

Yichen looked at her.

“Why would you get tired of gloves?”

Natalie shrugged.

They started walking.

The first road Ricardo wanted to see was not accessible from where he thought it was.

A fence continued past the corner.

Ricardo checked his phone.

Natalie stood beside him.

“You drew an entrance.”

“There is an entrance.”

“Where?”

Ricardo moved the phone.

“Here.”

Natalie looked up.

There was no entrance.

Yichen said, “Good start.”

Ricardo walked farther along the fence.

They followed.

A truck passed behind it.

The road inside continued toward a group of warehouse buildings.

At the next corner Ricardo stopped.

There was a gate.

Natalie read the sign.

“No unauthorized vehicles.”

“That doesn’t mean nothing goes through.”

“That is almost what it means.”

“Trucks go through.”

Yichen looked through the fence.

“Was there a fence?”

Ricardo looked at her.

“What?”

“Friday.”

“I don’t know.”

Natalie looked through too.

“I don’t remember one.”

Ricardo checked his phone.

“There could’ve been one on the other side.”

Yichen said, “There could’ve been almost anything on the other side.”

Ricardo put the phone in his pocket.

They kept walking.

The road bent.

The fence stayed beside them.

On the opposite side were parked cars, a low office building and a patch of grass with a plastic cup caught against the curb.

Natalie kicked the cup free.

It rolled once and stopped against the curb again.

Yichen put both hands into her sleeves.

Ricardo noticed.

“Told you.”

“I’m not complaining.”

“You’re doing that because you’re cold.”

“Yes.”

“That counts.”

“No.”

Natalie took off one glove and held it out.

Yichen looked at it.

“One?”

“You only have one hand?”

Yichen took the glove.

Ricardo kept walking.

After another block, the service road disappeared behind a building.

There was no sidewalk.

A loading truck backed across the entrance.

The three of them stopped.

Ricardo looked at his phone.

Natalie said, “Does your bus go through the truck?”

“It wasn’t there Friday.”

“Probably.”

Yichen looked past the loading dock.

“There still weren’t houses.”

“No.”

“And the laundromat.”

“No.”

“And the store.”

“I know.”

Natalie looked at Ricardo.

“So what does this explain?”

He looked back toward the road they had walked.

“A bus could be back here.”

Yichen pulled Natalie’s glove tighter over her hand.

“That wasn’t the question.”

Nobody spoke.

A truck beeped while reversing.

Ricardo put his phone away.

They turned back.

* * *

They stopped at a convenience store before separating.

Natalie bought coffee.

Yichen bought another pair of gloves.

Ricardo bought chips and a bottle of Coke.

Natalie looked at the gloves.

“Those are ugly.”

“They’re warm.”

“They’re really ugly.”

Yichen put them on.

“You can have yours back.”

Natalie took the glove and put it in her pocket.

Ricardo opened the chips.

“You know what the problem is?”

Natalie looked at him.

“No.”

“The road doesn’t need to look like that the whole way.”

Yichen opened the store door.

“What?”

Ricardo followed her outside.

“The service road.”

Natalie came out last.

Ricardo continued.

“It could be service road, then normal streets.”

Yichen stopped on the sidewalk.

“So several roads.”

“Yes.”

Natalie looked at him.

“That’s what we said.”

“No.”

“Yes.”

“You said we mixed up roads.”

“Yes.”

“I’m saying the bus used more than one road.”

Natalie looked at Yichen.

Yichen said, “That is also what roads usually do.”

Ricardo ate a chip.

“That’s not what I mean.”

Natalie smiled.

“We know.”

* * *

The mixed-streets explanation stayed longer.

Yichen wrote it first.

Maybe there was no long street.

Ricardo: we already did this

Yichen: Maybe there were two normal areas and we put them together.

Natalie: thats what i meant

Yichen: Yes.

Ricardo: how

Yichen: What?

Ricardo: how do we put two places together

Natalie: we remembered them wrong

Ricardo: helpful

Natalie: thank you

Yichen: You were asleep.

Ricardo: not again

Yichen: Natalie wasn’t looking outside the whole time.

Natalie: true

Yichen: I didn’t know the area.

Ricardo: so

Yichen: So maybe the laundromat and the skeleton weren’t as close as you think.

Ricardo: they were

There was a pause.

Natalie: i think they were close

Yichen: Okay.

Ricardo: thank you

Yichen: I said okay.

Ricardo: yes

Yichen did not answer.

A minute later Ricardo sent:

what about keller

Natalie: what about it

Ricardo: where does that go

Yichen: I remember a sign.

Natalie: same

Ricardo: before or after skeleton

No answer came immediately.

Natalie: after?

Yichen: Maybe.

Ricardo: great

A photograph of the map appeared.

It now had:

L

S

and:

K?

Ricardo: good enough

Yichen: For what?

Ricardo: for putting it on the map

Yichen: You put a question mark.

Ricardo: yes

Yichen: Then okay.

Natalie: historic agreement

* * *

On Tuesday, Yichen sent a photograph of a notebook page.

There was no message with it.

At the top she had written:

ORDER?

Below it:

turn

Ricardo asleep

names

laundromat

skeleton photo

Keller?

man gets on

“Not yet.”

woman gets off later

normal road

Natalie replied first.

wait

Then:

names before laundromat?

Yichen: I think.

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: you said you were asleep at laundromat

Ricardo: i know

Natalie: but you were awake for names

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: so

No answer.

Yichen: That is why I put the question mark at the top.

Ricardo: thats not how question marks work

Natalie: apparently it is now

Yichen sent another message.

What do either of you remember about the laundromat?

Ricardo answered first.

lights

Then:

machines

Natalie: windows

Another message:

really bright

Yichen: Someone was inside.

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: woman

Yichen: Maybe.

Natalie: there was definitely someone

Ricardo: folding clothes

A pause.

Natalie: i think so

Ricardo: and tv

Natalie: was there a tv

Ricardo: yes

Yichen: I remember a screen.

Natalie: same

Ricardo: so tv

Yichen: Probably.

Ricardo: finally

Nothing else came for a while.

Later that evening Yichen sent another photograph.

Under laundromat she had written:

bright windows / machines / woman folding clothes / TV?

Ricardo replied to a different line.

man got on before not yet

Yichen: I know.

Natalie: do we

Yichen: I think.

Ricardo: great question mark the entire page

Yichen: I considered it.

* * *

Two days later Ricardo sent:

two dryers

Natalie: what

Ricardo: laundromat

Yichen: What about them?

Ricardo: there were two

Natalie: i dont know

Ricardo: i remember two

Yichen: Okay.

Ricardo: you dont

Yichen: I remember machines.

Ricardo: two

Yichen: Machines.

Natalie: there cant have been one dryer

Ricardo: exactly

Yichen: He remembers two.

Natalie: i know

Yichen: I'm leaving it as machines.

Ricardo: coward

Yichen: Yes.

* * *

The photograph became a problem next.

Not the skeleton.

The time.

Natalie sent:

how sure are we 10:51 is right

Ricardo: its on the photo

Natalie: i know

Ricardo: then very

Yichen: Could the phone time have been wrong?

Ricardo: by what twenty minutes

Yichen: I don’t know.

Natalie: mine couldve been off too

Ricardo: both

Natalie: possible

Ricardo: come on

Yichen: You wanted normal explanations.

Ricardo: not stupid ones

Natalie: phones being wrong is real

Ricardo: not like that

Yichen: How do you know?

Ricardo did not answer.

Several minutes later:

Ricardo: even if its wrong by 5 minutes it doesnt fix the road

Natalie: probably

Ricardo: why probably

Natalie: because i dont know where the road is

Ricardo: great

Nothing else came.

* * *

The group quieted for four days.

Ricardo sent Owen two photographs of a game.

Owen sent back a picture of a controller with one button missing.

Natalie worked three evenings.

Yichen went to a birthday dinner.

On the fifth day Ricardo sent the bus group:

i think yichen is right

Natalie: screenshotting this

Yichen: About what?

Ricardo: mixed streets

Natalie: oh

Yichen: Why?

Ricardo sent a map.

There were two circles now.

One was near the area he had been using for the skeleton.

The other was farther away.

No route connected them.

Ricardo: laundromat couldve been here

Then:

skeleton here

Yichen: Why?

Ricardo: both places fit better separately

Natalie: and between them

Ricardo: dont know

Yichen: How long between them?

Ricardo: also dont know

Natalie: so we have nothing between them

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: youre being weirdly reasonable

Ricardo: shut up

The map stayed in the group.

Nobody sent anything else until the next afternoon.

* * *

They met again the following weekend.

Not at McDonald’s.

Natalie had complained that they always smelled like fries afterward.

Ricardo suggested the library.

Yichen said the library closed too early.

They ended up at a small table in the diner where Natalie worked.

She was not working that day.

The manager saw her come in and pointed toward a booth.

“No discount.”

“I didn’t ask.”

“You were going to.”

Natalie looked at Ricardo.

“He does this.”

Ricardo sat down.

“You do it too.”

Yichen took the outside seat.

The manager brought three menus.

Natalie did not open hers.

“I know the menu.”

“That’s very impressive,” Ricardo said.

She kicked his shoe under the table.

Yichen moved her feet farther away.

Ricardo put the map between the ketchup bottle and the napkin holder.

It was not the old printout.

This one was larger.

Several sheets had been taped together.

Natalie looked at it.

“You made another one.”

“The old one was unreadable.”

“That was your fault.”

“Yes.”

Yichen leaned over.

“What are the circles?”

“Things.”

“What things?”

Ricardo pointed.

“Skeleton.”

Another.

“Laundromat.”

“Possible laundromat,” Natalie said.

Ricardo picked up the pencil and added a question mark.

Natalie smiled.

“Growth.”

Ricardo put the pencil down.

Yichen pointed at another mark.

“That?”

“Possible exit.”

Another.

“Keller.”

Natalie looked at him.

He added another question mark.

“Happy?”

“A little.”

* * *

They spent most of lunch moving things.

Ricardo pointed to a road.

“We could’ve come through here.”

Yichen said, “Why?”

“Because then you can get from the skeleton to the gas station.”

Yichen looked at the map.

“You need it there for the route.”

“Yes.”

“Do you remember it?”

Ricardo looked down.

Natalie said, “Do either of you remember turning there?”

“No,” Yichen said.

Ricardo moved his finger.

“Not exactly there.”

“Then where?”

He moved it again.

Stopped.

Natalie said, “Okay.”

Ricardo looked up.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“That means something now.”

“It means okay.”

Yichen looked at Natalie.

Natalie looked back.

“You’re making it worse,” Natalie said.

A server brought their drinks.

The map had to be moved to make room.

Ricardo folded one side over.

For several minutes they ate.

The bus did not come up.

Natalie told Yichen about a customer who had tried to order breakfast after breakfast ended.

Yichen asked why they could not just make eggs.

Natalie said they could.

Ricardo looked at her.

“Then why didn’t you?”

“Because breakfast ended.”

“That’s not an answer.”

“It is at a restaurant.”

Yichen said, “I agree with her.”

Ricardo looked at both of them.

“This explains a lot.”

Natalie laughed.

The server brought fries.

Ricardo took one from Natalie’s plate.

She slapped his hand.

The map stayed folded beside the ketchup.

* * *

When Ricardo opened it again, Yichen’s notebook was beside it.

The page contained short lines.

woman already on

paper bag

Natalie: “Is this it?”

woman: “Not yet.”

driver: “You sure?”

woman: “Yes.”

man got on

Below those:

Keller?

And:

laundromat — bright windows / machines / woman folding clothes / TV?

Ricardo looked at the last line.

Then at the map.

“Where do I put the man?”

Yichen looked at him.

“What?”

“The man who got on.”

“I don’t know.”

“Before the woman got off.”

“Yes.”

“So somewhere before W.”

“You took W off.”

Ricardo looked at the map.

The W was not there.

“Right.”

Natalie took a fry.

“Growth.”

Ricardo ignored her.

He drew a tiny M near one of the circles.

Yichen looked at it.

“Why there?”

Ricardo erased it.

Natalie said, “More growth.”

“Stop.”

The server returned.

“Everything okay?”

All three looked up.

Natalie said, “Yeah.”

* * *

Over the next few weeks, the maps changed.

One photograph showed the skeleton circle closer to River Road.

The next showed it farther west.

The laundromat moved twice.

Keller disappeared from one map and returned on another with a question mark.

Messages appeared between ordinary ones.

did we cross tracks before the skeleton

dont know

after?

dont know

helpful

Another night:

was the gas station before we knew where we were

what does that mean

before we recognized the road

probably

you say probably too much

you say yes too much

Sometimes there were no bus messages for several days.

Natalie worked.

Ricardo went to Owen's.

Yichen stopped carrying Natalie's glove because she had her own.

Then somebody sent a photograph and the group returned to the top of all three phones.

* * *

By the next month Natalie's page looked different.

There were three lines at the top:

10:28 — already on

10:51 — skeleton photo

10:52 — sent

Below them, with more space between each:

construction?

service road?

mixed streets

phone time wrong?

exit location?

Ricardo replied:

you put wrong phone time again

Natalie: yes

Ricardo: why

Natalie: because we didnt prove it wasnt

Ricardo: we didnt prove aliens didnt move the bus

Natalie: adding aliens

Ricardo: dont

Yichen: Please do.

Natalie: 2 votes

Ricardo: i hate this group

No one added aliens.

* * *

Yichen sent another page later that week.

It had no headings.

Only entries.

woman already on

paper bag

Natalie: “Is this it?”

woman: “Not yet.”

driver: “You sure?”

woman: “Yes.”

man got on

Below that:

Keller?

Then:

laundromat — bright windows / machines / someone inside

Natalie: you took folding clothes out

Yichen: Yes.

Ricardo: why

Yichen: I’m not sure.

Ricardo: you had it before

Yichen: Yes.

Natalie: i think i remember it

Yichen: Okay.

Natalie: youre not adding it

Yichen: No.

Ricardo: dictator

Yichen: Make your own list.

Ricardo: i have a map

Natalie: oh my god

* * *

The next Saturday, Ricardo printed another map.

It had fewer marks than the one at the diner.

There was a circle for the skeleton.

A larger circle for the laundromat.

A question mark near the possible exit.

Three small marks along River Road where they had pointed weeks earlier.

No line connected all of them.

Natalie looked at it.

“Better.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“It has less information.”

“Yes.”

“That isn’t better.”

Yichen pulled the paper closer.

“It has less stuff you have to move.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“That is not what a map is for.”

Natalie pointed at the skeleton circle.

“Why is this one small?”

“Photo.”

“The tower?”

“Yes.”

“If it’s the tower.”

Ricardo picked up the pencil.

He made the circle slightly larger.

Natalie stopped him.

“I didn’t say change it.”

“You just said—”

“I asked.”

Ricardo put the pencil down.

Yichen touched the larger circle.

“And this?”

“Laundromat.”

“Why is it bigger?”

“We don’t know exactly where it was.”

“You know exactly where the skeleton was?”

Ricardo looked at the smaller circle.

“No.”

Natalie leaned closer.

“What does small mean, then?”

Ricardo looked at both circles.

“More sure.”

“How much more?”

“I don’t know.”

“Then maybe write that.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“Write what?”

“I don’t know.”

“That’s very useful.”

Natalie smiled.

“Thank you.”

Yichen touched the three marks along River Road.

“And these?”

“Where we thought we turned.”

“Thought?”

“Yes.”

“Do you still?”

Ricardo looked at the marks.

Yichen touched the one nearest Montrose.

“I don’t know anymore.”

Natalie said, “Me neither.”

Ricardo looked from one mark to the next.

The pencil stayed beside his hand.

For a while nobody moved anything.

* * *

That evening Ricardo sent a photograph of the map to the group.

Natalie: whats the plan now

Ricardo: dont know

Yichen: Good.

Ricardo: stop saying that

Natalie: shes right

Ricardo: how is not knowing good

Yichen: You don’t have to put something there.

Ricardo: then the map has a hole

Yichen: Yes.

Several minutes passed.

Ricardo: fine

Natalie: fine what

Ricardo: leave it

The group went quiet.

* * *

Two nights later, Yichen sent another photograph of her notebook.

No one had asked for it.

The page was cleaner than the earlier one.

Some words had been crossed out.

Others had moved.

Near the bottom:

laundromat — bright windows / machines / someone inside

Natalie replied:

that looks wrong

Yichen: What part?

Natalie: i dont know

Ricardo: helpful

Natalie: shut up

A minute passed.

Then:

Natalie: werent the lights really white

Ricardo: yeah

Yichen did not answer.

The next afternoon she sent another photograph.

The laundromat line now read:

laundromat — very bright / machines / someone inside

Ricardo replied:

why did you move the skeleton circle

Yichen: I didn’t.

Natalie: thats his map

Ricardo: wrong photo

Yichen: Good.

Ricardo: stop

Natalie: never

CHAPTER SEVEN

Almost three months after the bus, Ricardo brought a new map.

There was snow along the edge of the parking lot.

Most of it had gone gray.

A plow had pushed one ridge against the curb outside the McDonald’s, where it had frozen hard enough that somebody had stepped onto it without leaving much of a mark.

Natalie arrived first.

She had a paper cup and no food.

Yichen came in a few minutes later carrying a backpack with one strap twisted.

Ricardo was last.

He put a folder on the table before he took off his coat.

Natalie looked at it.

“Hello to you too.”

“Hi.”

“You could pretend.”

“Hi, Natalie.”

“Better.”

Yichen sat down.

Ricardo opened the folder.

The map inside was larger than the ones he had used before.

Two sheets had been printed separately and taped together along the middle. The tape was slightly crooked. River Road ran down one side. Mannheim and Irving Park were labeled. The railway was there. So was the water tower.

There were fewer circles than before.

The laundromat was no longer a single place. Ricardo had drawn a loose oval around several blocks.

The skeleton had a smaller one.

Three old marks remained along River Road, but they had been reduced to faint pencil crosses.

Several possible streets had been drawn in broken lines.

One stretch was black.

Natalie put her cup down.

“You learned how to use the printer.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“I always knew how to use a printer.”

“The tape disagrees.”

Yichen pulled the map closer.

Ricardo took out a pencil.

“There are only two routes that work now.”

Natalie said, “You said that last time.”

“No. Last time there were four.”

“That is worse.”

“It is better.”

“How?”

“Because two are gone.”

Yichen looked at the black line.

“Why?”

Ricardo pointed.

“This one crosses the tracks here. That doesn’t work.”

Natalie leaned over the table.

“Why not?”

“There’s no crossing.”

“Now or then?”

Ricardo looked at her.

“Both.”

“You checked?”

“Yes.”

“How?”

“Street View.”

Natalie looked at Yichen.

Yichen said, “That does not tell you both.”

Ricardo closed his eyes for a second.

“I checked old satellite pictures too.”

Natalie picked up her cup again.

“Okay.”

Ricardo pointed to the second route.

“This one goes too far south. We would have had to come back north before the gas station.”

Yichen said, “Maybe we did.”

“Nobody remembers that.”

“That has not stopped you before.”

Ricardo moved the pencil away from her.

“It stops me now.”

Natalie smiled into the lid of the cup.

No one said anything for several seconds.

Ricardo tapped the map.

“So that leaves this.”

The black line began near one of the possible turns from River Road.

It went west, bent around the railway, passed the larger laundromat oval and continued toward the smaller circle near the water tower.

After that it broke apart again.

The final section toward the road they had recognized was dotted.

Yichen looked at the first section.

Then she looked at Ricardo.

“Why is that solid?”

“What?”

She touched the paper.

“This.”

“Because we know we came through there.”

“No.”

Ricardo looked at her.

Yichen kept one finger on the line.

“You think we did.”

“There isn’t another way.”

“That’s not the same sentence.”

The table went quiet.

Behind them, a tray hit the top of a trash can.

Someone laughed near the counter.

Ricardo looked back at the map.

“There isn’t another way that fits.”

Yichen said, “Okay.”

“So.”

“So that is what you know.”

Ricardo looked up.

“What?”

“That there isn’t another way that fits.”

“Yes.”

“Not that we came through there.”

Natalie leaned back.

Ricardo said, “If there isn’t another way, then we came through there.”

Yichen shook her head once.

“No.”

“How?”

“I don’t know.”

“That isn’t an answer.”

“It is.”

“No, it isn’t.”

Natalie said, “Here we go.”

Ricardo pointed at the map.

“If the bus got from here to here, and every other road is impossible, then it had to use this one.”

Yichen said, “If those are the right two places.”

Ricardo stopped.

Yichen moved her finger to the laundromat oval.

“This can move.”

Then to the skeleton circle.

“This can move.”

“The tower can’t.”

“The photograph can.”

“What does that mean?”

“You said the tower might be in the photograph.”

“It is.”

Yichen looked at Natalie.

Natalie said, “Looks like it.”

Ricardo stared at her.

“You agreed it was the tower.”

“I agreed it looks like the tower.”

“You two are impossible.”

Yichen touched the black line again.

“Then make it dotted.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“What?”

“A dotted line.”

“That doesn’t help.”

“It’s accurate.”

“It makes it look like we don’t know.”

Yichen waited.

Natalie put her cup down.

Ricardo looked from one of them to the other.

“We know something.”

“Then draw that part,” Yichen said.

“What part?”

“I don’t know.”

Ricardo dropped the pencil onto the map.

“Great.”

* * *

They left the line alone for a while.

Natalie had brought a folded sheet of notebook paper.

She opened it beside the map.

At the top:

10:28 — already on

10:51 — skeleton photo

10:52 — sent

Below that were several entries with question marks.

woman off before normal road?

gas station before 11?

photo time wrong?

Ricardo looked at the last one.

“You still have that.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because you still haven’t proved it wasn’t.”

“I checked my phone.”

“Three months later.”

“The clock is automatic.”

“Now.”

“It was automatic then.”

Natalie looked at him.

Ricardo took out his phone.

Yichen said, “Don’t.”

“I’m showing her.”

“She knows phones have clocks.”

“Apparently not.”

Natalie said, “I know phones have clocks.”

“Good.”

“I also know you don’t know if yours was right that night.”

Ricardo put the phone down.

“Fine.”

Natalie drew a small mark beside the entry.

Ricardo pointed.

“What does that mean?”

“Nothing.”

“You just wrote it.”

“It means we talked about it.”

“That is something.”

Natalie looked at the mark.

Then crossed it out.

Ricardo smiled.

“Good system.”

“Shut up.”

Yichen had opened her notebook.

Several older pages had been folded underneath the cover.

The current page began:

woman already on

paper bag

Natalie: “Is this it?”

woman: “Not yet.”

driver: “You sure?”

woman: “Yes.”

Farther down:

man got on

Keller?

laundromat — very bright / machines / someone inside

Natalie glanced at it.

“Still very bright.”

Yichen looked at the line.

“Yes.”

“You kept it.”

“Yes.”

Ricardo said, “Because it was bright.”

Yichen did not answer him.

Natalie looked at the notebook for another moment.

Then at the map.

“Okay.”

Ricardo said, “What?”

“Nothing.”

“You keep saying that after looking at things.”

“I’m allowed to look at things.”

“You make a face.”

“I have a face.”

Yichen turned the page.

Ricardo picked up his pencil again.

The black route remained.

* * *

They ordered food later.

Natalie got fries.

Yichen ordered a small coffee and let it sit untouched until it stopped steaming.

Ricardo came back with a tray, moved the map to make room and nearly folded one corner into ketchup.

Yichen caught it.

“Careful.”

“It’s paper.”

“You spent three months on it.”

“I did not spend three months on one map.”

Natalie said, “That would be worse.”

Ricardo put the tray down.

“There were versions.”

“How many?”

He did not answer.

Natalie looked at Yichen.

Yichen said, “How many?”

“Like eight.”

Natalie laughed.

Ricardo opened a packet of ketchup.

“Some of them were basically the same.”

“That is not helping.”

He squeezed the packet onto the wrapper beside his fries.

Yichen pulled one of the older sheets from the folder.

It was smaller.

More lines crossed it.

A third had circles in different places.

Another had no route at all.

Natalie put two of them side by side.

“The laundromat moved.”

“Yes.”

“Three times.”

“Yes.”

“The skeleton moved too.”

“Barely.”

Yichen said, “It moved.”

Ricardo took a fry.

“Because the circles got better.”

Natalie said, “What does that mean?”

“The possible area got smaller.”

“Because?”

Ricardo pointed at the older map.

“Because if the laundromat is over here, the route can’t get back without crossing the tracks. If it’s here, it can.”

Yichen looked at him.

Ricardo stopped chewing.

“What?”

“You moved the laundromat because the route works better there.”

“It also makes sense there.”

“Why?”

“Because it does.”

Natalie said, “Excellent.”

Ricardo put the fry down.

“There are commercial buildings there.”

“There are commercial buildings everywhere.”

“Not everywhere.”

“Near an airport?”

Ricardo looked back at the map.

Yichen took his pencil.

She drew a small question mark beside the laundromat oval.

Ricardo watched her.

“You can’t just draw on it.”

“You do.”

“It’s my map.”

Yichen handed the pencil back.

“Then remove it.”

Ricardo looked at the question mark.

He did not erase it.

Natalie reached across and pulled one of the older maps closer.

“This line.”

Ricardo looked.

“What about it?”

“It’s dotted here.”

“Yes.”

She moved to the newest map.

“And solid here.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

Ricardo did not answer immediately.

Yichen looked at him.

Natalie said, “Was there something new?”

“No.”

“Then why did it change?”

“Because the other route stopped working.”

Yichen sat back.

Ricardo said, “What?”

“Nothing.”

“Don’t do that.”

“Do what?”

“That.”

Natalie said, “She didn’t do anything.”

“She did the face.”

Yichen looked at Natalie.

Natalie said, “Apparently we both have one.”

Ricardo took the pencil.

He put the tip on the black line.

Did not move it.

Then he drew over the first inch with short gaps.

The line became uneven.

Part black.

Part white.

He stopped halfway.

“This looks terrible.”

Yichen said, “Keep going.”

“No.”

Natalie said, “Now I agree with him.”

“Thank you.”

“It does look terrible.”

Ricardo put the pencil down.

Yichen took it again.

She continued the broken line to the edge of the laundromat oval.

The old solid line remained faintly visible beneath the gaps.

Ricardo watched.

“You can still see it.”

“Yes.”

“That defeats the point.”

Yichen rubbed the side of her thumb across one section.

Gray graphite spread over the paper.

Natalie said, “That helped.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“No, it did not.”

* * *

They tried the same question on the rest of the map.

It went badly.

The skeleton circle came first.

Ricardo said, “That stays.”

Yichen said, “Why?”

“Photograph.”

Natalie said, “Photograph of something.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“You know what it is.”

“I know what it looks like.”

Yichen said, “Small circle?”

Natalie said, “Why small?”

Ricardo said, “We already did this.”

“Did we decide?”

No one answered.

The circle stayed.

The possible exit came next.

It had a question mark.

Natalie said, “That’s fine.”

Ricardo said, “Why?”

“Because it already says we don’t know.”

Yichen said, “Does a question mark mean the same thing as dotted?”

Ricardo looked at her.

Natalie looked at the map.

“No.”

“What does it mean?”

“I don’t know.”

Ricardo laughed once.

Natalie pointed at him.

“Don’t.”

“I didn’t say anything.”

“You were going to.”

“You don’t know that.”

Yichen smiled.

Natalie looked at her.

“You’re both awful.”

They moved to the three old River Road crosses.

Ricardo said, “Those can probably go.”

Natalie said, “Why?”

“None of us still thinks those are right.”

Yichen touched the middle one.

“I might.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“Might what?”

“Think it was around here.”

“Do you remember that?”

Yichen looked at the cross.

A few seconds passed.

“I remember pointing there.”

Natalie said, “At McDonald’s.”

“Yes.”

Ricardo said, “That doesn’t tell us anything.”

Yichen looked at him.

“It tells us I pointed there.”

“About the road.”

“Yes.”

“So leave it.”

“Why?”

Ricardo looked at the map.

No one spoke.

Natalie picked up the pencil.

She wrote beside the three crosses:

we pointed here

Ricardo read it.

“That’s ugly.”

“It’s true.”

Yichen said, “Keep it.”

Ricardo said, “You are both ruining this map.”

Natalie handed the pencil back.

“Your map was lying.”

“It was not lying.”

“The line changed by itself?”

“I changed it.”

“With no new thing.”

“There was reasoning.”

“Then write the reasoning.”

“On the map?”

“Somewhere.”

“That would be a book.”

Yichen lifted her notebook slightly.

Ricardo looked at it.

“No.”

* * *

That night Natalie sent a photograph to the group.

It was not a map.

It was a blank piece of paper with two short lines drawn near the top.

One was continuous.

One was broken.

Beside the first she had written:

we have something for this

Beside the second:

it works but we dont know

Ricardo replied first.

this is horrible

Natalie: thank you

Ricardo: the second one is not a category

Natalie: it literally is

Yichen: I like it.

Ricardo: of course you do

Natalie: what do you want instead

Ricardo: real / possible

Yichen: No.

Ricardo: why

Yichen: A memory can be wrong.

There was no answer for a while.

Natalie: supported / possible

Ricardo: supported by what

Natalie: something

Ricardo: great

Yichen: That is better.

Natalie: solid = something

dots = maybe

Ricardo: weve invented language

Natalie: youre welcome

Yichen: Use that.

Ricardo: i am not writing “something” on a map key

Natalie: coward

Yichen: Yes.

Ricardo: that wasnt even you

Yichen: I know.

* * *

The next map had a key.

It did not say something.

In the lower right corner Ricardo had drawn:

— supported

- - possible

Natalie replied:

look at you

Ricardo: dont

Yichen: Supported by what?

Ricardo: oh my god

Natalie: she has a point

Ricardo: photo / all 3 / record / whatever

Yichen: Those are different.

Ricardo did not answer.

Ten minutes later another photograph appeared.

Below the key he had added:

see notes

Natalie: there are notes now

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: how many pages

Ricardo: one

Yichen: Send it.

Ricardo: why

Yichen: Because you wrote “see notes.”

Ricardo sent the page.

There were seven entries.

A — photo, possible tower

B — all remember road after

C — Natalie time

D — route only

E — old turn guesses

F — gas station / recognized area

G — construction possible, not route evidence

Natalie replied:

C what

Ricardo: 10:51

Natalie: thats photo time not route

Several seconds passed.

Then Ricardo:

fine

A new photograph arrived.

C — photo at 10:51

Natalie: yes

Yichen: B what road?

Ricardo: the normal one

Yichen: Name?

Ricardo: we dont know

Yichen: Then “road after” is enough.

Ricardo: this is why normal people dont do this

Natalie: normal people werent on the bus

Nothing came for a while.

Then Ricardo:

unfortunately

* * *

The lines spread into their messages.

Not immediately.

At first only Ricardo used them.

A week later he sent:

service road is dotted again

Natalie: why

Ricardo: gate

Yichen: Current gate.

Ricardo: yes

Natalie: so

Ricardo: so maybe

Another day:

laundromat location still dotted

Then:

tower circle stays

Then:

exit is not even dotted

Natalie: what is less than dotted

Ricardo: nothing

Yichen: Good.

Ricardo: stop

Some messages had nothing to do with the bus.

Natalie sent a photograph of a plate with one pancake left on it.

someone ordered six

Ricardo: solid or dotted

Natalie: i watched it happen

Yichen: Supported.

Natalie: both of you shut up

Another night Owen sent Ricardo something about a game.

Ricardo answered him.

The bus group stayed quiet.

Two days later Yichen sent:

Did the man get on before Keller or after?

Ricardo: before

Natalie: dotted

Ricardo: why

Natalie: because you just answered in 1 second

Ricardo: thats not evidence

Natalie: exactly

Yichen: I have Keller after.

Ricardo: see

Yichen: But I don’t know why.

No one answered.

A minute later:

Ricardo: then dotted

Yichen: I wasn’t asking about the map.

Ricardo: i know

The message remained there.

* * *

By February the newest map was cleaner than the one from January.

It was also less complete.

A short solid section near the end showed the road they had all agreed they recognized.

Another mark belonged to the photograph.

Most of the middle was broken.

Some parts were not connected at all.

The old black route could still be seen faintly under one section where Ricardo had erased it.

Gray remained between the dots.

Natalie placed her notebook beside it.

Yichen put hers on the other side.

They were sitting in the library this time.

Nobody had planned to meet for long.

Natalie had homework open under her notebook.

Yichen had a library book face down beside her elbow.

Ricardo had brought the folder.

He pointed at a broken section.

“If this is wrong, the whole middle goes.”

Natalie said, “Okay.”

“That’s all?”

“What do you want me to say?”

“That it matters.”

“It matters.”

“You said okay.”

“I can say it louder.”

Yichen looked at the map.

“What makes it wrong?”

Ricardo said, “Nothing yet.”

“Then why are we talking about it?”

“Because if I move the laundromat again—”

Natalie looked up.

“Again?”

“Yes.”

“Where?”

Ricardo pointed.

The new oval was farther north.

Yichen said, “Why?”

“There’s an old commercial strip there.”

Natalie said, “Did you find a laundromat?”

“No.”

“Then dotted.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“It isn’t a route.”

“You know what I mean.”

“No, actually.”

Natalie took his pencil.

She drew a dotted outline around the new location.

Ricardo stared at it.

“You can’t dot a circle.”

“I just did.”

“That’s disgusting.”

Yichen said, “I understand it.”

“Of course you do.”

Natalie put down the pencil.

“There.”

Ricardo looked at the dotted oval.

Then at the older solid-edged oval beneath it.

He erased the older one.

Natalie said, “Why?”

“It’s not better.”

“The new one?”

“The old one.”

“Because?”

Ricardo pointed at the notes page.

“Nothing supports it.”

Nobody answered.

He finished erasing.

A pale oval remained in the paper.

Yichen opened her notebook.

“What about Keller?”

Ricardo said, “What about it?”

“You moved it.”

“I moved the possible store.”

“Why?”

“There are industrial buildings there.”

“Keller?”

“No.”

“Then why Keller?”

“I wrote a question mark.”

Yichen looked at the map.

There was a small K? beside a dotted side street.

She said, “Okay.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“That’s it?”

“Yes.”

“You usually make this harder.”

“I’m trying something new.”

Natalie said, “Supported.”

Yichen nodded.

“Possible.”

Ricardo put his pencil down.

“You made the words worse.”

* * *

They stayed a while longer.

Nothing was solved.

Natalie found that the 10:52 message still did not say where any of them were.

Ricardo found another possible street and left it off the map because it required moving both circles.

Yichen crossed out before Keller beside the man and replaced it with:

relative order?

At one point Natalie looked at the page.

“That is ugly.”

Yichen said, “Yes.”

“You could just write you don’t know.”

“I did.”

“Where?”

Yichen pointed to the question mark.

“That is one question mark.”

“Yes.”

Natalie looked at Ricardo.

“This is your fault.”

Ricardo said, “I didn’t invent question marks.”

“You made us need a legend.”

“I made a map.”

Yichen said, “Same problem.”

Ricardo looked at her.

She turned a page.

He picked up his pencil again.

* * *

Near closing, Ricardo took a photograph of the map.

The library lights reflected faintly across the table.

His phone cast a shadow over one corner.

He checked the photograph.

Took another.

Natalie packed her notebook.

Yichen put on her coat.

Ricardo was still looking at the screen.

Natalie said, “Are you sending it?”

“Yes.”

“To us?”

“Yes.”

“We are here.”

“So?”

“You can show us.”

“You’ve seen it.”

“Then why send it?”

Ricardo looked at her.

“For later.”

Natalie zipped her bag.

“Okay.”

He sent it.

All three phones vibrated within a second of one another.

Yichen took hers out.

The photograph filled the group.

The route was mostly broken lines.

A few small pieces were solid.

Two circles were dotted.

One was not.

Question marks remained.

In the lower corner was the key.

— supported

- - possible

Below it:

see notes

Yichen enlarged the photograph.

Natalie looked over her shoulder.

Ricardo put the paper map back into the folder.

Yichen said, “This one.”

Ricardo stopped.

“What?”

She pointed at the phone.

A short segment near the skeleton circle was solid.

Ricardo leaned closer.

“So?”

“What supports it?”

He looked at the paper again.

Opened the folder.

Found the notes page.

Ran one finger down it.

Stopped.

Natalie waited.

Ricardo looked at the map.

Then at the phone.

“I don’t know.”

No one said anything.

He took the pencil.

The three of them were still standing.

Ricardo erased the line.

It did not disappear completely.

A gray mark stayed beneath it.

He redrew the segment with gaps.

Yichen looked at it.

Natalie put her gloves on.

Ricardo closed the folder.

“Done.”

Natalie said, “For now.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“Fine.”

Yichen opened the library door.

Cold air came in before any of them stepped outside.

Ricardo held the door after her.

Natalie walked through.

The folder stayed under his arm.

The map inside had more empty space than the one he had brought in.

CHAPTER EIGHT

By April, the bus group could go a week without saying anything about the bus.

Then somebody would send a photograph.

Or a question.

Or:

does this road look familiar

And the group would move back to the top of three phones.

On one Saturday afternoon, Ricardo was at the McDonald's near River Road with Owen.

Owen had finished his burger and was reaching for Ricardo's fries.

Ricardo moved the carton.

"Buy your own."

"I did."

"Then eat yours."

"I did."

Owen reached again.

Ricardo moved the fries farther away.

A folder was on the chair beside him.

Owen looked at it.

"No."

Ricardo looked up.

"What?"

"Nothing."

The door opened.

Natalie came in first.

She had a paper cup in one hand and a bag over one shoulder.

Yichen followed her.

Owen stopped with one hand still extended across the table.

He looked at Ricardo.

"No."

Ricardo looked at him.

“What?”

“These are the bus people?”

Natalie reached the table.

“Nice to meet you too.”

Owen sat back.

“I didn’t mean—”

“You did.”

“Okay.”

Ricardo moved the folder off the empty chair.

Yichen put her bag there instead.

Owen looked from Natalie to Yichen.

Then at Ricardo.

“You’re still doing this?”

Ricardo said, “Not really.”

Natalie sat down.

“Sometimes.”

Yichen pulled out the chair beside her.

“He is.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“You came.”

“Yes.”

“That means you’re doing it too.”

“No.”

Natalie took the lid off her cup.

Owen looked at all three of them.

“This is not what stopped looks like.”

Nobody answered.

He reached for a fry.

Ricardo let him take one.

* * *

The map came out after Natalie had finished half her coffee.

It was not the map from January.

Two sheets had been replaced by three.

The tape along one edge had started to lift.

River Road ran down the right side.

Mannheim was marked farther west.

The railway crossed part of the page.

I-294 cut through another section.

A small circle sat near the possible water tower.

A larger dotted oval marked the laundromat.

Several routes stopped halfway.

Others ended in crosses.

Most of the middle was broken lines.

In the lower corner:

— supported

- - possible

Below that:

see notes

Owen leaned over.

“What am I looking at?”

Ricardo said, “Possible routes.”

Yichen looked at the map.

“Some of them.”

Owen looked at her.

“Some of the possible routes?”

“Yes.”

“That made it worse.”

Natalie took a drink.

Ricardo pointed at one broken line.

“This one gets around the railway.”

“Okay.”

“But it puts the laundromat too far south.”

Owen looked at the dotted oval.

“So move that.”

Natalie said, “We did.”

“Then what’s the problem?”

Ricardo pointed farther north.

“It was there before.”

Owen waited.

Yichen said, “Maybe.”

“Why did you move it?”

Ricardo turned the map slightly.

“Because there’s an older commercial strip here.”

“Was there a laundromat?”

“No.”

Owen looked at Natalie.

She said, “That’s why it’s dotted.”

He looked back at the map.

“So dotted means wrong.”

“No,” Ricardo said.

“Possible,” Natalie said.

Yichen said, “Not enough to make it solid.”

Owen looked at her.

“That sounds different from possible.”

“Yes.”

Ricardo pointed to the key.

“It says possible.”

Owen read it again.

“Why did I ask?”

Natalie smiled into her cup.

* * *

Owen kept looking at the map.

He turned it once so the labels faced him.

“What’s S?”

“Skeleton.”

“Why not write skeleton?”

Ricardo looked at the page.

“It takes up space.”

Owen pointed at the larger oval.

“And L?”

“Laundromat.”

“So you’ll write supported, possible and see notes, but not laundromat.”

“Yes.”

“Okay.”

He pointed at a mark farther south.

“K question mark.”

Ricardo moved his hand before Owen touched it.

“Keller.”

“Keller what?”

There was a pause.

Yichen said, “Something.”

Owen looked at her.

“That’s the name?”

“No.”

Natalie said, “That’s approximately how much we know.”

Ricardo said, “It was Keller.”

Yichen looked at him.

“Keller something.”

“Yes.”

“That’s different.”

Ricardo looked at Owen.

“This is why it takes forever.”

Owen nodded.

“I’m starting to understand.”

He pointed at the skeleton circle.

“When was that?”

Ricardo looked at Natalie.

She had not moved.

“Ten fifty-one.”

Owen looked at Ricardo.

“You didn’t know that?”

“I know it.”

“You looked at her.”

“She was sitting there.”

Natalie put her cup down.

“No, you looked at me because I wrote those down.”

Ricardo said nothing.

Owen looked at the margin of the map.

There were three times written together.

10:28 — already on

10:51 — skeleton photo

10:52 — sent

Below them were questions.

phone time wrong?

exit before 11?

Owen pointed.

“Ten twenty-eight is when you got on?”

Natalie said, “No.”

“When was it?”

“I don’t know.”

“But it says—”

“It says I was already on.”

Owen read the line again.

“Right.”

Ricardo said, “See?”

Owen looked at him.

“I was talking to her.”

“I know.”

Owen pointed at the skeleton circle.

“Where was the picture?”

Natalie looked at Ricardo.

Owen saw her do it.

Ricardo pulled the map closer.

“Somewhere around here if that’s actually the water tower.”

Yichen said, “If.”

Ricardo kept his finger on the page.

Owen looked at the circle.

Then at Natalie.

Then Ricardo.

“What did the woman say again?”

Ricardo said, “Not yet.”

Yichen said, “That part is right.”

Owen looked at her.

“And the driver?”

“‘You sure?’”

“And she said yes?”

“Yes.”

Owen sat back.

He looked at Natalie.

Then Ricardo.

Then Yichen.

“Okay.”

Nobody said anything.

Owen pointed at Natalie.

“You have the times.”

Then Ricardo.

“You have the map.”

Then Yichen.

“And you have what everybody said.”

Yichen looked at him.

“Not exactly.”

Owen closed his eyes.

Ricardo laughed.

Natalie picked up her coffee again.

Owen opened his eyes.

“What?”

Yichen opened her notebook.

“I write down what we said we remember.”

“That is what I just said.”

“No.”

Owen waited.

“So what do you have?”

“What we said we remember.”

Owen looked at the notebook.

Then at her.

“Okay.”

“That’s different.”

“Okay.”

He turned to Ricardo.

“So she has what everybody said.”

Yichen closed the notebook.

Natalie smiled into her coffee.

Ricardo said, “Basically.”

Yichen looked at him.

He added, “Not exactly.”

Owen nodded.

“Great.”

* * *

Owen tried once more to understand the current explanation.

“What’s the best one?”

Ricardo looked at the map.

“Construction is real.”

Owen nodded.

“Good.”

“A detour is possible.”

“Okay.”

“Maybe a service road for part of it.”

“Less good.”

Natalie said, “The service road is still possible.”

Yichen said, “The laundromat location is still possible too.”

Owen looked at the dotted oval.

“Those are different possible?”

“Yes,” Natalie said.

Ricardo said, “Kind of.”

Yichen said, “Yes.”

Owen looked at all three.

Ricardo continued.

“And the mixed-streets explanation still works.”

“What is that?”

“That we put different normal places together in memory.”

Owen waited.

“So your best explanation is construction that may not matter, a road you may not have used, a laundromat you can’t place, and maybe remembering several streets as one.”

Ricardo looked at Natalie.

Natalie looked at Yichen.

Yichen said, “Approximately.”

Owen sat back.

“I understand less after asking.”

Ricardo folded one side of the map over.

“That’s normal.”

* * *

The map stayed folded for a while after that.

Natalie asked Owen what school he went to.

He answered.

Yichen asked whether he still played the game Ricardo had been playing the night of the bus.

Owen looked at Ricardo.

“You told them that?”

Ricardo said, “It came up.”

“How?”

Nobody answered.

Owen waited.

Natalie took a drink.

Yichen looked toward the windows.

Ricardo folded the corner of a napkin.

Owen looked at all three.

“This is the weirdest friendship I’ve ever seen.”

Natalie said, “We’re not—”

She stopped.

Owen waited.

Natalie put the cup down.

Yichen looked from Natalie to Ricardo.

Ricardo unfolded the corner of the napkin.

Owen said, “Okay.”

No one corrected him.

Outside, a bus stopped near the curb.

Two people got off.

Several others boarded.

The doors closed.

The bus continued north.

Owen watched it until it passed the window.

Then he looked back at the table.

“So how often do you actually meet?”

Ricardo said, “Not that often.”

Natalie said, “Less now.”

Yichen nodded.

“How much less?”

Nobody answered.

Owen looked at Natalie.

She looked back.

“What?”

“I thought you had the times.”

Natalie stared at him.

Ricardo laughed.

Yichen looked down at her notebook.

Owen smiled.

“That was good.”

Natalie said, “Once.”

“Fine.”

* * *

A little later, Owen unfolded the map again.

“So you never found the driver?”

Ricardo shook his head.

“No.”

“The actual bus?”

“We know what route we were supposed to be on,” Natalie said.

Owen looked at her.

“That’s not what I asked.”

Yichen looked at Owen.

He looked back.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

Owen pointed at her.

“I’m getting good at this.”

“No,” Ricardo said.

“Possible,” Natalie said.

Owen looked at her.

She smiled.

He pointed at the map again.

“What about the house with the skeleton?”

Ricardo said, “Nothing.”

Yichen looked at him.

Ricardo stopped.

Then:

“We don’t have the house.”

Owen looked at Yichen.

She nodded once.

Ricardo said, “Don’t encourage him.”

“I didn’t.”

“You nodded.”

“Yes.”

“That’s encouraging.”

“No.”

Owen reached for another fry.

The carton was empty.

He looked inside anyway.

* * *

His phone vibrated not long after.

Owen read the message.

“My mom’s outside.”

Ricardo looked toward the parking lot.

A car had pulled in near the edge.

Owen stood.

Natalie moved her bag so he could get past.

He put on his jacket.

Then stopped at the end of the table.

“So what happens if you actually solve it?”

Ricardo looked at him.

“What?”

“The bus.”

Natalie looked down at the folded map.

Yichen kept one hand on her notebook.

Owen waited.

Ricardo said, “Then we know.”

“Know what?”

No one answered.

A child at the next table dropped a plastic spoon.

His mother picked it up.

Someone near the counter called a number.

Owen waited another second.

Then nodded.

“Good system.”

He started toward the door.

Ricardo said, “You’re annoying.”

Owen turned around while walking backward.

“Ask Yichen if you said that.”

Yichen said, “You did.”

Owen pointed at her.

“See?”

The door opened behind him.

Cold air moved into the restaurant.

Then he was outside.

* * *

The three of them stayed.

Ricardo opened the folder again.

Natalie pulled the map toward herself.

Yichen turned to a clean page.

No one mentioned Owen for a while.

Ricardo pointed at the laundromat oval.

“This is still too far south.”

Natalie said, “Possible.”

“I know.”

Yichen wrote something.

Ricardo looked at her.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“That means something.”

Yichen moved the notebook away.

Natalie said, “You taught him that.”

“I did not.”

“You absolutely did.”

Ricardo took the pencil.

He moved one dotted line.

Stopped.

Put it back where it had been.

Natalie looked at the three times in the margin.

Yichen crossed out one question mark and wrote another beside a different line.

Outside, another bus passed without stopping.

They stayed until Natalie checked her phone and put on her coat.

Yichen closed the notebook.

Ricardo folded the map.

At the door Natalie went one way.

Yichen another.

Ricardo stood outside for a moment with the folder under his arm.

Then he walked north.

* * *

Two days later Ricardo sent the group a screenshot.

when was this

Yichen replied:

talk to timestamps

There was no answer for a while.

Then Natalie:

9:14

Ricardo: see

Natalie: shut up

No one mentioned Owen.

CHAPTER NINE

Three weeks after Owen met them, Natalie sent a cropped photograph of the map.

One road was circled.

which one is this

Yichen replied first.

Map department.

Ricardo:

dont call me that

Natalie:

answer the question

Ricardo:

road by the gas station

Natalie:

does it go north

Ricardo:

no

Natalie:

you checked

Ricardo: yes

Natalie:

okay

Yichen:

Which part of the route is it supposed to be?

Ricardo sent another image.

The same road was circled beside a broken section of the route.

Yichen:

After the man got on?

There was a pause.

Ricardo:

probably

Yichen:

Then I don’t know if it was that road.

Natalie:

why

Yichen:

We don’t know where he got on.

Ricardo:

right

A minute later he sent the map again.

The circle was gone.

Natalie:

okay

No one asked Ricardo whether the road really failed to connect.

The group stayed quiet for the rest of the day.

* * *

By June, ordinary things appeared more often in the same group.

Natalie sent a photograph of a receipt that read:

2 COFFEE

1 PIE

7 KETCHUP

Ricardo:

who needs 7 ketchup

Natalie:

apparently table 4

Yichen:

That is not seven packets.

Natalie:

yes it is

Yichen:

It says seven orders.

Ricardo:

dont

Natalie:

youre banned from receipts

The bus did not come up.

Almost two weeks later Natalie sent:

im off saturday

Ricardo:

good for you

Natalie:

do either of you want food

There was no answer for a while.

Then Yichen:

Where?

Natalie named a pizza place near Irving Park Road.

Ricardo:

what time

Yichen:

Ask timestamps.

Natalie:

youre both annoying

Then:

2

Ricardo:

ill be there

Yichen:

Me too.

No one mentioned the bus.

* * *

Ricardo arrived carrying only his phone and keys.

Natalie looked at his hands before he sat down.

“You didn’t bring it.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“What?”

“The map.”

“No.”

Yichen had already taken a menu.

She looked up.

“Good.”

Ricardo pulled out the chair across from her.

“I wasn’t going to.”

Natalie sat beside Yichen.

“You usually do.”

“That is not the same as always.”

Yichen opened the menu.

“Correct.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“Thank you.”

“That wasn’t support.”

Natalie laughed.

He sat down.

There was nothing on the table except menus, napkins and a metal shaker of red pepper.

Ricardo looked at the empty middle.

Natalie looked at him.

“No.”

“I didn’t say anything.”

“You looked.”

“At the table?”

“Yes.”

“That’s what tables are for.”

Yichen turned a page of the menu.

“For looking at?”

Ricardo looked at her.

She did not look up.

Natalie laughed again.

A server came over.

They ordered.

The server left.

For several seconds, no one said anything.

Ricardo picked up the pepper shaker.

Put it down.

Natalie looked toward the window.

Yichen folded the corner of a paper placemat.

Then Natalie said, “So how bad were the exams?”

Yichen looked at her.

“Which one?”

“All of them.”

“They were fine.”

“That means bad,” Ricardo said.

“No.”

“You always say fine when something is bad.”

Yichen looked at him.

“No, I don’t.”

“Give me an example.”

Ricardo opened his mouth.

Stopped.

Natalie said, “Don’t ask her for evidence.”

Yichen smiled.

Ricardo leaned back.

“This is impossible.”

The food came.

For a while they talked about school.

Not the bus.

Natalie told them about a man who had sent back toast because it was “too rectangular.”

Ricardo said that could not have been the actual complaint.

“It was.”

“Those exact words?”

Natalie looked at Yichen.

Yichen raised both hands.

“I wasn’t there.”

Ricardo said, “Convenient.”

Yichen took a slice of pizza.

Natalie said, “He said, ‘I don’t like how rectangular this is.’”

Ricardo looked at her.

“Exactly?”

“Yes.”

Yichen chewed.

Then said, “Maybe.”

Natalie pointed at her.

“No.”

Yichen smiled.

They talked about Owen.

Ricardo told them he had tried to return a game and discovered it had been in the wrong case for almost a year.

Natalie said, “How?”

“He doesn’t look at anything.”

“You hang out with him.”

“I know.”

Yichen said, “Maybe that explains you.”

Ricardo stopped eating.

Natalie put her pizza down and laughed.

Ricardo looked from one to the other.

“I invited neither of you into my life.”

Natalie said, “You literally did.”

“When?”

She reached for her phone.

Ricardo pointed at it.

“No.”

She left it on the table.

“Fine.”

Yichen said, “You asked for my number on the bus.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“You asked for mine.”

“No.”

Natalie looked between them.

“Oh no.”

Ricardo said, “You definitely did.”

Yichen put her pizza down.

“You said we should exchange numbers.”

“That is asking.”

“It is suggesting.”

“That is the same thing.”

“No.”

Natalie covered her face with one hand.

“No bus.”

They stopped.

Ricardo picked up his pizza again.

Yichen reached for a napkin.

For several minutes they talked about something else.

* * *

Later, Natalie mentioned a customer who had missed his stop on the Blue Line and ended up farther west than he meant to.

Ricardo said, “How far?”

Natalie looked at him.

He stopped.

Yichen looked down at her plate.

Ricardo said, “Normal question.”

Natalie smiled.

“I know.”

The conversation continued.

A family left the table beside them.

Two people came in.

The server refilled their drinks.

Ricardo asked Yichen whether she had decided what she was doing during the summer.

She said maybe visiting family for part of August.

Natalie said she would probably work more.

Ricardo said Owen wanted to drive to Wisconsin for no reason.

“For no reason?” Yichen asked.

“Yes.”

“Where?”

“He doesn’t know.”

Natalie looked at Ricardo.

Yichen looked at Ricardo.

Ricardo looked at both of them.

“No.”

Natalie started laughing.

“I didn’t say anything.”

“You were both about to.”

“We weren’t,” Yichen said.

“You were.”

Natalie said, “You should ask him to make a map.”

Ricardo threw a folded napkin at her.

It missed.

* * *

They stayed after the plates had been cleared.

No one brought out a notebook.

No map appeared.

Natalie’s phone stayed face down beside her cup.

Yichen’s bag remained under her chair.

Ricardo had nothing on the table except his keys.

The conversation slowed.

Then stopped.

The server walked past without asking whether they wanted anything else.

Ricardo looked out the window.

Across the street, cars moved through the intersection.

Natalie tapped one finger against her cup.

Yichen looked at the empty plates.

Then she said, “Did we ever decide whether Keller was before the man?”

Ricardo looked back.

Natalie stopped tapping.

“Keller,” Ricardo said.

Yichen looked at him.

“What?”

“Keller was first.”

Natalie said, “No.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“What do you mean, no?”

“I mean no bus.”

“Yichen asked.”

“I know.”

Yichen said, “I shouldn’t have.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“Why?”

“Because now you’re doing it.”

“I answered a question.”

Yichen shook her head.

“You think Keller was first?”

“Yes.”

“Do you remember that?”

Ricardo did not answer.

Yichen continued.

“Or is that where you put it on the map?”

Ricardo looked at the table.

Natalie said, “No.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“Again?”

“We’re not doing this.”

“I just want to know.”

“That is doing it.”

Yichen folded the corner of the placemat the other way.

“I don’t remember which was first.”

Ricardo looked at her.

Then at Natalie.

Natalie did not reach for her phone.

Ricardo did not take his out.

After a while Natalie said, “There was a movie I meant to ask if either of you saw.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“Which one?”

“The one with the train.”

“That narrows it down.”

“It was new.”

“That narrows it down less.”

Natalie tried to say the title.

Stopped.

“No. Never mind.”

Yichen said, “Good description.”

“Thank you.”

They spent the next few minutes naming movies.

None was the one Natalie meant.

* * *

Three days later Ricardo sent:

keller / man order

Natalie:

no

Yichen:

We don’t know.

Ricardo:

thats what im writing

Then:

so we dont forget that we dont know

There was no answer for a while.

Yichen:

That is actually useful.

Natalie:

unfortunately

Ricardo:

thank you

Nothing was added to the map.

* * *

In July, Ricardo sent a new version of the route.

There was less on it than before.

Natalie replied:

this one looks empty

Ricardo:

because most of it is not supported

Yichen:

Good.

Ricardo:

dont

Natalie:

growth

The laundromat remained an oval.

The skeleton remained a circle.

Keller remained:

K?

The woman had no point.

The man had no point.

The turn had three possibilities.

Several roads that had once been drawn in black had disappeared completely.

Natalie asked:

did you check if this connects

She circled a road in the screenshot.

Ricardo:

no

A few minutes later:

doesnt

Natalie:

okay

Yichen:

How far off?

Ricardo:

enough

Yichen:

That isn’t a distance.

Ricardo:

map department says enough

Natalie:

very scientific

Ricardo sent nothing else.

* * *

In August, Yichen went away for nine days.

She sent one photograph to the group.

A lake.

No caption.

Natalie:

nice

Ricardo:

where

There was no answer until later.

Then Yichen sent the name of the town.

Ricardo:

why didnt you just say that

Yichen:

You didn’t ask.

Natalie:

he literally did

Yichen:

He asked where.

Ricardo:

yes

Yichen:

The lake or me?

Ricardo:

both

Natalie:

dont encourage this

The bus did not come up.

* * *

By September, they had stopped meeting regularly.

There had been no decision.

Natalie had more shifts.

Yichen had school.

Ricardo saw Owen more often than either of them.

The bus group sometimes went two weeks without a message.

Then somebody would send something unrelated.

One evening Natalie sent:

someone ordered coffee with no cup

Ricardo:

what

Natalie:

asked for coffee

then said no cup

Yichen:

What did he want it in?

Natalie:

his thermos

Ricardo:

thats normal

Natalie:

he did not have a thermos

There was a pause.

Yichen:

Then I have questions.

Ricardo:

write them down

Natalie:

see notes

Yichen:

Both of you stop.

The next morning Ricardo sent:

supported: man wanted coffee

Natalie:

possible: man had plan

Yichen:

unsupported: either of you is funny

The group stayed active for the rest of the morning.

None of it was about the bus.

* * *

A few days later Ricardo sent an older Street View image.

A low building stood beside a wide road.

The sign could not be read.

could be keller

Natalie:

can you read it

Ricardo:

no

Yichen did not answer until the next afternoon.

Neither can I.

Ricardo:

okay

The image stayed in the group.

No one put it in the notes.

No one printed it.

No one circled the building.

Nothing else was said about it.

* * *

Near the end of October, Ricardo sent a message late in the evening.

its been a year

Natalie replied:

no it hasnt

Ricardo:

yes it has

Natalie:

tomorrow

There was a pause.

Ricardo:

seriously

Natalie:

yes

Ricardo:

how do you know

Nothing appeared for a while.

Then Natalie sent a screenshot.

The image showed the information panel from the skeleton photograph.

The date was from the previous October.

The time read:

10:51 PM

Ricardo:

of course

Natalie:

you asked

Yichen:

He did.

Ricardo:

fine

Then:

almost a year

Natalie:

yes

Ricardo:

better

A few seconds later:

see this is why you have the times

Natalie:

shut up

Ricardo:

supported

Natalie:

im leaving

Nothing came for several minutes.

Then Yichen sent:

Do we still care?

Ricardo:

i do

Natalie:

apparently

There was another pause.

Yichen:

That wasn’t my question.

Ricardo’s typing indicator appeared.

Stopped.

Natalie’s appeared.

Stopped.

Nothing else came.

CHAPTER TEN

For most of 2016, nothing new happened.

The group did not disappear.

It became quieter.

In January, Ricardo sent a map with two roads crossed out.

Natalie:

better

Yichen:

Why?

Ricardo:

because neither works

Yichen:

Then yes.

In March, Natalie found an older message and sent a screenshot.

this was before the photo

Ricardo:

how much before

Natalie:

dont know

Ricardo:

useful

Natalie:

accurate

Yichen:

She has you now.

Ricardo:

unfortunately

In May, Yichen sent:

Do either of you remember whether the man sat down?

Ricardo:

yes

Natalie:

i think

Yichen:

Where?

There was no answer.

Several minutes later Ricardo:

no idea

Natalie:

same

Yichen:

Okay.

Nothing was added to the notes.

In July, Ricardo sent a photograph of a road.

Natalie replied the next morning.

no

Yichen did not reply.

In September, Natalie sent a photograph of a dog asleep under one of the tables at work.

Ricardo:

supported

Yichen:

Leave the dog alone.

The bus did not come up.

By winter, the group could go several weeks without moving.

Then one of them would ask something.

The answer usually came.

Sometimes several hours later.

Sometimes the next day.

* * *

The maps changed more than the conversation did.

Ricardo stopped sending photographs of paper.

The newer versions were cleaner.

Road names were typed.

Possible routes were thinner.

Confirmed roads were darker.

Question marks appeared beside some locations.

Others disappeared.

The laundromat remained uncertain.

The skeleton remained fixed to the photograph, not to a house.

The turn remained unresolved.

Keller changed slowly.

First:

K?

Then:

Keller

By 2017, one version of the timeline read:

KELLER & SONS

No question mark followed it.

Below that:

MAN BOARDS

Then:

“NOT YET”

No one commented on the change.

* * *

Almost three years after the bus, Ricardo sent two words to the group.

found something

The previous message was more than three weeks old.

Natalie answered two hours later.

what

Ricardo sent a PDF.

It was an archived construction notice from October 2014.

The first page showed a road closure.

The second showed temporary traffic routing around it.

Ricardo had drawn a red line over the diagram.

It bent around the closed section, continued west, then came back toward River Road.

A second image followed.

His current bus map.

The same red line had been placed over one of its blank sections.

Natalie:

where did you get this

Ricardo sent the archive link.

Then:

look at the date

Natalie:

i am

There was no reply from Yichen.

Ricardo:

it fixes the entrance

Natalie:

maybe

Ricardo:

why maybe

Natalie:

because this proves the road was closed

Then:

not that our bus used this

Ricardo:

yes

A minute later:

but the timing works

Natalie did not answer immediately.

Then:

it doesnt break it

Ricardo:

exactly

Natalie:

not the same sentence

Ricardo:

youve all become the same person

Natalie:

good

The group went quiet again.

Yichen replied the next morning.

What are you trying to prove?

Ricardo:

that this could be the detour

Yichen:

Okay.

Ricardo:

thats it

Yichen:

What?

Ricardo:

okay

Yichen:

I said it could be.

Ricardo:

yes

Yichen:

Not that it was.

Ricardo:

i know

There was a pause.

Then Ricardo sent another image.

This one showed only the red route.

Near one end he had written:

TURN?

Near the other:

WOMAN

Yichen:

Why is she there?

Ricardo:

because this only works if the turn was before she looked up

No reply.

Ricardo:

was it

Yichen:

I don’t know.

Ricardo:

you said before

Yichen:

When?

Ricardo did not answer for several minutes.

Then he sent a screenshot of an older message.

The date was from 2015.

Yichen’s message read:

I think the driver had already turned.

Ricardo:

there

Yichen:

Then I said it in 2015.

Ricardo:

you were there

Yichen:

So were you.

Ricardo:

i was asleep

Yichen:

Exactly.

Nothing came for a while.

Then Natalie:

you remember that stuff better than we do

Yichen:

What stuff?

Natalie:

people

Yichen:

That’s not an answer.

Natalie:

you know what i mean

The typing indicator appeared beside Yichen’s name.

Disappeared.

Appeared again.

Then:

No.

Natalie:

come on

Yichen:

You keep asking me what he meant.

Ricardo:

because you notice that stuff

Yichen:

I notice what people do.

Ricardo:

fine

Yichen:

That is not the same thing.

Ricardo did not answer.

Natalie:

nobody said it was

Yichen:

You do every time you ask me.

Natalie:

ask you what

Yichen:

Did he know her.

Then:

Was he scared.

Then:

Why did she look at him.

Ricardo:

those are normal questions

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

so

Yichen:

They are still questions.

Ricardo:

then tell me what you actually remember

Yichen:

I already did.

Ricardo:

when

Yichen:

Three years ago.

There was no message for almost a minute.

Then Yichen:

Why do you keep asking?

Ricardo:

because we find new things

Yichen:

The new things don’t change what I saw.

Ricardo:

they can change what it means

Yichen:

Exactly.

Ricardo:

what is that supposed to mean

Yichen:

You ask me again every time the answer you want changes.

Ricardo:

i dont want an answer

Yichen:

Okay.

Ricardo:

i want to know what happened

Yichen:

Okay.

Ricardo:

stop saying okay

No answer.

Natalie:

nobodys making you answer

Yichen:

You are.

Natalie:

how

Yichen:

Because every time I say I don’t know, you ask again in a different way.

Natalie:

thats not making you answer

Yichen:

Then why do you ask again?

Natalie did not reply.

Yichen sent another message.

Maybe I’m getting better at answering because you’ve given me three years of practice.

Ricardo:

thats not fair

Yichen:

Probably.

Natalie:

seriously

Yichen:

What?

Natalie:

you act like we made this your job

Yichen:

You did.

Natalie:

no we didnt

Yichen:

Then stop asking me what people meant.

Natalie:

fine

Yichen:

Okay.

Natalie:

and stop doing that

Yichen:

Doing what?

Natalie:

you know what

No answer came.

Then Yichen:

And you don’t remember times.

Natalie:

what

Yichen:

You look them up.

Natalie:

thats the point

Yichen:

I know.

Natalie:

then what are you talking about

Yichen:

You look at messages.

Then:

Photos.

Then:

Metadata.

Natalie:

yes

Yichen:

Then everybody says you remember when things happened.

Natalie:

because i do

There was a pause.

Yichen:

Now.

Nothing came for more than a minute.

Ricardo:

what does that even mean

Yichen:

It means she knows it now.

Natalie:

i knew some of it then

Yichen:

Some.

Natalie:

yes

Yichen:

That’s different.

Natalie:

i never said it wasnt

Yichen:

You just said you remember it.

Natalie:

I DO remember it

Yichen:

Now.

Natalie did not answer.

Ricardo:

this has nothing to do with the detour

Yichen:

It does.

Ricardo:

how

Yichen:

Look at your timeline.

Ricardo:

what about it

Yichen:

Keller before the man.

Ricardo:

yes

Yichen:

We didn’t know that.

Ricardo:

yes we did

Yichen:

No.

Ricardo:

you literally said store then man

Yichen:

I said I think so.

Ricardo:

same thing

Yichen:

No.

Natalie:

wait

No one sent anything for several seconds.

Then Natalie:

we wrote this down

Ricardo:

what

Natalie sent a screenshot.

It was from 2015.

keller / man order

Below it:

Yichen: We don’t know.

Then:

Ricardo: thats what im writing

Then:

so we dont forget that we dont know

No message appeared for a while.

Ricardo:

before that she said store then man

Yichen:

I think so.

Ricardo:

yes

Yichen:

You keep removing that part.

Ricardo:

because we have like five versions

Yichen:

Exactly.

Ricardo:

and this is the one that makes sense

Yichen:

That isn’t the same as remembering it.

Ricardo:

i know

Yichen:

Do you?

Ricardo:

yes

Natalie:

why does it say keller & sons now

Ricardo:

because thats what it was called

Yichen:

Was it?

Ricardo:

yes

Yichen:

How do you know?

Ricardo:

we all remember it

Natalie:

i remember keller

There was a pause.

Then:

i think it was keller & sons

Yichen:

You think.

Natalie:

yes

Ricardo:

we have been calling it that for years

Yichen:

That doesn’t make it older.

Ricardo:

what do you want me to call it

Yichen:

I don’t care.

Ricardo:

then why are we arguing about it

Yichen:

Because you asked what I remember.

Ricardo:

fine

Then:

forget keller

Natalie:

you cant say forget keller after three years of maps

Ricardo:

you know what i mean

Yichen:

Apparently.

Natalie:

okay both of you stop

Ricardo:

im trying to

Yichen:

So stop.

There was another pause.

Natalie sent:

youre the one drawing maps like you saw the turn

Ricardo:

what

Natalie:

you heard me

Ricardo:

i know where it had to be

Yichen:

Had to be.

Ricardo:

yes

Natalie:

you were asleep

Ricardo:

for two minutes

Yichen:

You don’t know that either.

No one replied.

The construction notice remained in the group.

So did Ricardo’s map.

In the image, the red detour curved through the blank section.

Below it, the timeline still read:

KELLER & SONS

MAN BOARDS

No new version appeared.

No one sent anything the next day.

Or the next week.

The group moved lower on three phones.

October ended.

Then November.

Then the year.

No one deleted the group.

No one added to it.

Eight months passed.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Eight months after the last message, Natalie sent two words.

found something

The message stayed alone for forty-three minutes.

Then Ricardo:

what

Natalie sent a photograph.

It showed a road behind a chain-link fence.

A warehouse occupied most of the left side. On the right, beyond a patch of dead grass, a full-size bus was turning through an opening in the fence.

The photograph was grainy.

The bus was partly hidden behind a parked truck.

Ricardo replied almost immediately.

where

Natalie:

look at the building

Ricardo:

i am

Another message:

where did you get this

Natalie sent a link.

The page had been uploaded in November 2014.

There were twelve photographs.

The one she had sent was number nine.

Under it was a caption:

back lot after rain

Nothing else identified the road.

Ricardo:

thats it

Natalie:

what is

Ricardo:

the service road

There was no reply.

A minute later:

Ricardo: the one we walked

Natalie:

i know

Ricardo:

then yes

Natalie:

i didnt say yes

Ricardo:

you found a bus on it

Natalie:

i found a photo with a bus

Ricardo:

on the road

Natalie:

probably

Ricardo:

why are you like this

Nothing came from Yichen.

Ricardo sent another message.

same warehouse

Then:

same fence

Then:

look at the corner

Natalie:

i did

Ricardo:

the gate is open

Natalie:

yes

Ricardo:

so buses could get through

Natalie:

a bus could

Ricardo:

thats what i said

Natalie:

no it isnt

The group went quiet again.

Three hours later, Yichen replied.

When was the photograph taken?

Natalie:

page went up november 18 2014

Yichen:

That isn’t what I asked.

There was a pause.

Natalie:

dont know

Ricardo:

its obviously around then

Yichen:

Probably.

Ricardo:

great

Yichen:

What?

Ricardo:

nothing

Another pause.

Then Ricardo:

does this road look familiar to you

Yichen did not answer for several minutes.

The fence does.

Ricardo:

yes

Yichen:

The building maybe.

Ricardo:

yes

Yichen:

I don’t remember the road looking like that.

Ricardo:

it was dark

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

and you were inside a bus

Yichen:

Also yes.

Natalie:

this is going well

Ricardo:

saturday

No one answered immediately.

Then:

Natalie: im working until 4

Ricardo:

after

Another minute.

Yichen:

Okay.

Ricardo:

okay

Natalie:

fine

No other message came that night.

* * *

Ricardo arrived at the McDonald’s at 4:38 on Saturday.

He chose the table farthest from the door.

There was nothing on it except his phone.

At 4:51 Natalie came in carrying a coat over one arm.

She stopped beside the table.

“Hi.”

“Hi.”

She sat down across from him.

Neither of them took out anything.

Ricardo looked toward the entrance.

Natalie put her coat over the empty chair beside her.

“You print it?”

“No.”

She looked at him.

“You didn’t?”

“I have it on my phone.”

“That’s unlike you.”

Ricardo put the phone on the table.

“Do you want me to print it?”

“No.”

“Okay.”

Natalie looked toward the counter.

“I’m getting food.”

“Okay.”

She stood.

Ricardo looked at his phone.

Natalie came back with fries and a drink.

Yichen arrived while she was opening a ketchup packet.

She had cut her hair.

Ricardo looked at it.

Yichen took off her coat.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

Natalie looked up.

“Oh.”

Yichen sat down.

“What?”

“You cut it.”

“Yes.”

“When?”

“February.”

Natalie nodded.

Ricardo looked at the table.

Yichen put her bag beneath the chair.

Natalie took a fry.

“Looks good.”

“Thank you.”

Ricardo picked up his phone.

Natalie looked at him.

“That was smooth.”

“What?”

“Nothing.”

Yichen said, “Show me the photograph.”

Ricardo unlocked the phone.

* * *

They enlarged it until the bus filled most of the screen.

Natalie pointed at the warehouse.

“That’s the same loading dock.”

Ricardo nodded.

“And this.”

He moved the photograph.

The image shifted to the right.

A utility pole stood near the fence.

He opened another photograph.

It was one he had taken when they walked the road three years earlier.

The pole was still there.

Natalie leaned closer.

Yichen moved her chair slightly.

Ricardo put the two images side by side.

“The fence is different.”

Natalie said, “A little.”

“There’s another gate now.”

“Or there was another gate then.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“Yes.”

Natalie waited.

He looked back at the phone.

“Yes.”

Yichen pointed at the older photograph.

“Can you tell which direction the bus is going?”

Ricardo enlarged it.

The picture blurred.

“No.”

“Could it be parked?”

“No.”

Natalie looked at him.

Ricardo enlarged it again.

“You can see the front wheels.”

“Can you?”

He handed her the phone.

Natalie stared at it.

Yichen took one of Natalie’s fries.

Natalie looked at her.

Yichen put it back.

“You already touched it.”

Yichen took it again.

Natalie returned to the photograph.

“I think they’re turned.”

Ricardo said, “Exactly.”

“I said think.”

He looked at her.

Natalie handed the phone back.

Ricardo said nothing.

Yichen watched the screen.

“The gate matters more.”

“Yes,” Ricardo said.

Natalie wiped salt from her fingers.

“It proves there was an opening.”

“In 2014.”

“It proves there was an opening when the picture was taken.”

Ricardo looked at her.

Natalie looked back.

He nodded once.

“Fine.”

Yichen pulled her chair closer.

“Do we know where the photographer was standing?”

Ricardo opened the page again.

“No.”

Natalie said, “Probably the lot.”

“Which lot?”

Natalie looked at the photograph.

“I don’t know.”

Yichen nodded.

Ricardo scrolled through the remaining images.

Rain on pavement.

Two trucks.

A loading dock.

A man in a reflective vest looking away from the camera.

Another view of the fence.

No bus.

The last photograph showed the corner of the building and part of the road beyond it.

Ricardo stopped.

“Wait.”

Natalie leaned forward.

“What?”

He enlarged the road.

There was a sign at the far edge of the photograph.

Most of it was turned away.

Only the back was visible.

Yichen said, “What?”

“I thought that was—”

He stopped.

Natalie waited.

Ricardo reduced the image.

“Nothing.”

No one said anything.

He returned to photograph nine.

* * *

Ten minutes later, Ricardo opened the old map.

Not a paper copy.

The version on his phone.

Several layers could be turned on and off.

Natalie looked at the screen.

“You still have all of these?”

“Yes.”

“How many?”

“Don’t.”

“How many?”

Ricardo looked at Yichen.

She waited.

“Twenty-three.”

Natalie put down a fry.

“Twenty-three maps?”

“Versions.”

“That is worse.”

“Some are almost the same.”

“You said that last time.”

Ricardo looked at her.

Natalie stopped.

For a moment nobody spoke.

Yichen looked at the map.

“Which one was the last one?”

Ricardo scrolled.

“This.”

The map changed.

A red route appeared across part of the screen.

The construction detour from eight months earlier was still there.

Farther down the timeline:

KELLER & SONS

MAN BOARDS

“NOT YET”

Yichen looked at it.

Ricardo moved the screen upward.

“If this road was open, then we could have come through the service section and—”

Natalie said, “Could.”

Ricardo stopped.

“Yes.”

He continued.

“We could have come through here.”

Yichen pointed at the line.

“Is that the old route?”

“Yes.”

“The one from the construction notice?”

“Yes.”

Natalie looked at the photograph again.

“So now you have a detour that could send something this way and a photograph showing a bus could be back there.”

Ricardo said, “Yes.”

“Different evidence.”

“Yes.”

“Neither proves ours did.”

“Yes.”

Natalie looked at him.

Ricardo looked back.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“Stop doing that.”

“I didn’t do anything.”

“You looked at me.”

“I’m allowed to look at you.”

Yichen said, “Apparently.”

Ricardo looked at her.

She was still looking at the map.

He moved farther down the timeline.

“So after Keller—”

He stopped.

Yichen’s eyes remained on the screen.

Natalie reached for her drink.

Ricardo waited.

Yichen looked at the two lines.

KELLER & SONS

MAN BOARDS

Then at the photograph of the service road.

“Keep going.”

Ricardo moved the map.

“The man gets on somewhere before the section with the woman.”

Yichen said nothing.

Natalie picked up a fry.

Ricardo continued.

“If this is the road, then it fixes the part where we thought there couldn’t have been a bus back there.”

“Maybe,” Natalie said.

Ricardo nodded.

“Maybe.”

* * *

They stayed for another hour.

At 5:42 Natalie found the original page metadata.

“November eighteenth.”

Ricardo said, “We know.”

“No. The upload.”

“Right.”

She scrolled.

“The account posted another picture on the twelfth.”

“Of what?”

“A truck.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“Helpful.”

“I’m checking.”

“Okay.”

Natalie looked up.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“You did it.”

“Did what?”

“That.”

Ricardo smiled.

Natalie looked back at her phone.

Yichen had opened the photograph on her own screen.

“Could the bus be a shuttle?”

Ricardo looked at her.

“Maybe.”

“Airport?”

“Maybe.”

“Private?”

“Maybe.”

Natalie said, “Look at him.”

Ricardo ignored her.

Yichen enlarged the bus.

There was no readable logo.

The side windows reflected the warehouse.

Ricardo said, “Still means something that size could use the road.”

“Yes.”

“And there wasn’t always a closed gate.”

“Yes.”

Natalie said, “Those are both fair.”

Ricardo leaned back.

“Thank you.”

“No one attacked you.”

“I know.”

Yichen looked at him.

Ricardo looked at the table.

Natalie took the last fry.

For a while none of them said anything.

People came in through the side door.

A child dropped a paper cup.

Someone at the counter asked for more sauce.

Ricardo locked his phone.

“So.”

Natalie said, “So what?”

“That’s probably it.”

Yichen looked at him.

“For the photograph?”

“Yes.”

Natalie folded the empty fry carton.

“It’s not bad.”

“No.”

“It’s not great.”

“No.”

“It doesn’t fix the route.”

“No.”

Yichen put her phone away.

“It gives the service road something.”

Ricardo nodded.

“Yeah.”

Natalie pushed the carton toward the middle of the table.

“Supported?”

Ricardo looked at her.

Yichen said, “The gate.”

Natalie nodded.

“Possible for the bus.”

Ricardo said, “Fine.”

No one wrote it down.

* * *

Natalie threw away the trash.

When she came back, Ricardo’s phone was still locked.

Yichen’s bag remained beneath her chair.

Natalie put on her coat.

Then sat down again.

Ricardo looked at her.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“You have your coat on.”

“Yes.”

“You sat down.”

“Yes.”

Yichen said, “Maybe she changed her mind.”

Natalie looked at her.

“Thank you.”

Ricardo leaned back.

“So are we leaving?”

Natalie said, “Do you need to?”

“No.”

Yichen shook her head.

Natalie pulled one sleeve of the coat back off.

“Okay.”

No one opened the map again.

Ricardo asked Natalie if she still worked at the diner.

She looked at him.

“No.”

“When did you leave?”

“January.”

“Oh.”

“Yeah.”

“What happened?”

“Nothing.”

“You quit for nothing?”

“I got another job.”

“Where?”

She told him.

Ricardo nodded.

Yichen asked, “Do you like it?”

Natalie made a face.

Ricardo said, “Apparently not.”

“It’s fine.”

“That means no.”

“It means fine.”

Yichen said, “I believe her.”

“Thank you.”

Ricardo looked at Yichen.

“What about you?”

“What about me?”

“What are you doing?”

Yichen looked at him.

“With what?”

“Anything.”

“That is a very broad question.”

Natalie laughed.

Ricardo said, “School.”

“Oh.”

Yichen answered.

The explanation took less than a minute.

Ricardo asked one question.

Natalie asked two.

Then Natalie said something about a customer at her new job.

Ricardo interrupted halfway through.

“That didn’t happen.”

“It did.”

“No one says that.”

“He did.”

“What exactly did he say?”

Natalie stopped.

Yichen looked at Ricardo.

Ricardo looked back at her.

Natalie said, “Don’t.”

Ricardo smiled.

“I didn’t do anything.”

“You were about to.”

“About to what?”

“Ask timestamps.”

“I was not.”

Yichen said, “He was.”

Ricardo looked at both of them.

“You’re both doing it again.”

No one answered for half a second.

Then Natalie said, “Good.”

Ricardo laughed.

Yichen looked down at the table.

Natalie pulled her coat sleeve off again.

* * *

At 7:03, they finally stood.

The photograph had not come back up.

Outside, the parking lot was wet.

It had rained while they were inside.

Ricardo put his hands into his pockets.

Natalie zipped her coat.

Yichen stood beside them.

For several seconds nobody moved toward a car or the street.

Natalie said, “I’m going this way.”

Ricardo nodded.

“Okay.”

Yichen said, “Same.”

Natalie looked at her.

“For how long?”

“Two blocks.”

“Fine.”

Ricardo looked the other direction.

Natalie said, “Bye.”

“Bye.”

Yichen said, “Bye.”

They separated.

No one mentioned the last time they had been together.

* * *

The photograph stayed in the group.

The next day Ricardo sent a cropped version.

The bus was larger.

The image was worse.

Natalie:

you made it less visible

Ricardo:

enhanced

Yichen:

No.

Ricardo:

both of you are useless

Natalie:

eight months and hes still like this

There was no reply for almost a minute.

Then Ricardo:

you came back

Natalie:

unfortunately

Yichen:

The photograph did.

Ricardo:

coward

Yichen:

Yes.

The conversation ended there.

Two days later, Yichen sent:

The opening in the fence is wider in photo 6.

Ricardo:

i saw

Natalie:

when

Ricardo:

yesterday

Natalie:

and you didnt say anything

Ricardo:

it doesnt change much

Yichen:

Correct.

Natalie:

who are you

Ricardo:

growth

Nothing else came that night.

* * *

For the next several weeks, the group did not return to what it had been.

It did not disappear either.

The bus came up twice.

Once when Ricardo found an older aerial photograph.

Once when Natalie noticed that the uploaded page had been copied from another account.

Neither helped much.

Yichen asked one question about the fence.

Ricardo answered the next morning.

Natalie sent a correction to the upload date.

No one argued.

Between those messages were other things.

A photograph of a vending machine that had charged Ricardo twice.

A screenshot Natalie sent without context.

A link Yichen sent and then immediately said:

wrong group

Ricardo:

too late

Natalie:

reviewing evidence

Yichen:

No.

Ricardo:

supported

Yichen:

Stop.

The link had nothing to do with the bus.

No one deleted it.

* * *

One Friday night, Natalie sent a photograph.

It showed a handwritten sign taped to the counter at her new job.

PLEASE DO NOT ASK IF WE ARE OPEN

Under it, somebody had added:

WE ARE OPEN

Ricardo:

why

Natalie:

long story

Yichen:

How long?

Natalie:

you dont get to do that

Yichen:

Do what?

Ricardo:

timestamps

Natalie:

absolutely not

Yichen:

I asked how long the story was.

Ricardo:

same thing

Yichen:

No.

Natalie:

here we go

The bus was not mentioned.

The conversation continued for twenty-seven messages.

CHAPTER TWELVE

In October 2021, Natalie sent a message to the group.

are you back thursday

Yichen replied twelve minutes later.

Yes.

Ricardo:

back from where

There was no answer for a while.

Then:

Yichen: Madison.

Ricardo:

why are you in madison

Natalie:

wait

why are you in madison

Yichen:

I live here.

Nothing came for almost a minute.

Ricardo:

what

Natalie:

since when

Yichen:

May.

Ricardo:

may what

Yichen:

May.

Natalie:

you moved

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

to wisconsin

Yichen:

Madison is in Wisconsin.

Ricardo:

i know where madison is

Yichen:

Good.

Natalie:

you moved five months ago

Yichen:

Almost.

Ricardo:

and didnt tell us

There was another pause.

Yichen:

I thought I did.

Natalie:

you did not

Ricardo:

absolutely did not

Yichen:

Okay.

Ricardo:

okay????

Natalie:

when did you think you told us

Yichen did not answer immediately.

Then:

I sent the apartment picture.

Ricardo:

what apartment picture

Natalie:

the one with the bad kitchen?

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

that was your apartment

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

in madison

Yichen:

Yes.

Natalie:

you sent a picture of a sink

Yichen:

There was more than the sink.

Natalie:

not much more

Ricardo:

you cannot move states through context clues

Yichen:

Apparently I can.

Natalie:

apparently you cant

There were no messages for several minutes.

Then Ricardo:

why madison

Yichen:

School.

Ricardo:

oh

Natalie:

for how long

Yichen:

I don't know.

Ricardo:

helpful

Yichen:

Accurate.

Natalie:

thursday what time

Yichen sent the time.

The conversation moved on.

* * *

They met two days later.

Not at the McDonald's.

Natalie had suggested a place near the airport because Yichen's bus got in before six and Ricardo said anything farther south would add forty minutes for no reason.

Ricardo arrived first.

Natalie came in carrying a paper bag.

“You brought food to a restaurant.”

“It's not for here.”

“What is it?”

“Nothing.”

“That's usually something.”

Natalie put the bag on the chair beside her.

“You have not changed.”

Ricardo looked toward the door.

“At least I tell people where I live.”

Natalie laughed.

“That was bad.”

“It was good.”

“No.”

Yichen came in a few minutes later pulling a small suitcase.

Ricardo looked at it.

Then at her.

“You really live there.”

Yichen stopped beside the table.

“What did you think?”

“I don't know.”

“That I took a suitcase to make the story more convincing?”

Natalie moved the paper bag off the chair.

“Sit down.”

Yichen sat.

Ricardo looked at the suitcase again.

“Five months.”

“Yes.”

“Five.”

“Yes.”

Natalie said, “We did this already.”

“No, we texted about it.”

“That counts.”

“It doesn't.”

Yichen took off her coat.

“What would count?”

Ricardo opened his mouth.

Stopped.

Natalie looked at him.

He said, “Nothing.”

“That is growth.”

Yichen looked at Natalie.

Natalie nodded.

“He does that now.”

“Does what?”

“Stops.”

Ricardo looked at both of them.

“I hate this.”

Yichen smiled.

The suitcase stayed beside the table.

* * *

They talked about Madison.

Mostly because Ricardo kept asking questions.

How far was the apartment from campus.

Whether she had a car.

Whether the winters were worse.

Whether she knew anyone before she moved.

Whether the kitchen was actually as small as it looked.

Yichen answered most of them.

Natalie opened the paper bag and gave her a book.

Yichen looked at the cover.

“What is this?”

“You left it at my place.”

“When?”

“Two years ago.”

Yichen looked at her.

Natalie shrugged.

“I kept forgetting.”

Ricardo said, “Interesting.”

Natalie looked at him.

“No.”

“I didn't say anything.”

“You were going to.”

“I was not.”

Yichen opened the book.

A receipt was folded inside.

Natalie reached for it.

Yichen moved the book away.

“What?”

“I want to see the date.”

Ricardo started laughing.

Natalie looked at him.

“Don't.”

Yichen unfolded the receipt.

“December seventh.”

Natalie held out her hand.

“Give me that.”

Yichen gave it back.

Ricardo said, “Two years.”

Natalie put the receipt into the bag.

“It was a book.”

“You had evidence.”

“It was a receipt.”

“You preserved evidence.”

“I forgot to throw it out.”

Yichen looked at the date again.

“Useful accident.”

“Don't.”

They ordered.

The bus did not come up.

* * *

Natalie's manager said the package had arrived before lunch.

Natalie looked up from the computer.

“It didn't.”

He stopped.

“What?”

“It came after.”

“No, it was here when I got back.”

“You got back at one.”

He looked at the clock on the wall.

It was 3:17.

“How do you know when I got back?”

“You complained that the elevator stopped on six.”

He waited.

Natalie clicked through a folder on the computer.

“You sent the maintenance message at twelve fifty-eight.”

“That doesn't mean I was downstairs.”

“You said 'I just got back upstairs.'”

Her manager looked at the screen.

Natalie opened the message.

He read it.

“Oh.”

Natalie closed the window.

“The package was signed for at one twelve.”

“So after lunch.”

“After your lunch.”

He looked at her.

“That is what I said.”

“No.”

He smiled.

“You're very annoying.”

Natalie returned to the spreadsheet.

“Apparently.”

A few minutes later he came back.

“Can you figure out when the other box got here?”

Natalie looked at him.

“Which one?”

“The small one.”

“From yesterday?”

“I think so.”

Natalie moved the spreadsheet aside.

“Do you think so, or was it yesterday?”

Her manager stared at her.

She waited.

“I think so.”

Natalie nodded.

“Okay.”

* * *

In Madison, a woman named Clara sat across from Yichen on the floor of Yichen's apartment.

There were two open takeout containers between them.

Clara said, “So she was angry.”

Yichen took a drink.

“She left.”

“Yes.”

Clara waited.

Yichen put the cup down.

“She left.”

“You know what I mean.”

“Yes.”

“And?”

“And what?”

“Was she angry?”

“I don't know.”

“You were there.”

“Yes.”

Clara looked at her.

“You are impossible.”

Yichen opened one of the containers.

Clara said, “She slammed the door.”

“Yes.”

“So she was angry.”

“She slammed the door.”

“That means angry.”

“Probably.”

Clara pointed at her.

“See.”

Yichen looked at the container.

“What?”

“You agree.”

“I said probably.”

Clara stared at her for a moment.

Then she laughed.

“You do this every time.”

Yichen picked up a fork.

“Do what?”

Clara shook her head.

“Nothing.”

Yichen started eating.

* * *

By December, the bus group had gone quiet for eleven days.

Then Natalie sent a photograph of a crooked parking sign.

Ricardo:

illegal

Natalie:

its a sign

Ricardo:

installed illegally

Yichen:

How do you install a sign illegally?

Ricardo sent three messages explaining.

Natalie:

regret asking

Yichen:

I didn't ask you.

Ricardo:

you literally did

Yichen:

I asked how.

Natalie:

same thing

Yichen:

No.

The conversation continued for another hour.

No one mentioned the bus.

* * *

In January, Ricardo sent a photograph from a gas station.

The price sign had one number burned out.

Natalie replied:

thats not how much gas costs

Ricardo:

prove it

Natalie:

no

Yichen:

Supported.

Ricardo:

by what

Yichen:

Everyone.

Ricardo:

terrible methodology

Natalie:

youre alone on this one map department

Ricardo:

retired

Yichen:

No.

Ricardo:

why

Yichen:

You sent me directions last week.

Ricardo:

different department

Natalie:

growth

The bus did not come up.

* * *

Yichen returned to Chicago again in March.

Ricardo did not know until Natalie sent:

food tonight

Ricardo:

why

Natalie:

because yichen is here

Ricardo:

since when

Yichen:

Yesterday.

Ricardo:

why am i always last

Natalie:

skill issue

Ricardo:

hate both of you

Yichen:

7?

Natalie:

730

Ricardo:

why ask if youre just changing it

Natalie:

because i have work

Yichen:

Then 7:30.

Ricardo:

fine

They met at 7:46.

Ricardo was last.

Natalie looked at the time on her phone when he sat down.

He saw her.

“Don't.”

“I didn't say anything.”

“You looked.”

“I have eyes.”

Yichen moved a menu toward him.

“Apparently.”

Ricardo sat.

“Why are you both like this?”

Natalie said, “Practice.”

Ricardo opened the menu.

“That sounds threatening.”

No one disagreed.

* * *

They ate for almost an hour before anyone mentioned the bus.

It happened because Natalie said she had found an old external hard drive.

Ricardo looked up.

“What's on it?”

“Old stuff.”

“What stuff?”

“School.”

“Pictures?”

“Yes.”

“From when?”

Natalie looked at him.

“No.”

“What?”

“No.”

“I asked a question.”

“You asked three.”

Yichen said, “He'll get there.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“Thank you.”

“That wasn't support.”

Natalie took a drink.

“There are some 2014 folders.”

Ricardo stopped.

Yichen looked at Natalie.

Natalie set the glass down.

“I knew that would happen.”

Ricardo said, “What's in them?”

“I don't know yet.”

“You just said—”

“I said folders.”

“Did you check dates?”

“Some.”

“Any October?”

Natalie looked at him.

“Yes.”

Ricardo put his fork down.

Yichen said, “Do you remember what's in them?”

“No.”

“Then why are we doing this now?”

Ricardo looked at her.

“Because she has files from 2014.”

Natalie said, “Mostly school.”

“Mostly.”

“Ricardo.”

“Fine.”

He picked up his fork again.

For another several minutes they ate.

Then Natalie said, “There are probably screenshots.”

Ricardo looked up again.

Yichen did not.

Natalie pointed at him.

“I said probably.”

Ricardo nodded.

“Probably.”

Yichen looked at him.

He looked back.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

* * *

Three days later, Natalie uploaded a folder.

There were 317 files.

Ricardo replied:

what am i looking for

Natalie:

you wanted it

Ricardo:

yes but what

Natalie:

2014

Ricardo:

helpful

Yichen:

Do any have dates?

Natalie:

all of them have dates

Ricardo:

see this is why you have the times

Natalie:

shut up

Yichen:

Are they original dates?

There was a pause.

Natalie:

some

Then:

some are copy dates

Yichen:

Keep both.

Ricardo:

why

Yichen:

Because they are different.

Ricardo:

i know

Yichen:

Then why did you ask?

Ricardo:

conversation

Natalie:

growth

They found nothing from the night of the bus.

There were screenshots from September.

A photograph of a classroom.

Three pictures of food.

A blank image.

A game menu.

A weather screenshot from October.

Two photographs with no visible reason for existing.

Ricardo opened one.

A parking lot at night.

He sent it to the group.

where is this

Natalie:

no idea

Yichen:

Did you take it?

Natalie:

probably

Ricardo:

probably??

Natalie:

its on my drive

Ricardo:

that is not the same thing

No one answered for a few seconds.

Then Yichen:

Correct.

Ricardo:

dont

Natalie:

growth reversed

The photograph stayed in the folder.

No one added it to the bus notes.

* * *

Over the next year, the group got quieter without becoming empty.

There were stretches of three days.

Then ten.

Once nineteen.

Yichen missed a birthday dinner because she was in Madison.

Ricardo sent:

traitor

Yichen:

I live here.

Natalie:

apparently

Ricardo:

still sounds fake

Yichen sent a photograph of snow outside her apartment window.

Ricardo:

could be anywhere

Yichen:

Good.

Natalie:

dont encourage him

A month later, Ricardo changed jobs.

Yichen found out because Natalie asked how his first week had gone.

Yichen:

First week where?

Ricardo:

oh

Natalie:

lol

Yichen:

What?

Ricardo sent the name of the place.

Yichen:

Since when?

Ricardo:

two weeks

Yichen:

Okay.

Ricardo:

thats all

Yichen:

You moved states through a sink.

Natalie:

fair

Ricardo:

not remotely the same

Yichen:

Okay.

In June, Natalie was away for four days.

Neither of them knew until she sent a photograph from a hotel hallway.

Ricardo:

where

Natalie:

detroit

Yichen:

Why?

Natalie:

work

Ricardo:

when are you back

Natalie:

sunday probably

Ricardo:

sunday

Yichen:

She said probably.

There was a pause.

Ricardo:

right

Natalie:

wow

Ricardo:

what

Natalie:

nothing

Yichen:

Supported.

Ricardo:

retiring again

* * *

When Yichen came back in September 2022, all three of them managed to be free on the same Saturday.

They met after six.

No one brought a notebook.

No one brought a printed map.

Natalie had a laptop in her bag because she had come from work.

Ricardo had his phone.

Yichen had a charger she forgot to take out of her coat pocket until she sat down.

They talked about apartments.

Then Owen.

Then Natalie's manager.

Then whether Wisconsin winters were actually worse or people just complained more.

Yichen said they were worse.

Ricardo said she had insufficient comparative data.

Yichen told him to stop.

Natalie laughed.

Food came.

They ate.

The bus did not come up.

After eight, Ricardo said, “Did we ever figure out when that warehouse page was actually uploaded?”

Natalie looked at him.

“What warehouse page?”

“The service-road one.”

Yichen looked up.

“Oh.”

Natalie thought for a moment.

Then reached for her bag.

Ricardo said, “You forgot.”

Natalie stopped.

“What?”

“You forgot.”

“I didn't forget.”

“You just asked what I meant.”

“That is not the same as forgetting.”

Yichen said, “Careful.”

Natalie looked at her.

Yichen smiled.

Ricardo leaned back.

“This is disgusting.”

Natalie opened the laptop.

“No one asked you.”

The old folder was still there.

It opened differently now.

More files.

Cleaner names.

Several subfolders.

Ricardo leaned toward the screen.

“You reorganized it.”

“A while ago.”

“When?”

Natalie looked at him.

He raised both hands.

“Never mind.”

She opened:

SOURCES

Then:

2014

Then:

ROADS / BUS / PEOPLE / RECORDS

Yichen looked at the folder names.

“People?”

Natalie said, “Old name.”

“From when?”

“I don't know.”

Ricardo smiled.

Natalie looked at him.

“Don't.”

“I didn't.”

“You did.”

Yichen said, “Continue.”

Natalie opened the warehouse page.

A note appeared beside it.

page upload: 18 Nov 2014

Below:

photo date: unknown

Below that:

bus identity: unknown

Ricardo read it.

“Okay.”

Natalie scrolled.

There were links beside some entries.

Screenshots beside others.

One source had:

original unavailable - copy only

Another:

date from page metadata

Another:

memory only

Ricardo said, “When did this get so organized?”

Natalie shrugged.

“It wasn't hard.”

Yichen opened another file.

The route timeline appeared.

It was cleaner than the last version Ricardo remembered.

The red line was gone.

The route was split into sections.

Each one had a note.

supported by location

possible

assumption

unresolved

Farther down:

KELLER & SONS

MAN BOARDS

"NOT YET"

* * *

They found the warehouse upload date.

It had already been in the notes.

Natalie had added the source two years earlier.

Ricardo looked at her.

“You knew.”

“I had it written down.”

“That counts.”

Yichen said, “For what?”

Ricardo looked at her.

Yichen waited.

He shook his head.

“Nothing.”

Natalie closed the file.

They stayed another forty minutes.

The laptop remained open but no one touched it.

When they finally stood, Ricardo asked Natalie:

“When are you back from Detroit again?”

Natalie put on her coat.

“Seventeenth. Probably.”

Ricardo nodded.

“Seventeenth.”

Yichen picked up her bag.

“She said probably.”

Ricardo looked at her.

Then at Natalie.

“Right.”

Natalie smiled.

“Thank you.”

“For what?”

“Nothing.”

They left.

* * *

In November, Ricardo sent a link.

Natalie:

what

Ricardo:

county archive

Yichen:

What about it?

Ricardo:

more of this stuff is online now

Natalie:

what stuff

Ricardo:

old permits

Then:

property records

Then:

photos

Natalie:

since when

Ricardo:

dont know

Yichen:

Useful?

Ricardo did not answer immediately.

Three minutes later:

nothing useful yet

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

In February 2023, Ricardo sent a link to the group.

Nothing before it.

Natalie replied six minutes later.

what am i looking at

Ricardo:

left side

Natalie:

there are like twelve things on the left side

Ricardo:

railroad

Natalie:

yes

Ricardo:

below it

There was a pause.

Natalie:

orchard place

Ricardo:

yes

Another pause.

Natalie:

what is orchard place

Ricardo:

dont know yet

Natalie:

excellent

Ricardo:

keep looking

Natalie:

at what

Ricardo:

roads

Three minutes passed.

Then Natalie:

which road

Ricardo sent a screenshot.

It was a section of an old map.

A railway crossed near the upper edge.

Below it, several roads divided the pale background into uneven blocks.

Ricardo had circled one.

Natalie:

okay

Ricardo:

does that look familiar

Natalie:

no

Ricardo:

look at the bend

Natalie:

still no

Ricardo:

open the old route

Natalie:

im at work

Ricardo:

later

Natalie:

yes

Nothing else came.

At 12:41, Yichen replied.

What year is this?

Ricardo:

1924

Yichen:

Then no.

Ricardo:

no what

Yichen:

It isn’t our road.

Ricardo:

i know

Yichen:

Okay.

Ricardo:

thats not what i mean

Yichen:

What do you mean?

Ricardo did not answer for nine minutes.

Then:

not sure yet

Yichen:

Good.

Ricardo:

dont start

* * *

That evening, Natalie opened the link again.

The page was part of a digitized atlas.

She went back to the title.

Then to the index.

Then back to the map.

She sent:

it actually says orchard place in the title

Ricardo:

yes

Natalie:

you knew that

Ricardo:

thats why i sent it

Natalie:

why were you looking at this

Ricardo:

airport stuff

Natalie:

specific

Ricardo:

old maps

Natalie:

more specific

Ricardo:

trying to find roads near the service area

Natalie:

2014 roads

Ricardo:

yes

Natalie:

in a 1924 map

There was a pause.

Ricardo:

the search result was weird

Natalie:

thats not an answer

Ricardo:

it had schiller park in the title

Natalie:

okay

Ricardo:

and des plaines

Natalie:

okay

Ricardo:

and orchard place

Natalie:

which you had never heard of

Ricardo:

no

Natalie:

so you clicked it

Ricardo:

yes

Natalie:

growth

Ricardo:

shut up

Yichen:

What is Orchard Place?

Ricardo:

still reading

Natalie:

apparently old ohare

Yichen:

Old O’Hare?

Natalie:

before ohare

Ricardo:

wait

Nothing came for several minutes.

Then Ricardo sent another link.

Natalie opened it.

Yichen did not reply.

Ricardo:

it was a place

Natalie:

yes that is usually how place works

Ricardo:

no

Then:

like people lived there

Natalie:

i assumed that

Ricardo:

railroad station

Another message.

houses

Another.

then douglas took over the area during the war

Natalie:

how much of the area

Ricardo:

reading

Yichen:

When did it disappear?

Ricardo:

before us

Yichen:

Very helpful.

Natalie:

hes learning from me

Ricardo:

1930s subdivision

Then:

war stuff starts 1942

Then:

airport after

Natalie:

so again

not our road

Ricardo:

i know

Yichen:

You keep saying that.

Ricardo:

because both of you keep saying it isnt

Yichen:

It isn’t.

Ricardo:

I KNOW

Natalie:

this is going well

Ricardo sent the screenshot again.

This time a second image followed.

A current map.

He had reduced the opacity of one and placed it over the other.

The alignment was rough.

The scale was not exact.

The old railway and the current one did not sit perfectly on top of each other.

Neither did the roads.

But one short section of the old map bent in the same direction as a road Ricardo had drawn years earlier.

Natalie did not reply.

Yichen:

How did you align these?

Ricardo:

railroad first

Then:

and a couple roads that still exist

Yichen:

Which roads?

Ricardo named them.

Natalie:

those arent exact

Ricardo:

no

Yichen:

Then the overlay can move.

Ricardo:

a little

Yichen:

How much?

No answer.

Yichen:

Ricardo

Ricardo:

working on it

* * *

At 10:18 that night, Ricardo uploaded a new image.

The old map was pale gray.

Modern streets were black.

His 2014 route was red.

The historical road was blue.

For several blocks, the blue and red lines approached one another.

Then separated.

Natalie:

thats not the same road

Ricardo:

i didnt say it was

Natalie:

it looks like youre saying it

Ricardo:

im showing both

Yichen:

Why is the old road solid?

Ricardo:

because its on the map

Yichen:

And the red one?

Ricardo:

our route

Yichen:

That isn’t what I asked.

There was a pause.

Ricardo:

the parts we have support for

Natalie:

make old roads blue

Ricardo:

they are blue

Natalie:

i mean all of them

Ricardo:

why

Natalie:

because then you know what youre looking at

Ricardo:

i know what im looking at

Yichen:

We don’t.

Ricardo:

fine

Eleven minutes later he sent another version.

All historical roads were blue.

The 2014 reconstruction remained red.

Modern roads stayed black.

Natalie:

better

Ricardo:

same information

Natalie:

better

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

hate this group

* * *

For the next four days, Orchard Place stayed near the top of the group.

Not because anyone decided it should.

Ricardo sent maps.

Natalie sent dates.

Yichen sent questions.

A link showed that a railroad depot had given the place its name.

Another showed that a residential subdivision had once existed nearby.

A later history described wartime aircraft production.

Natalie sent:

so the houses were already gone

Ricardo:

yes

Yichen:

Before 2014 by seventy years.

Ricardo:

yes

Natalie:

good

Ricardo:

why is everyone happy about this

Natalie:

because now we know

Ricardo:

know what

Natalie:

what it isnt

Yichen:

Supported.

Ricardo:

stop

The next day, Ricardo sent a photograph from an old airport history page.

Runways crossed the image.

Large empty areas surrounded them.

Natalie:

this is 1940s

Ricardo:

yes

Natalie:

and

Ricardo:

look at the roads outside

Natalie:

which one

He circled one.

Yichen:

That is not the same direction as the other map.

Ricardo:

the image is rotated

Yichen:

Rotate it.

Ricardo did.

Yichen:

Still not the same.

Ricardo:

close

Yichen:

Close is fine.

Ricardo:

thank you

Yichen:

It is still close.

Ricardo:

there it is

* * *

On Friday, the group went quiet for most of the day.

At 6:13, Natalie sent:

why is it called ord

Ricardo:

what

Natalie:

ohare

ord

Ricardo:

airport code

Natalie:

yes ricardo

Yichen:

I also want to see this answer.

Ricardo:

looking

Natalie:

i already looked

There was a pause.

Then:

orchard

Ricardo:

what

Natalie:

orchard field

Yichen:

Oh.

Nothing came for almost a minute.

Ricardo:

wait

Then:

seriously

Natalie sent a screenshot.

A paragraph had been highlighted.

The old airport name remained in the code.

Ricardo:

thats insane

Yichen:

Why?

Ricardo:

because its still there

Yichen:

The code?

Ricardo:

yes

Natalie:

airport has not been named orchard in seventy years

Ricardo:

exactly

Yichen:

Okay.

Ricardo:

you dont think thats weird

Yichen:

No.

Ricardo:

how

Yichen:

Codes stay.

Natalie:

she has a point

Ricardo:

i know she has a point

Another pause.

Ricardo:

still cool

Natalie:

yes

Yichen:

Yes.

The conversation ended there.

* * *

Two weeks later, Yichen came to Chicago.

Ricardo asked whether she was coming back because of Orchard Place.

She replied:

No.

Then:

But I can meet Saturday.

Natalie:

same place

Ricardo:

which one

Natalie:

airport one

Yichen:

You have a name for it?

Natalie:

no

Ricardo:

apparently not

They met at six.

Ricardo arrived with a laptop.

Natalie saw it before he sat down.

“No.”

“What?”

“You brought the laptop.”

“Yes.”

“We’re eating.”

“I know.”

Yichen put her bag under the chair.

“You could leave it closed.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“That is a very aggressive suggestion.”

“It’s a laptop.”

Natalie said, “Growth.”

Ricardo sat.

The laptop stayed closed for twenty-seven minutes.

* * *

Natalie was halfway through telling them about a coworker who had accidentally sent a resignation email to the entire department when Ricardo opened the laptop.

She stopped.

“You lasted longer than I expected.”

“I waited.”

“You were counting.”

“No.”

Yichen looked at him.

Ricardo turned the screen around.

Three maps were open.

Natalie leaned closer.

“You fixed the alignment.”

“Mostly.”

Yichen said, “How mostly?”

Ricardo ignored her.

Natalie said, “That means not mostly.”

“It’s better.”

“Show us.”

Ricardo enlarged the first map.

“This is current.”

Modern streets.

Airport boundaries.

The railway.

He switched tabs.

“2014.”

The route reconstruction appeared.

Not the old one from 2017.

This version had fewer labels.

Several stretches were red.

Others were broken.

Small notes appeared at intersections.

Then the third.

“Historical.”

Blue roads.

Property lines.

The railroad.

The words:

ORCHARD PLACE

Natalie moved closer.

Yichen did not.

Ricardo switched between them.

Current.

2014.

Historical.

Current.

Historical.

2014.

Natalie said, “You’re making me dizzy.”

Ricardo stopped.

“Look here.”

He pointed at a short diagonal section.

“Historical road.”

Then switched.

A modern service road appeared farther east.

Then 2014.

The red reconstruction crossed the space between them.

Natalie said, “Those don’t line up.”

“No.”

Yichen said, “Then what are we looking at?”

“The direction.”

“What about it?”

“It’s the same general angle.”

Natalie leaned back.

“General.”

“Yes.”

Yichen said, “What does that give us?”

Ricardo looked at the screen.

“A road.”

Yichen shook her head.

“An old road.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“Yes.”

Yichen waited.

Ricardo said, “An old road.”

“Okay.”

He switched maps again.

“But there are more.”

He opened another section.

Then another.

Old roads appeared and disappeared beneath airport development.

Some had no modern equivalent.

Some seemed to follow property boundaries that survived later in different forms.

One line ended where a runway now crossed.

Another approached the railway.

Ricardo said, “The whole area changed.”

Natalie said, “We know.”

“No, I mean changed changed.”

Yichen looked at him.

Ricardo moved the map.

“Not just new buildings. Roads gone. Roads moved. Parcels combined. Airport roads added. Construction on top of that.”

Natalie said, “Over seventy years.”

“Yes.”

“And we were there in 2014.”

“Yes.”

Yichen said, “So what are you saying?”

Ricardo sat back.

For several seconds, he said nothing.

Then:

“I don’t know.”

Natalie looked at him.

Ricardo continued.

“Maybe we’ve been trying to find one road.”

No one answered.

He moved to the 2014 reconstruction.

“The laundromat. Keller. The service road. The place with the houses. The airport stuff.”

Yichen said, “We don’t know that Keller was airport stuff.”

“I know.”

“You put it next to airport stuff.”

“I know.”

Natalie said, “Keep going.”

Ricardo looked at her.

She shrugged.

“You were saying something.”

He returned to the map.

“Maybe there wasn’t one road that had all of it.”

Yichen looked at the screen.

Ricardo continued.

“Maybe there were pieces.”

Natalie said, “We already had mixed streets.”

“Yes, but not like this.”

“How is this different?”

Ricardo pointed at the historical layer.

“This whole area already had pieces.”

“Pieces of what?”

“Old roads. Industrial roads. airport roads. normal streets. Things that stopped connecting the way they used to.”

Yichen said, “In 2014?”

“Some.”

“Which?”

Ricardo stopped.

Natalie said, “That’s the question.”

“Yes.”

Yichen looked at the blue lines.

“So we still need 2014.”

Ricardo closed one tab.

“Yes.”

No one spoke for a while.

The server came by.

Natalie ordered another drink.

Yichen asked for water.

Ricardo closed the laptop halfway.

Natalie said, “You can leave it.”

He looked at her.

“I thought we were eating.”

“We are.”

He opened it again.

* * *

They worked for three hours.

Not continuously.

Food arrived.

They stopped.

Natalie told the end of the resignation-email story.

Yichen asked whether the coworker still worked there.

Natalie said yes.

Ricardo said that seemed disappointing.

Then the laptop came back.

Natalie made a new column in the source sheet.

DATE / SOURCE / WHAT IT PROVES

Ricardo looked at it.

“That last one is aggressive.”

“It’s useful.”

Yichen said, “Keep it.”

Ricardo opened the 1924 atlas.

Natalie typed:

1924 atlas — Orchard Place shown

Under WHAT IT PROVES:

Orchard Place existed / road network existed then

Ricardo said, “That sounds obvious.”

“Good.”

The next source:

O’Hare history — Orchard Field / airport development

Natalie typed:

area substantially changed before 2014

Ricardo looked at her.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“You made that sound bad.”

“It’s not bad.”

“It sounds bad.”

“It is literally what happened.”

Yichen said, “It’s useful.”

Ricardo pointed at her.

“See.”

Yichen continued.

“It doesn’t help your road yet.”

Ricardo lowered his hand.

“Fine.”

Another source.

A historical aerial image.

Natalie:

airport / industrial infrastructure present

Ricardo:

“Can we write roads?”

“Can we see them?”

“Yes.”

“All of them?”

“No.”

“Then no.”

Yichen said, “Some roads visible.”

Natalie typed:

some roads visible

Ricardo looked at both of them.

“I regret this.”

“You brought the laptop,” Natalie said.

* * *

Near nine, Ricardo opened the oldest route timeline.

Natalie recognized the format before the labels loaded.

“Is that the bad one?”

“They’re all bad.”

“The fight one.”

Ricardo stopped moving the mouse.

Yichen looked at Natalie.

Natalie said, “What?”

Ricardo reopened the file.

“It’s not the same version.”

“Okay.”

The timeline appeared.

The sequence ran downward.

KELLER & SONS

MAN BOARDS

“NOT YET”

Below that, later landmarks.

Above it, several route segments.

Ricardo opened a second window beside it.

The Orchard Place materials.

No one commented on the three lines.

Ricardo said, “If this section is farther north—”

Natalie interrupted.

“If.”

Ricardo nodded.

“If this section is farther north, some of these industrial roads work better.”

Yichen said, “Better for what?”

“For getting us back to the part we know.”

“Which part?”

He pointed.

Natalie leaned closer.

“That’s not one of the solid sections.”

“It used to be.”

She looked at him.

Ricardo sighed.

“Possible section.”

“Okay.”

He changed the display.

A broken red line appeared.

Yichen said, “Better.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“It is the same line.”

“I know.”

He returned to the historical layer.

A road from the old atlas ran toward the railway.

It ended decades before their route.

Ricardo said, “This one is real.”

Natalie said, “Was.”

“Fine. Was real.”

Yichen said, “Solid?”

Ricardo looked at her.

“For historical?”

“Yes.”

He changed the old road to a solid blue line.

Natalie looked at the screen.

“Fine.”

Ricardo clicked another old road.

“Solid.”

Then another.

“Solid.”

Blue lines accumulated.

The red route remained broken in places.

After several minutes, Ricardo switched all three layers on at once.

Black.

Red.

Blue.

Natalie said, “That is horrible.”

“It’s useful.”

“I can’t see anything.”

Ricardo reduced the black layer.

Yichen said, “More.”

He reduced it again.

The old blue roads became clearer.

The red reconstruction sat between them.

One blue line approached a red one.

Another crossed under it at an angle.

A third ended nearby.

Nothing matched exactly.

Nothing was far enough away to dismiss immediately.

Natalie stared at the screen.

Ricardo said, “See?”

She did not answer.

Yichen moved closer.

Ricardo pointed.

“If this is shifted even a little—”

Yichen said, “It can be.”

“I know.”

“How much?”

“Not enough to put these on top of each other.”

Natalie said, “Good.”

Ricardo looked at her.

She pointed at the screen.

“That matters.”

“Yes.”

“So write it.”

Ricardo opened the notes.

He typed:

alignment approximate — no direct road match

He stopped.

Then added:

possible shared orientation

Yichen read it.

“Fine.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“That’s it?”

“Yes.”

“You don’t hate it?”

“I don’t know what it means yet.”

Ricardo smiled.

Natalie said, “Don’t encourage him.”

* * *

At 9:36, Natalie asked, “What are we calling this?”

Ricardo looked up.

“What?”

“This.”

She pointed at the open windows.

Ricardo looked at the screen.

“Historical?”

“No.”

“Airport?”

“No.”

“Why no?”

“Because there are six airport folders.”

“There are not.”

Natalie opened the shared directory.

There were six.

Ricardo looked at her.

“When did that happen?”

“Over nine years.”

Yichen said, “Apparently.”

Ricardo leaned back.

Natalie clicked NEW FOLDER.

The blank name field appeared.

“What are we calling it?”

Ricardo said, “Orchard Place.”

Yichen looked at the screen.

Natalie typed:

ORCHARD PLACE

Then stopped.

“Anything else?”

Ricardo said, “Question mark?”

Natalie looked at him.

Yichen said nothing.

Ricardo looked at the folder name.

Then:

“No.”

Natalie pressed Enter.

The folder appeared.

Empty.

For a moment no one moved.

Then Ricardo dragged the 1924 atlas screenshot into it.

Natalie added the history page.

Yichen moved the overlay image.

Ricardo added a second map.

Natalie added the source sheet.

No one said anything about the name again.

* * *

Yichen went back to Madison Sunday afternoon.

At 4:12 she sent:

Your blue road is wrong.

Ricardo replied immediately.

which one

She sent a screenshot.

One historical line had been traced across a property boundary rather than along the road.

Ricardo:

oh

Natalie:

map department

Ricardo:

shut up

Yichen:

It changes the angle.

Ricardo:

how much

Yichen sent another image.

The corrected line bent farther west.

It matched the red route less well.

There was a pause.

Ricardo:

fine

Then:

fixing

Natalie:

growth

Ricardo:

i hate both of you

At 4:29 he uploaded a new overlay.

The blue line no longer approached the red one.

Yichen:

Better.

Ricardo:

worse

Yichen:

More accurate.

Ricardo:

yes

No one restored the old version.

* * *

In March, Orchard Place disappeared from the group for nine days.

Natalie sent a picture of a broken office chair.

Yichen sent a photograph of snow.

Ricardo sent nothing.

Then one Tuesday:

Ricardo: what did orchard place actually look like in the 30s

Natalie:

hello to you too

Yichen:

What part?

Ricardo:

houses

Natalie:

why

Ricardo:

trying to compare

Yichen:

To the houses we saw?

Ricardo:

maybe

Natalie:

we barely have the houses

Ricardo:

i know

Yichen:

What do we have?

There was a delay.

Ricardo:

not much

Natalie:

good answer

Ricardo:

dark

Then:

detached

Then:

some space between

Yichen:

Whose memory?

Ricardo did not answer.

Natalie:

mine maybe

Yichen:

Maybe?

Natalie:

yes

Ricardo:

i remember houses

Yichen:

That wasn’t the question.

Ricardo:

both of us then

Yichen:

No.

Ricardo:

fine

A minute later:

dont compare houses

Yichen:

I didn’t say that.

Ricardo:

i know

No photographs were added that night.

* * *

In April, Natalie found a date error in one of the new sources.

The group had labeled an aerial photograph 1945.

The archive page said circa 1945.

She changed the source sheet.

Ricardo:

thats basically 1945

Natalie:

no

Ricardo:

come on

Yichen:

No.

Ricardo:

you two have become unbearable

Natalie:

practice

Ricardo did not reply.

Ten minutes later, the filename changed from:

1945_airfield.jpg

to:

c1945_airfield.jpg

Natalie:

growth

Ricardo:

blocked

* * *

In May, Ricardo sent an airport map without explanation.

Natalie:

what

No response.

Yichen:

Ricardo

Still nothing.

Twenty minutes later:

look at the north side

Natalie:

what about it

Ricardo:

service access

Yichen:

2014?

Ricardo:

2000s map

Natalie:

then why

Ricardo:

because the pattern survives

Yichen:

What pattern?

Ricardo sent a cropped image.

Several roads ran along edges of airport property.

One bent around an enclosed area and rejoined a larger road.

Ricardo:

roads built around things

Natalie:

yes

Ricardo:

not straight through

Natalie:

yes

Ricardo:

so if we remember one long road it couldve been multiple

Yichen:

We already knew that.

Ricardo:

not with this much physical reason

Yichen:

Maybe.

Ricardo:

thank you

Yichen:

Maybe.

Ricardo:

I HEARD YOU

Natalie:

growth stable

* * *

By June, the folder held nine files.

Three were maps.

Two were archive pages.

One was an aerial photograph.

One was a source table.

One was Ricardo’s overlay.

The last was a text file Yichen had created.

Its name was:

QUESTIONS

Ricardo opened it.

There were seven lines.

Which historical roads still existed in any form by 2014?

Which alignments are being compared because they are actually close, and which because the overlay was adjusted?

Do we have independent evidence for the houses?

Does Orchard Place explain anything after the airport existed?

Are we using “Orchard” to mean the community, the field, or the later airport site?

What, if anything, connects Keller?

And:

What does this explain that construction + mixed streets did not already explain?

Ricardo read the list.

Then sent:

rude

Yichen:

Which one?

Ricardo:

all

Natalie:

last one is good

Ricardo:

i know

Yichen:

Good.

Ricardo:

stop

* * *

The answer to the last question did not come quickly.

The folder remained.

Files were added.

Removed.

Renamed.

One road disappeared from the overlay when Ricardo found a better reference point.

Another historical line moved south.

Natalie found that two pages had copied the same historical claim from one earlier source and marked them as one source instead of two.

Yichen deleted a note that said:

old neighborhood maybe explains houses

and replaced it with:

old neighborhood had houses

Ricardo changed it again:

historical fact only

No one discussed the edit.

* * *

In July, Ricardo uploaded a new file at 1:08 in the morning.

Natalie opened it the next day.

Yichen opened it three hours later.

It was not a map.

It was a one-page note.

At the top:

ORCHARD PLACE — WORKING

Under it:

Known

- Orchard Place existed.
- Airport development replaced the earlier community and road network.
- Some historical roads and property lines differ substantially from the modern layout.
- Later airport and industrial access roads created additional non-residential routes through the area.
- 2014 construction created further temporary routing nearby.

Then:

Possible

- Our route used more than one type of road.
- Some remembered geometry may combine roads from different sections.
- Airport-edge/service infrastructure may explain why parts of the route did not resemble normal residential streets.

Then:

Not established

- Any 2014 road followed an Orchard Place street.
- The bus entered airport property.
- Orchard Place explains the houses.
- Orchard Place explains Keller.
- One continuous route connects all remembered landmarks.

Natalie replied:

this is surprisingly normal

Ricardo:

thank you

Yichen:

Keep the last section.

Ricardo:

i was going to

Yichen:

Okay.

Ricardo:

you dont believe me

Yichen:

I didn’t say that.

Natalie:

oh no

Ricardo:

dont

The note stayed.

* * *

By August, the folder contained fourteen files.

The newest was the corrected overlay.

The oldest was the screenshot Ricardo had sent in February.

The railroad.

The pale blocks.

The small printed name they had not known six months earlier.

The folder containing all of them was named:

ORCHARD PLACE

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

By March 2024, the Orchard Place folder had six folders inside it.

MAPS

2014

HISTORICAL

PHOTOS

BUSINESSES

QUESTIONS

Ricardo noticed because he could not find the overlay.

Ricardo: where did the map go

Natalie:

maps

Ricardo:

which maps

Natalie:

the folder called maps

Ricardo:

there are four folders in maps

Yichen:

That sounds like a map department problem.

Ricardo:

you made these folders

Natalie:

yes

Ricardo:

why

Natalie:

because there were fourteen files sitting next to each other

Ricardo:

they were organized

Natalie:

by what

Ricardo:

me

Natalie:

exactly

A minute later:

Ricardo: found it

Yichen:

Good.

Ricardo:

stop

The overlay had been moved into:

MAPS / WORKING

Beside it were five versions.

The newest had a date in the filename.

The oldest did not.

* * *

A construction drawing Ricardo had saved years earlier showed a temporary closure.

A newer set of records showed how the same section had been used during later airport work.

An aerial image showed a service road behind a fence.

Another showed that the fence line had changed.

A permit plan showed a gate where Ricardo had once drawn an entrance and later erased it.

He sent the page.

Natalie:

what year

Ricardo:

2013

Yichen:

The gate existed?

Ricardo:

looks like

Natalie:

looks like or did

Ricardo:

plan says temporary access gate

Natalie:

better

Yichen:

Was it open in October 2014?

Ricardo:

dont know

Yichen:

Okay.

Ricardo:

but it existed

Yichen:

Yes.

Several minutes later:

Ricardo: this is exactly what i drew

Natalie:

after you moved it twice

Ricardo:

still

Yichen:

The gate is supported.

Ricardo:

thank you

Then:

Yichen: The bus is not.

Ricardo:

there it is

Natalie:

growth

The drawing went into 2014.

Its filename was:

temporary_access_gate_2013

No one added the bus to the filename.

* * *

In April, Ricardo updated the overlay.

The historical layer was blue.

The 2014 reconstruction remained red.

Current roads were black.

The temporary gate appeared as a small square.

He sent the image at 11:09 at night.

Natalie replied the next morning.

why is this better

Ricardo:

gate

Natalie:

yes

Ricardo:

it gives the service road an entrance

Natalie:

an entrance

Ricardo:

yes

Natalie:

not ours

Ricardo:

you sound like yichen

Yichen:

No.

Natalie:

apparently

Ricardo:

both of you stop

Yichen:

Does the road connect?

Ricardo:

depends when

Natalie:

good answer

Ricardo:

2013 yes

Yichen:

2014?

Ricardo:

probably

Nothing came for a while.

Then Ricardo:

i know

Yichen:

Okay.

* * *

By summer, the phrase mixed streets had returned.

It had not been used much in years.

Ricardo found it in one of the old notes and sent a screenshot.

Ricardo: we were already saying this

Natalie:

yes

Yichen:

What year?

Ricardo:

2014

Natalie:

2015

Ricardo:

same thing

Natalie:

no

Yichen:

No.

Ricardo:

fine

Then:

2015

The old message below the screenshot read:

Maybe there were two normal areas and we put them together.

Natalie:

that was you right

Yichen:

Me.

Ricardo:

this is basically orchard place

Yichen:

No.

Ricardo:

how

Yichen:

It is basically mixed streets.

Ricardo:

which orchard place explains

Yichen:

Maybe.

Ricardo:

we have old roads

Yichen:

Yes.

airport roads

Yes.

industrial roads

Yes.

normal streets nearby

There was a pause.

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

construction

Natalie:

real

Ricardo:

so

Yichen:

So those things existed.

Ricardo:

you are impossible

Natalie:

but hes not wrong

Yichen:

I didn’t say he was.

Ricardo:

what

Natalie:

historic moment

Yichen:

I said the area could contain different kinds of roads.

Ricardo:

yes

Yichen:

That is not the same as saying we used them.

Ricardo:

i know

Natalie:

still better than 2015

Ricardo:

thank you

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

ill take it

* * *

The first time they opened the skeleton photograph again, none of them had planned to.

Natalie was looking for the original file date.

She found the photograph in an old backup and sent:

this is the actual original

Ricardo replied immediately.

send

Natalie:

i did

Ricardo:

full size

Natalie:

that is full size

Ricardo:

seriously

Natalie:

2014 phone

Yichen:

What are you looking for?

Ricardo:

background

The photograph was blurry.

A plastic skeleton sat in an upstairs window.

One arm was caught above its head.

The bus interior reflected across the glass.

A pale bar from the overhead lights cut through part of the frame.

The edge of a seat appeared near the bottom.

Behind the roofline was a pale vertical shape.

Its top widened slightly.

Ricardo had once thought it might be a water tower.

Then he had thought it was not.

Then he had stopped labeling it.

Natalie:

metadata is the same

Ricardo:

1051

Natalie:

yes

Yichen:

Sent when?

Natalie:

1052

Ricardo:

one minute

Natalie:

yes

Ricardo enlarged the photograph.

The skeleton broke into blocks.

Natalie:

helping

Ricardo:

no

Yichen:

Can you see the building?

Ricardo:

roof

Natalie:

window

Ricardo:

thank you

Yichen:

Anything identifiable?

Ricardo did not answer.

Several minutes later he sent a crop.

The pale shape behind the roof filled most of it.

Natalie:

tower again

Ricardo:

maybe

Yichen:

Which tower?

Ricardo:

schiller park maybe

Natalie:

we did this

Ricardo:

i know

Yichen:

Did we decide?

Natalie:

no

Ricardo:

no

Yichen:

Then okay.

The crop went into PHOTOS.

Nothing on the map moved.

* * *

Two weeks later Ricardo sent another message.

if orchard place is old why is everything in the photo normal

Natalie:

what

Ricardo:

bus reflection

Then:

phone

Then:

everything

Natalie:

because it was 2014

Ricardo:

i know

Yichen:

What are you asking?

Ricardo did not reply immediately.

Then:

not time travel

Natalie:

good

Ricardo:

i never said time travel

Natalie:

you just brought it up

Ricardo:

to say no

Yichen:

Then no.

Ricardo:

thank you

Another message:

thats actually better

Natalie:

how

Ricardo:

because orchard place doesnt have to still be there

Yichen:

It wasn’t.

Ricardo:

yes

Then:

the roads can be later roads on old alignments

Natalie:

can

Ricardo:

some

Yichen:

Which ones?

Ricardo:

working on it

Natalie:

there he goes

* * *

By October 2024, a file called UNRESOLVED sat inside the folder.

The first line read:

exact relationship between historical alignments and 2014 access roads

Below it:

skeleton location

houses

Keller

boarding point — man

woman / driver exchange

exact route between supported segments

The folder had twenty-three files.

* * *

Yichen came to Chicago in November.

They met at the same place near the airport.

Ricardo brought the laptop.

Natalie saw it.

“How many minutes this time?”

“What?”

“Before you open it.”

“I can leave it closed.”

Yichen sat down.

“No one believes that anymore.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“You used to be supportive.”

“No.”

Natalie checked the time on her phone.

Ricardo pointed.

“You’re timing me.”

“I’m checking the time.”

“Same thing.”

Yichen took off her coat.

“That is not the same thing.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“You haven’t changed at all.”

She put her coat over the chair.

“Apparently.”

The laptop stayed closed for thirty-four minutes.

Natalie told them about a new supervisor.

Yichen showed them a photograph of a chair she had found on the curb in Madison and carried six blocks home.

Ricardo asked why.

“It was a good chair.”

“It was garbage.”

“It was beside garbage.”

“That is where garbage lives.”

Natalie said, “Was.”

Yichen looked at her.

Natalie smiled.

Ricardo said, “You’re both getting worse.”

Food arrived.

They ate.

Then Ricardo opened the laptop.

Natalie looked at the time.

“Thirty-four.”

“I hate you.”

* * *

The new map was less dramatic than the old one.

There were fewer lines.

The supported 2014 pieces were thicker.

The uncertain sections were broken.

Blue historical roads sat beneath them.

A few black current roads remained for reference.

Natalie leaned toward the screen.

“What changed?”

Ricardo pointed.

“This one.”

A red broken section had been shortened.

“Why?”

“Doesn’t need to reach the gate anymore.”

“Why not?”

Ricardo opened another image.

A construction plan.

Then an aerial photograph.

Then a road diagram.

He switched between them.

“This access road existed here.”

Yichen said, “When?”

“2014.”

Natalie looked at him.

Ricardo smiled.

“Actually 2014.”

“Source?”

He opened the page.

Natalie read it.

The date was September 2014.

A temporary service connection was marked along the airport edge.

She leaned closer.

“That’s annoying.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“What?”

“It’s good.”

“Say that again.”

“No.”

Yichen took the laptop and moved it closer.

“This part?”

“Yes.”

“And this was September.”

“Yes.”

“Still there in October?”

Ricardo opened an aerial image.

“Probably.”

Yichen looked at him.

He corrected himself.

“Visible in an image dated October.”

Natalie smiled.

Ricardo said, “Don’t.”

Yichen looked at the second image.

A narrow strip of pavement curved behind a fenced area.

It did not match Ricardo’s remembered route exactly.

It did not need to.

Natalie said, “That helps.”

Ricardo sat back.

“Yes.”

Yichen said nothing.

Ricardo looked at her.

“What?”

“It helps.”

He waited.

“That’s it?”

“Yes.”

Natalie said, “He wants a certificate.”

“I don’t.”

Yichen handed the laptop back.

“You found a road.”

Ricardo looked at her.

“A 2014 road.”

“Yes.”

He smiled.

Natalie said, “Don’t encourage him.”

* * *

That road entered the Orchard Place map as solid red.

Not because anyone remembered it.

A note beside it read:

documented access road — Oct 2014

The reconstructed bus route remained broken where it approached.

For several months, the two lines sat close together without touching.

* * *

In January 2025, Natalie sent a screenshot at 7:14 in the morning.

you have this source twice

Ricardo:

which

Natalie:

airport history

Ricardo:

different sites

Natalie:

same text

Ricardo:

no

Natalie sent two screenshots.

The wording was almost identical.

Ricardo:

okay

Yichen:

One source.

Ricardo:

yes

Natalie:

deleting one

Ricardo:

fine

An hour later the folder contained thirty-one files instead of thirty-two.

* * *

In March, Ricardo found a photograph of an airport-edge industrial block from the early 2000s.

He sent it.

Natalie:

and

Ricardo:

houses

Yichen:

Those are warehouses.

Ricardo:

behind

Three small houses were visible beyond the lot.

Natalie enlarged the image.

could be

Ricardo:

thank you

Yichen:

Could be what?

Ricardo:

the kind of transition we remember

Yichen:

Industrial to residential.

Ricardo:

yes

Natalie:

that part is real

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

so

Yichen:

Stop saying so.

Ricardo:

why

Yichen:

Because then you add something.

Natalie:

supported

Ricardo:

both blocked

The photograph went into PHOTOS.

The houses entry remained under UNRESOLVED.

* * *

By summer, Orchard Place was no longer something they introduced when it came up.

Ricardo would send:

OP map updated

Natalie:

what changed

Or:

check OP businesses

Yichen:

Why?

Or Natalie:

OP source has wrong date

Ricardo:

which

No one had decided to shorten the name.

It happened anyway.

* * *

In August, Yichen sent:

When did we start calling it OP?

Ricardo:

you just did

Yichen:

You did yesterday.

Natalie:

he did

Ricardo:

efficient

Yichen:

Okay.

Nothing else came.

* * *

The business folder stayed mostly empty.

There were directories.

Property records.

A few archived storefront photographs.

Most of them explained nothing.

A plumbing company had occupied one building until 2011.

A flooring supplier had moved in 2016.

A repair shop had existed on the wrong side of the airport.

A company with SONS in the name was forty minutes away.

Ricardo sent it anyway.

Natalie:

no

Ricardo:

i know

Yichen:

Then why did you send it?

Ricardo:

emotional support

Yichen:

For whom?

Ricardo:

me

Natalie:

denied

Nothing was added.

* * *

In October, Natalie found an archived trade directory.

The scan quality was bad.

She searched the text.

The search returned nothing.

She tried again without & Sons.

Nothing.

Then:

Keller

There were fourteen results.

Most were people.

One was a law firm.

One was a school employee.

One was an equipment company nowhere near Chicago.

She reached the eleventh result.

Then she sent a screenshot to the group.

No message.

Ricardo replied nine minutes later.

no

Yichen:

What?

Ricardo:

natalie

Natalie:

yes

Ricardo:

where did you get this

Natalie:

trade directory

Ricardo:

year

Natalie:

2013

Yichen:

What am I looking at?

Natalie sent a clearer crop.

A short listing appeared between two other businesses.

KELLER & SONS

Below it:

commercial fixtures / service

Below that:

Des Plaines, Illinois

No street address appeared in the crop.

Nothing came for more than a minute.

Then Yichen:

Address?

Natalie:

not on this page

Ricardo:

still

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

we had the name

Yichen:

We had Keller.

Ricardo:

keller & sons

Yichen:

Later.

There was a pause.

Natalie:

its literally in the 2017 file

Yichen:

Yes.

Natalie:

and the 2022 file

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

and now a 2013 directory

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

so

Yichen:

Don’t.

Natalie sent another message.

still keller

Yichen:

Yes.

Nothing came for several minutes.

Then Ricardo:

commercial fixtures makes sense too

Natalie:

why

Ricardo:

store looked like that

Yichen:

Did it?

Ricardo:

shelves

Natalie:

i remember shelves

Yichen:

Do you remember shelves, or the file?

Natalie did not answer immediately.

Then:

fair

Ricardo:

there were shelves

Yichen:

Okay.

Ricardo:

that okay means no

Yichen:

It means okay.

Natalie:

historic agreement part 2

* * *

Natalie kept searching.

The directory had been assembled from industry listings.

A separate index contained mailing information.

Three days later she sent:

found address maybe

Ricardo:

maybe

Natalie:

different database

Yichen:

Same company?

Natalie:

same phone number

Ricardo:

address

Natalie sent it.

Ricardo opened a map.

The address no longer existed in the same form.

The property had been combined with another parcel.

The building shown in older aerials was gone.

He sent a pin.

Natalie:

how far

Ricardo:

from our route or orchard place

Yichen:

That is a good question.

Ricardo:

route: depends

Natalie:

orchard

Ricardo:

close

Yichen:

How close?

Ricardo sent a distance.

Natalie:

thats close

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

thank you

Yichen:

It is close.

Ricardo:

you make agreement unpleasant

Yichen:

Practice.

* * *

The business had been listed there in 2013.

Another record still showed it in early 2014.

A later database marked it inactive.

The exact closure date was not available.

Ricardo:

so it couldve been there

Natalie:

yes

Yichen:

In October?

Natalie:

couldve

Yichen:

Do we know?

Natalie:

no

Ricardo:

but now we have an actual keller & sons

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

near the area

Yichen:

Yes.

Ricardo:

that existed in 2014

Yichen:

Early 2014.

Ricardo:

close enough

No one replied.

A moment later Ricardo sent:

for now

Yichen:

Better.

* * *

They added the directory listing.

They added the matching phone number.

They added the old parcel.

They did not add the shelves.

* * *

The next time they met, Ricardo had printed the listing.

Natalie took one look at it.

“You printed it.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“I wanted to.”

“That is not a reason.”

“It literally is.”

Yichen took the page from him.

The listing was small.

KELLER & SONS

The letters were ordinary.

No logo.

No photograph.

No storefront.

Yichen looked at it.

Ricardo said, “You can say it.”

“Say what?”

“That it’s weird.”

“It’s a business directory.”

“You know what I mean.”

“Yes.”

“And?”

Yichen put the page down.

“It’s Keller & Sons.”

Ricardo looked at Natalie.

Natalie smiled.

“Take it.”

“I am.”

Yichen said, “That is all I said.”

“I know.”

For once, he did not ask her to say more.

* * *

They opened the old timeline.

The one descended from the 2017 version.

It had changed formats several times.

The current version was cleaner.

Dates and sources appeared in a column on the right.

Confidence markers appeared beside some entries.

The sequence still read:

KELLER & SONS

MAN BOARDS

“NOT YET”

Natalie added a source beside the first line.

2013 trade directory / 2014 business record

Yichen watched.

Ricardo said, “What?”

“Nothing.”

Natalie looked at her.

Yichen pointed at the first line.

“That supports the business.”

“Yes.”

“Not where we saw it.”

“Yes.”

“Or when.”

Natalie said, “Yes.”

Yichen looked at Ricardo.

He nodded.

“Yes.”

She sat back.

Natalie saved the file.

* * *

In November, Ricardo found an older satellite image of the parcel.

The resolution was poor.

A rectangular building sat near the road.

Cars filled part of the lot.

The sign could not be read.

He sent it anyway.

Natalie:

building

Ricardo:

yes

Yichen:

Can you identify it?

Ricardo:

address matches

Yichen:

The company?

Ricardo:

probably

Natalie:

property matches

Ricardo:

thank you

Yichen:

Property.

Ricardo:

yes

The photograph was added.

Its note read:

building at listed parcel — business identity not visible

* * *

By December 2025, the ORCHARD PLACE folder contained fifty-eight files.

The subfolders had changed.

MAPS

SOURCES

2014

BUSINESSES

REMAINING

It had four lines.

exact route

woman / driver

man boarding point

skeleton location

* * *

On December 18, Ricardo updated the working note.

It no longer fit on one page.

Natalie replied:

too long

Ricardo:

you made half of it

Natalie:

still too long

Yichen:

What changed?

Ricardo:

summary

Natalie:

that is not a summary

Ricardo:

fine

An hour later he uploaded another version.

It was shorter.

At the top:

SUPPORTED

- Orchard Place and the pre-airport road network existed.
- Airport development substantially replaced and reorganized the area.
- Multiple later service, industrial and ordinary roads existed around the airport edge.
- Temporary access and construction routing existed in 2014.
- A page uploaded in November 2014 shows a full-size bus using a service road.
- Keller & Sons was listed in the area in records from 2013–14.

Below:

WORKING

- The bus may have used a combination of ordinary streets, temporary construction routing and airport-edge/service roads.
- Some remembered landmarks may belong to different sections that were later remembered as more continuous than they were.

Then:

REMAINING

- Exact route.
- Exact skeleton location.
- Where the man boarded.
- Woman / driver exchange.

Natalie read it.

better

Yichen did not reply.

Ricardo:

yichen

No answer.

Twenty-three minutes later:

Yichen: The first Keller sentence is too broad.

Ricardo:

how

Yichen:

“in the area”

Ricardo:

it was

Yichen:

Which area?

Ricardo:

near orchard / airport

Yichen:

Write the place.

Ricardo:

why

Yichen:

Because “the area” changes depending on what we are talking about.

Natalie:

shes right

Ricardo:

fine

He changed the sentence.

Keller & Sons appears in 2013–14 business records for Des Plaines.

Yichen:

Better.

Ricardo:

anything else

There was no answer for several minutes.

Then:

No.

Ricardo:

finally

Natalie:

dont make her look again

* * *

Later that night, Ricardo sent the note again.

No changes.

Then:

getting shorter

Natalie:

finally

Yichen did not answer until the next morning.

Yes.

The group went quiet.

The folder remained at the top of all three screens.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

By spring 2026, REMAINING still had four lines.

It had had four lines in November.

It had four in December, when Ricardo found another county planning scan with Orchard Place printed in the margin and spent most of an evening enlarging a diagram that turned out to show drainage.

It had four in January, when Natalie located an archived transportation memo and established, with considerable satisfaction, that its date really was its date and, with considerably less satisfaction, that it said nothing they did not already know.

It had four in February.

In March, Yichen sent a message at 1:13 in the morning.

Are we still doing this?

Ricardo was awake.

Apparently.

Natalie replied six minutes later.

Define doing.

No one did.

The folder remained on Ricardo's laptop under the name ORCHARD PLACE. He no longer remembered when he had stopped finding the name strange.

Inside it, the work had become cleaner.

That was the annoying part.

The first maps had been covered with arrows. The later ones had fewer. Streets once joined by confident lines were now connected by dotted ones, then by thinner dotted ones, then sometimes by nothing at all. A route Ricardo had once been able to describe in three uninterrupted sentences now required qualifications.

They had definitely been here.

They had probably been here.

This would fit.

This would also fit.

Nothing proved either.

He learned to leave space between the pieces.

Natalie's timeline improved in the same direction. The early versions had been rows of times with events pressed neatly beside them. The new one contained more blank cells. She had separated device time from upload time, upload time from capture time, remembered sequence from recorded sequence, the date a page had been published from the date of the photograph on it.

Sometimes the best thing she added was a note explaining why nothing could be added.

Yichen's document got shorter.

That surprised Ricardo most.

It had once been the messiest of the three: observations about the driver, the woman, the man who boarded, the way people had looked at one another, the possibility that somebody knew more than they said, the possibility that somebody thought somebody else knew more than they said.

Now entire paragraphs had been reduced to sentences.

The man boarded.

The woman said, Not yet.

Later, the driver asked, You sure?

The bus stopped.

* * *

In April, Ricardo opened the map again.

He had not planned to. He was looking for a tax document and clicked the wrong folder.

The most recent route reconstruction filled the screen.

He had made it three weeks earlier and then left it alone.

At first glance, it looked unfinished.

At second glance, it looked worse.

The route began normally enough. Solid line. A turn. Another solid line. A section supported by the photograph they had argued over for years. Another stretch supported less directly, marked differently. Then the line broke.

It resumed farther north.

Broke again.

Reappeared.

Near Orchard Place, the page became crowded with annotations but the route itself did not become more certain. There were roads that existed. Service access that existed. A bus documented in a place buses could use. Keller & Sons where Keller & Sons had in fact been. A laundromat that might have been theirs and might have been one of several things remembered into one.

Evidence everywhere.

A route nowhere.

Ricardo zoomed out.

The gaps became smaller.

That used to make him feel better.

Now he zoomed back in.

He stared at the longest one.

Years earlier he would have crossed it.

He knew exactly how.

There was a road that made sense. The timing could be made to fit if one part of the memory was moved a little. The later turn would then align with Orchard Place. The man could have boarded near the beginning of it. Keller would appear in approximately the right relationship to the stop.

It was not even a bad reconstruction.

That was the problem.

He moved the cursor to the line tool.

Then he closed the file.

* * *

Yichen came down from Madison in May.

She had been planning to come to Chicago anyway, although later none of them could remember what the original reason had been. Natalie said it involved a person. Yichen said it involved two errands and neither of them was a person. Ricardo remembered something about a package.

This disagreement did not become a document.

They arranged dinner for Saturday.

Ricardo got there second.

Natalie was already at the table with water in front of her and her phone face down beside the napkin holder. She looked up when he approached, glanced automatically at the bag over his shoulder, and said nothing about it.

"You brought it."

"I bring my laptop everywhere."

"You didn't used to."

"I also didn't used to have a laptop worth stealing."

"That does not explain why you bring it everywhere."

"It explains why I'm emotionally attached to it."

Natalie moved her water away from the edge of the table.

"You spill things."

"I have spilled one thing near you."

"You spilled coffee on my notes."

"In 2018."

"It was tea."

Ricardo sat down.

"That helps my case."

Yichen arrived five minutes later and did not apologize because she was not late.

She put her coat over the back of the empty chair, looked at both of them, and said, "Why do you look like you started without me?"

"We were discussing 2018," Natalie said.

"That sounds dangerous."

"It was tea," Ricardo said.

Yichen sat down.

"I have no idea what that means."

Neither of them explained.

The laptop stayed in Ricardo's bag.

They ordered.

Natalie told them about somebody at work who had scheduled a meeting to decide whether another meeting was necessary. Ricardo said this was how institutions reproduced. Yichen said he had been waiting years to use that sentence.

Ricardo denied it.

They talked about Madison.

Yichen had moved apartments again, although not recently enough for either of them to have a good excuse for not knowing. Her new place was quieter. The heating made a clicking noise at night. The grocery store was farther away but the walk was better. She had a neighbor with a dog that reacted violently to delivery scooters and ignored thunderstorms.

Natalie asked the dog's name.

Yichen told her.

Ricardo forgot it within thirty seconds.

Their food arrived.

For a while they discussed whether a dish had changed or whether Ricardo had simply remembered it incorrectly.

"Careful," Natalie said.

He looked at her.

She was smiling.

"No," Ricardo said. "We are not doing provenance on noodles."

"You're the one claiming a historical recipe change."

"I said it used to be spicier."

"What year?"

"Stop."

"Source?"

"My mouth."

"Unreliable."

Yichen took another bite.

"It is less spicy."

Ricardo pointed at her.

"Independent corroboration."

"You both ordered the same thing."

"Still independent."

"No."

He put his hand down.

They moved on.

The bag stayed on the floor beside his chair.

They finished most of the food before anyone mentioned the bus.

It was Yichen who did, though only indirectly.

She had been telling Natalie about a building renovation near her apartment. Something about the entrance being moved during construction. Ricardo was half listening while trying to separate two containers that had arrived stuck together.

Yichen said, "They put up a temporary sign, but the sign points to the old door."

"That seems useful," Ricardo said.

"It is if your goal is to make everyone walk around the building once."

Natalie laughed.

Then she looked at Ricardo.

"Did you ever fix the northern gap?"

He stopped pulling at the containers.

"No."

The conversation paused.

Not heavily.

Just enough.

Yichen looked down at the bag.

Ricardo followed her eyes.

"Oh," he said.

Natalie took a drink of water.

"You don't have to."

"I know."

He reached down anyway.

The laptop came out.

He moved two plates aside and set it between them.

No one leaned toward it.

Ricardo opened ORCHARD PLACE.

The folder had not been opened in twelve days.

He knew because the system told him.

Inside were the same files, arranged by a naming scheme that had survived several computers and none of their original personalities.

He opened the map.

Natalie looked at it first.

Yichen turned her chair slightly.

Ricardo zoomed to the northern section.

"This is where it is now."

Natalie studied the legend.

"You changed the line types."

"Again."

"What does this one mean?"

"Direct support."

"And this?"

"Consistent with the evidence."

"That is not the same as inferred?"

"Not anymore."

Yichen looked at him.

"What's the difference?"

Ricardo pointed.

"Inferred means I had to add something that isn't independently there. 'Consistent' means it could happen without contradicting anything we have, but I'm not saying it did."

"That sounds like a distinction you invented after being yelled at."

"It is a distinction I invented after constructive peer review."

"You were yelled at," Natalie said.

"I was."

He moved the map.

The old path fragmented across the screen.

"This part is solid."

He traced it with the cursor.

"Not literally solid. The line is solid."

"We understand diagrams," Natalie said.

"I'm managing expectations."

He continued.

"This section is probably right. There are two ways out of it that work. Then here--"

The cursor entered blank space.

He stopped.

Natalie looked at him.

"What happened there?"

"I don't know."

"The next supported point is here."

He moved the cursor.

The gap remained behind it.

* * *

The man's boarding point had survived every version of the list.

For several years Ricardo had believed it would be one of the easiest items to remove. They remembered the stop. They remembered the man. They remembered enough of what came before and after.

That had once seemed like plenty.

Now the screen showed two shaded sections.

Natalie pointed to the first.

"This is still the stronger one?"

"Only if Keller matters."

"And if it doesn't?"

"They're close."

"How close?"

"Not enough to pick one."

Yichen looked at the second section.

"Why did we ever think we knew this?"

Ricardo glanced at her.

"We didn't."

"You did."

"I thought I did."

"That's different?"

"Yes."

Yichen nodded.

"Okay."

Ricardo opened a note attached to the first section.

Keller was there.

Not as an answer.

As a fact.

The business had existed. The location was real. Parts of their remembered geography fit around it surprisingly well. If the man had boarded in one particular stretch, the sequence became elegant.

Ricardo had once liked elegant sequences.

Now he looked at the note and said, "This one has Keller."

Natalie said, "Anything independent?"

"No."

"Then Keller makes it attractive."

"Yes."

"Not more supported."

"No."

He closed the note.

Neither section disappeared.

* * *

The woman and the driver had their own file.

Yichen groaned when Ricardo opened it.

"Why?"

"This is your department," he said.

"I don't have a department."

"You absolutely have a department."

"We agreed that was the problem."

"We agreed Owen was the problem."

"Owen named the problem."

Natalie looked between them.

"I think technically we named the problem by accepting the labels."

Ricardo looked at her.

"Whose department is that sentence?"

"Mine."

Yichen leaned back.

The file was mostly transcript now.

Not a real transcript. They had never possessed one. It was a reconstruction made from the portions all three agreed had been said, with uncertain words marked and later additions separated.

Near the middle were two lines.

Not yet.

Farther down:

You sure?

Natalie looked at Yichen.

"So what do you think she meant?"

Yichen did not answer immediately.

She looked at the screen.

"She said, 'Not yet.'"

Natalie waited.

"He asked if she was sure."

"That's what you think it meant?"

"That's what we have."

Natalie looked back at the file.

Yichen picked up her fork.

Ricardo closed it.

* * *

The skeleton took less time.

For years the photograph had seemed almost rude in its specificity.

It had an image.

It had metadata.

It had a minute.

10:51.

Among all the remembered turns, uncertain streets, repeated phrases, and stories retold too many times, 10:51 had remained stubbornly digital.

The message had gone out at 10:52.

Ricardo had sent it.

That part was not memory.

Natalie had checked it enough times to make checking it again unnecessary.

The photograph appeared on the screen.

A window.

The pale shape behind it.

Something that, once named, never looked like anything else.

Yichen stared at it for a second.

"I still hate this picture."

"You didn't used to," Ricardo said.

"I was sixteen."

"That's not an explanation."

"It's enough of one."

Natalie enlarged the file information panel.

10:51.

She did not touch anything else.

Ricardo said, "No location."

"No location," Natalie said.

"We know approximately where we were."

"We know what we thought came before it and what we thought came after it."

"That sounded aggressive."

"It was precise."

"Which is your aggressive."

Natalie ignored him.

Yichen looked from the photograph to the map behind it.

"Can it be placed in either of those route versions?"

Ricardo considered the question.

"Yes."

"Both?"

"Yes."

"So it doesn't choose."

"No."

He minimized the image.

That was all.

No one suggested image enhancement.

No one searched property photographs.

No one reopened the years in which Ricardo had compared window spacing, rooflines, trees, setbacks, siding, utility poles, and the shape of upper floors until houses in that part of Illinois had begun to look like one repeating building.

The skeleton remained where it had been for twelve years.

At 10:51.

In a window.

Somewhere.

* * *

Ricardo returned to the main document.

Near the bottom was the section Natalie had renamed REMAINING months earlier.

Four lines.

Exact route

Woman / driver

Man boarding point

Skeleton location

Nothing had changed.

Yichen read them.

"So."

Ricardo scrolled up.

Above the list was SUPPORTED.

It was long.

Longer than he remembered.

Orchard Place.

The road network.

The service road.

Keller & Sons.

The uploaded page.

Dates that actually belonged to pages.

Dates that did not belong to photographs.

The bus where a bus could be.

The remembered city where the city had, in fact, been.

All of it real.

All of it sitting beside four lines that refused to become smaller.

Ricardo scrolled down again.

For some reason, he thought about the earliest map.

Not the earliest file. The real one.

Paper.

A pen.

Three people still on the same bus, trying to decide which way they had turned.

He could not remember who had drawn the first line.

For years he had assumed it was him.

He no longer knew why.

The screen stayed on REMAINING.

Ricardo rested his hands beside the keyboard.

"I think that's enough."

Natalie turned to him.

"Enough for what?"

"For me."

No one answered.

The restaurant continued around them.

A plate touched a table somewhere behind Ricardo. Somebody near the front laughed too loudly and then laughed again because they had laughed too loudly. A server carried a stack of bowls past their table.

Natalie looked at the screen.

Her eyes moved upward.

Not far.

Ricardo did not follow them.

She reached toward the trackpad.

Her index finger stopped above it.

Yichen looked at Natalie's hand.

Natalie's eyes were still on the timeline.

10:28 sat in one row.

Farther down, 10:51 remained where it had always been.

Natalie did not touch the trackpad.

After a moment, she took her hand back.

Yichen looked at her face.

Then at the screen.

Then she reached for her water.

Ricardo closed the laptop.

* * *

They ordered dessert.

Ricardo did not want dessert, then ate part of Natalie's.

"You said you didn't want any."

"I said I didn't want to order one."

"That is worse."

"It is financially efficient."

"For you."

"Yes."

Yichen had ordered her own and moved it slightly farther from him.

Ricardo noticed.

"I'm not taking yours."

"You said that with no credibility."

"I respect boundaries."

"You just stole hers."

"Natalie and I have a different treaty."

Natalie moved her plate to the other side.

"The treaty has been suspended."

Ricardo looked around the table.

"This is hostile."

No one opened the laptop again.

The bag was back on the floor.

A few minutes later Natalie was telling Yichen about a train delay from the previous week, not because the delay was interesting but because the person standing beside her had spent forty minutes explaining an alternative route that would have taken longer than waiting.

Ricardo said the man sounded admirable.

Natalie said the man sounded like him.

"I would have checked the travel time."

"That would not have stopped you from explaining it."

"It would have improved the explanation."

Yichen said, "That is exactly what she means."

Ricardo finished the rest of the dessert he had not ordered.

They talked about whether Yichen was staying through Sunday.

She was.

Natalie asked if she wanted coffee the next morning.

Yichen said maybe, depending on when she woke up.

Ricardo said this was not how scheduling worked.

Yichen said it was exactly how weekends worked.

Someone dropped a spoon in the kitchen.

No one turned around.

* * *

When the bill came, Ricardo reached for it and Natalie took it first.

"You paid last time," she said.

"When was last time?"

"December."

"I don't remember December."

"I do."

"That sentence has historically caused problems."

Natalie looked at him.

Ricardo raised both hands.

"Sorry."

Yichen laughed.

Natalie tried not to.

The check stayed with her.

They split it anyway.

Ricardo calculated his share incorrectly.

Natalie corrected him.

He recalculated and got a different wrong number.

Yichen took his phone, entered the amount, and handed it back.

"Humiliating," Ricardo said.

"You made a map for twelve years."

"That is geometry."

"That was subtraction."

"Exactly."

Outside, the air was cooler than it had looked through the restaurant window.

Yichen stopped just beyond the door to put on her coat. Ricardo moved aside so a couple could pass. Natalie checked something on her phone.

"Where did you park?" Yichen asked.

Ricardo pointed.

"That way."

Natalie looked up.

"You said you parked behind the building."

"I did."

"That is not behind the building."

"It is from where I approached."

"Buildings do not have observer-dependent backs."

"They absolutely do."

"No."

Yichen zipped her coat.

"You two can solve this without me."

"We can't," Ricardo said.

"Good night."

"You're leaving?"

"My ride is two blocks away."

Natalie slipped her phone into her pocket.

"I'll walk with you."

Ricardo adjusted the strap of his bag.

"Traitor."

"You are parked in the other direction."

"Allegedly."

Yichen started walking.

Natalie followed, then turned.

"Tomorrow?"

Ricardo shrugged.

"Text me."

"That means no," Yichen said.

"It means text me."

"It means he'll answer at eleven thirty," Natalie said.

"Eleven twenty."

"You don't know that."

"No."

He smiled.

"I don't."

Natalie looked at him for half a second longer than necessary.

Then she turned and caught up with Yichen.

Ricardo watched them reach the corner.

Yichen said something.

Natalie looked back once, although Ricardo could not hear what they were talking about.

He lifted a hand.

She lifted hers.

Then the light changed and they crossed.

Ricardo turned the other way.

He had almost reached the next block when his phone buzzed.

A message from Yichen.

Natalie forgot her leftovers.

Ricardo stopped.

He looked down at the takeout box in his hand.

For several seconds he could not remember picking it up.

He typed:

I have them.

Three dots appeared.

Disappeared.

Appeared again.

Of course you do.

Ricardo put the phone away.

At the corner, he waited for the signal.

The laptop rested against his side inside the bag.

The folder was still there.

So were the four lines.

The signal changed.

Ricardo crossed the street.

EPILOGUE

The bus was late by three minutes.

The girl by the window checked twice.

Not because three minutes mattered, but because the display above the shelter had changed from 2 MIN to DUE and then stayed that way long enough for her to wonder whether DUE was a prediction or a category.

When the bus finally came, the boy beside her put his phone away.

“See?”

“You said it was cancelled.”

“I said maybe.”

“You said definitely.”

“I said probably definitely.”

“That is not a thing.”

“It got here.”

“That does not make you right.”

“It makes being wrong irrelevant.”

The doors opened.

They boarded.

There were eleven people already inside.

An older man near the front.

A woman with grocery bags.

Someone asleep against the window.

Three passengers sitting farther back together but not quite as a group: a man on the aisle, a woman beside him, another woman across from them with her coat folded over her lap.

The girl and the boy took the seats behind them.

Outside, Chicago moved normally.

A pharmacy.

Two low apartment buildings.

A fenced lot.

A row of parked cars under trees that had not yet decided whether the season was over.

The girl opened the route map on her phone.

She did this whenever she was going somewhere unfamiliar.

The boy saw.

“You know we’re on the bus, right?”

“That is why I’m looking at the bus route.”

“The bus knows the bus route.”

“The bus is not a person.”

“That feels discriminatory.”

She ignored him.

The blue dot moved.

* * *

The man in the aisle seat looked up.

He had been reading something on his phone.

At an intersection, the bus turned.

He looked through the windshield.

Then through the window to his left.

The movement was small enough that the girl behind him noticed it only because she had been looking past his shoulder at the street.

He did not say anything.

A few seconds later, he looked back down at his phone.

The girl returned to the map.

The blue dot had moved off the line.

She waited.

GPS did that sometimes.

It drifted onto parallel streets, crossed buildings, entered rivers, corrected itself.

The bus continued.

The dot did not correct itself.

She zoomed in.

“What?” the boy asked.

“Nothing.”

“Then why did you do that?”

“Do what?”

“That face.”

“What face?”

“The map face.”

“There is no map face.”

“There absolutely is.”

She held the phone closer.

The route line was one block east.

The bus was moving north.

Or at least the dot was.

She looked outside.

A small repair shop passed on the right.

Then a parking lot.

Then a street sign she did not read in time.

She turned in her seat to look back through the rear window, but the sign was gone.

“What are you doing?”

“I missed the street.”

“We’re still on one.”

“The name.”

“Why?”

She looked at him.

“Because I want to know where we are.”

He pointed at her phone.

“You have a map.”

“That’s the problem.”

He leaned over.

The blue dot continued north.

The route continued somewhere else.

“Oh.”

“Yeah.”

“It’s probably a detour.”

“There wasn’t an alert.”

“They don’t always put alerts.”

“Yes, they do.”

“No, they don’t.”

“You don’t even take this bus.”

“Neither do you.”

“That’s why I checked.”

He looked outside.

Nothing looked wrong.

That seemed to bother him more than if something had.

* * *

The woman beside the aisle passenger opened her phone.

She looked at the screen.

Locked it.

Several seconds passed.

She opened it again.

The girl noticed because the light reflected briefly in the window.

The woman looked at the upper corner of the screen.

Then at the front of the bus.

Then she put the phone face down on her knee.

She did not speak to the man beside her.

The other woman, across the aisle, was looking out the opposite window.

The three of them had not reacted to the turn together.

The girl had assumed they knew one another.

Now she was less sure.

“You think they noticed?” she whispered.

The boy followed her eyes.

“The people in front?”

“Yeah.”

“The guy did.”

“You saw?”

“No.”

“I did.”

“Then why are you asking me?”

“I’m asking if you think he noticed.”

“What else would he be looking at?”

“I don’t know.”

“Maybe a building.”

“What building?”

“I don’t know. A building-shaped building.”

She looked at the man again.

He had put his phone away.

His hands rested loosely on his knees.

The woman beside him still had hers face down.

None of them were talking.

The girl wondered if silence meant they had not noticed.

Then she wondered why she thought people who noticed something were supposed to talk about it.

* * *

The bus crossed another intersection.

No stop announcement played.

The girl waited for one.

Nothing.

She checked the display at the front.

It showed the route number.

No destination.

The boy saw her looking.

“That happens.”

“Does it?”

“Yes.”

“How do you know?”

“I’ve been on buses.”

“Not this one.”

“Buses share qualities.”

“That is not evidence.”

He smiled.

“Now you have a face for that too.”

She looked back at the map.

The blue dot jumped half a block.

Then stopped.

Then moved again.

The route line was farther away now.

She took a screenshot.

The boy watched.

“Why?”

“Because.”

“Because what?”

“So I have it.”

“You have the app.”

“I have the screenshot.”

“Of the app.”

“Yes.”

He shook his head.

“You’re weird.”

She saved it anyway.

* * *

At the next light, the bus stopped.

The doors did not open.

There was no stop there.

A car crossed in front of them.

The light was green.

The driver remained still for two or three seconds after the car passed.

Then the bus moved.

Across the aisle, the other woman finally looked toward the front.

The girl saw the driver’s eyes in the mirror.

The driver looked back.

Not at the whole bus.

At the woman.

The woman held the look for a moment.

Then turned to the window.

Nothing passed between them that the girl could hear.

The bus continued.

The boy leaned closer.

“Okay.”

“What?”

“That was weird.”

“What was?”

“The driver.”

“What did he do?”

“You saw.”

“I saw him look in the mirror.”

“No, before that.”

“What before that?”

“He stopped.”

“There was a car.”

“The light was green.”

“He might’ve been letting it go.”

“Then why did he look back?”

“I don’t know.”

The boy lowered his voice.

“Maybe she knows him.”

The girl looked at the woman across the aisle.

She had not moved.

“Why would that matter?”

“Maybe he was checking something.”

“What?”

“I don’t know.”

“That’s not an explanation.”

“It’s more of one than you have.”

“I’m not trying to explain it.”

“You took a screenshot.”

“That’s not explaining.”

“It’s pre-explaining.”

She almost laughed.

Then the bus turned again.

This time both of them stopped talking.

* * *

The man in the aisle seat looked out the window.

The woman beside him did not.

The woman across from them did.

No one said anything.

The bus entered a narrower road.

There were trees closer to the curb here.

A warehouse.

A chain-link fence.

A loading entrance with no visible sign.

The girl zoomed farther out.

The blue dot had frozen.

“It stopped.”

“What stopped?”

“The location.”

The boy looked.

“Signal.”

“Maybe.”

He opened his own map.

His blue dot was in the same place.

“Mine too.”

“That’s not good.”

“Why?”

“Because then it’s not my phone.”

“That could be good.”

“How?”

“Two phones are less likely to be broken.”

“That is exactly why it’s worse.”

He refreshed.

Nothing changed.

The bus kept moving.

The dot did not.

* * *

The girl looked toward the three passengers in front of them again.

The man had noticed the road.

The woman beside him had checked the time.

The woman across the aisle had watched the driver.

She did not know any of that for certain.

She knew only what she had seen them do.

She began arranging it anyway.

The man looked up when they turned.

The first woman checked her phone twice.

The second woman watched the mirror.

Maybe they had been watching for this.

The thought arrived fully formed.

She distrusted it immediately.

Then kept it.

* * *

The boy leaned forward.

“Excuse me.”

None of the three turned at first.

He tried again.

“Sorry.”

The man in the aisle seat looked back.

Up close, he was younger than the girl had assumed.

Mid-twenties, maybe.

“What?” he said.

The boy hesitated.

The girl almost answered for him.

Instead she asked, “Do you know where we are?”

The man looked at her.

Then at the boy.

Then toward the front of the bus.

“No.”

That was all.

The girl waited.

She had expected something after it.

A joke.

A reassurance.

A guess.

He turned back around.

The boy looked at her.

She looked at him.

“That was useful,” he whispered.

“At least he answered.”

“He could’ve said more.”

“Like what?”

“I don’t know.”

She looked at the back of the man’s head.

“Exactly.”

* * *

A minute later, the woman beside him spoke.

Not to the girl.

To the man.

“Ricardo.”

He turned slightly.

She said nothing else.

The girl waited.

Ricardo waited too.

Then the woman looked toward the windshield.

He followed her eyes.

The girl could not tell whether the name had been a warning, a question, or simply a way of getting his attention.

Ricardo glanced at the other woman.

She was still looking at the driver.

“Yichen,” he said.

The other woman turned.

The girl now knew two names.

She did not know the first woman’s.

The boy whispered, “They definitely know something.”

“You don’t know that.”

“They’re doing names.”

“What does that mean?”

“People do names when something is happening.”

“That might be the stupidest thing you’ve said today.”

“Not even close.”

The first woman heard them.

The girl could tell because the corner of her mouth moved.

She still did not turn around.

* * *

The bus slowed.

No stop.

No announcement.

A building appeared ahead on the right.

Brick.

Two floors.

Upper windows reflecting sky.

The girl looked at it because there was nothing else to look at.

For a moment she thought someone was standing behind one of the windows.

Then the bus moved past.

She twisted in her seat.

“What?” the boy asked.

“Nothing.”

“You keep saying that.”

“I thought I saw somebody.”

“Where?”

“In the window.”

“What window?”

“That building.”

He looked back too late.

“What kind of person?”

“I don’t know.”

“Like a worker?”

“I said I don’t know.”

“Could’ve been a mannequin.”

“Why would there be a mannequin?”

“Why would there be a person?”

She turned forward.

The building was gone.

She opened the camera roll.

There was no photograph.

She had not taken one.

For reasons she could not explain, this felt like an error.

* * *

The boy opened his messages.

bus is doing something weird lol

He sent it to someone.

The girl saw.

“Why did you write ‘lol’?”

“Because it’s not an emergency.”

“You don’t know that.”

“If it becomes one I’ll remove the lol.”

“That is not how messages work.”

He typed another line.

we’re off route

Then:

driver maybe lost

The girl said, “You don’t know that.”

He looked at her.

“What?”

“The driver.”

“I said maybe.”

“You’re telling people he’s lost.”

“I said maybe lost.”

“That becomes ‘driver lost’ in five minutes.”

“Who’s going to care?”

The message showed as read.

A reply came.

where r u

The boy looked at the frozen map.

He typed:

idk somewhere north

The girl watched him send it.

She wondered whether somewhere north was true.

It was probably true.

Probably.

* * *

At the front, the older man asked the driver something.

The girl could not hear the question.

The driver answered.

The older man sat back down.

“What did he say?” the boy whispered.

“How would I know?”

“Could ask.”

“You ask.”

“You’re closer.”

“You’re literally beside me.”

The woman with grocery bags looked toward them.

They stopped.

For thirty seconds, no one spoke.

Then the bus made another turn.

The girl felt the direction more than she saw it.

She opened the compass on her phone.

The boy laughed.

“What?”

“You have a compass?”

“It comes with the phone.”

“I know. I mean why are you using it?”

“To see which way we’re going.”

“We’re on a bus, not a ship.”

“Northwest.”

“What?”

“We’re going northwest.”

“You said we were going north.”

“We were.”

“When?”

“Before.”

“Before which turn?”

She looked at him.

“The second one.”

“What second one?”

“The one after the road with the repair place.”

He frowned.

“That wasn’t the second turn.”

“Yes, it was.”

“No, there was one before the repair place.”

“No.”

“Yes.”

“You were on your phone.”

“I looked up.”

“When?”

“At the gas station.”

“There wasn’t a gas station.”

He stared at her.

“Yes, there was.”

“Where?”

“On the corner.”

“What color?”

“What?”

“The sign.”

“I don’t know.”

“You would if you saw it.”

“That is not how seeing works.”

“There was no gas station.”

“There was.”

The girl thought back.

Parking lot.

Repair shop.

Trees.

An intersection.

Maybe a sign.

She could now almost see the gas station.

That bothered her.

“Fine,” she said. “Maybe.”

The boy looked satisfied.

She hated that more.

* * *

The three passengers in front still had not compared anything.

That became stranger with time.

Ricardo had seen the road.

The first woman had checked her phone again.

Yichen had watched the driver twice more.

They could have turned toward one another.

They could have whispered.

They could have asked questions.

They did none of it.

Once, Ricardo and Yichen looked at each other.

Only briefly.

Yichen shook her head.

Or perhaps she adjusted her hair.

The girl was not sure.

* * *

The map began working again.

The blue dot reappeared.

It placed them almost a mile from where the girl expected.

She showed the boy.

He opened his.

Same place.

“See?”

“That doesn’t tell us how we got here.”

“It tells us where we are.”

“Those are different.”

He stared at the screen.

The bus was approaching a road she recognized from the route map.

“If it turns here-”

It did.

The girl stopped speaking.

The blue dot moved toward the blue route line.

Thirty seconds later, the two met.

The bus continued.

The next stop announcement played normally.

A street name.

Then another.

The display at the front showed the destination again.

The boy looked around.

“That’s it?”

The girl checked the map.

They were exactly where they were supposed to be.

Or somewhere that could become exactly where they were supposed to be if she stopped asking how they had arrived there.

The older man got off two stops later.

The woman with grocery bags followed after him.

No one appeared concerned.

The sleeping passenger woke briefly, looked outside, and went back to sleep.

* * *

“Maybe it was a detour,” the boy said.

“There was no alert.”

“You keep saying that.”

“Because there wasn’t.”

“Could’ve been temporary.”

“Then why did the map freeze?”

“Bad signal.”

“Both phones?”

“Yes.”

“At the same time?”

“That happens.”

“Why did the driver stop at the green light?”

“Car.”

“And look back?”

He shrugged.

“Maybe he knew her.”

The girl looked at Yichen.

Yichen was speaking quietly to Ricardo now.

Too quietly to hear.

The first woman had taken her phone out again.

The girl realized she still did not know her name.

“Maybe they’re transit people.”

The boy looked at her.

“What?”

“The three of them.”

“Why?”

“They noticed.”

“So did we.”

“They noticed before us.”

“How do you know?”

She opened her mouth.

Closed it.

Because Ricardo had looked up.

Because the first woman had checked the time.

Because Yichen had watched the driver.

The sequence felt clean.

Cleaner than the ride had.

“I saw them,” she said.

“All three?”

“Yes.”

“When?”

She tried to place it.

Ricardo first.

Then-

No.

Had Yichen looked toward the mirror before the first woman checked the phone?

The woman had opened it twice.

Maybe Yichen had turned before that.

The girl replayed the first few minutes.

A turn.

Ricardo.

A reflection in the window.

A phone screen.

The driver.

Yichen.

Or Yichen, then the phone.

She locked her phone.

“I don’t know.”

The boy smiled.

“Finally.”

“Shut up.”

* * *

Their stop came first.

The girl stood.

The boy followed.

As they moved toward the rear doors, she looked at the three passengers one last time.

Ricardo was saying something she could not hear.

The unnamed woman looked annoyed.

Yichen laughed.

They looked ordinary.

That was the part she would remember most clearly.

The doors opened.

She stepped onto the sidewalk.

The boy came after her.

The bus pulled away.

For a few seconds, they watched it go.

Then he said, “You took the screenshot, right?”

She opened her phone.

“Yes.”

“Send it.”

“Why?”

“So I have it.”

She looked at him.

“You made fun of me for taking it.”

“I changed my mind.”

She sent it.

He opened the image.

The blue dot sat off the route.

A timestamp appeared at the top.

He zoomed in.

“What time did we turn?”

“I don’t know.”

“You checked.”

“I checked the route, not the time.”

“Was it before this?”

“Obviously.”

“How long before?”

She thought.

“Maybe five minutes.”

“I thought it was like two.”

“No.”

“You sure?”

She looked at the screenshot again.

The timestamp made the rest of the ride feel less certain.

“Pretty sure.”

He typed something into his messages.

“What are you writing?”

“My friend asked what happened.”

“What are you telling him?”

“That the bus went off route for like ten minutes.”

“It was longer than ten.”

“How long?”

“I don’t know.”

He looked at her.

“Twelve?”

“Maybe.”

He typed.

She watched his thumbs.

bus randomly went off route for like 12 min

He paused.

Then added:

three people on it acted like they knew what was happening

The girl frowned.

“They didn’t.”

“They definitely did.”

“They didn’t say anything.”

“That’s why.”

“That makes no sense.”

He sent the message.

The girl looked back down the street.

The bus was gone.

* * *

The screenshot would remain.

The frozen blue dot would remain.

The timestamp would remain.

Neither would show the turn.

Neither would show the green light.

Neither would show the driver looking in the mirror.

The girl by the window would later remember that Yichen was the first of the three to look up.